

BENEDICT SPINOZA

A Monograph

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Translated from the Danish

Benedict Spinoza. En Monographie. Kjøbenhavn: P. G. Philipsens Forlag, 1857

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Preface

The presentation of the Spinozist philosophy which I have given in this work is intended [1] to begin a series of monographs which, while each of them forms a whole by itself, shall at the same time, taken together, give a survey of the whole history of philosophy. I have not wished to attempt to treat that history with equal thoroughness in its entire connection; I believe that the powers of a single person are insufficient for such a work, when it is to be grounded on a real study of the sources, on a reliable autopsy; at least I feel that my own powers would be. I also assume that at the present moment, after the many attempts that have been made in this direction in the last 30 years, with greater and lesser skill and success, it would be less needed, and that what matters now is rather, through a new and careful treatment of the individual main points, to procure a more reliable material for a renewed comprehensive treatment of the whole subject. A fragmentary treatment which nevertheless, as from the commanding heights, gives an overview of the whole domain will perhaps also, in that it concentrates the gaze on what is essential, on the historically unfolded fundamental forms of thought, which are not something merely past, belonging to memory and to learned research, but something that within its limit is constantly justified and abiding, that retains its significance for all times, and in that it presents the systems of the individual thinkers in such detail that [2] a deeper insight can be opened into their inner mainsprings, so that they are seen as the unfolding of a *living* thought, be better fitted than the connected presentation to pave the way, not only for a more thorough understanding, but also, through it, in some, for some interest in a subject to which the mood and striving of the moment are not favorable. No one who has made philosophy the occupation of his life can well have escaped doubt and despondency at seeing the science which a few decades ago was the object of an enthusiastic, hopeful study become, through the reaction of disappointment, an object of indifference, and almost hidden beneath alien, often idea-less interests. But as the self-reflection of the human spirit, philosophy is its inalienable possession, which, once won, will never be given up; it is like those rivers which over a stretch of their course disappear under the earth, but only to come into view again, mightier and richer

after their union with invisible springs.

In making it my task, through a fragmentary presentation of the history of philosophy, to give a survey of it in its whole extent, my choice has had to fall on those systems which mark high points, from which there opens at once a view back over a longer, completed development, and forward over a new series, proceeding from the system presented or substantially influenced by it. With this consideration *this* coincides: to select such systems as by their principle and direction represent main forms of human thought; for only such stand in that relation to past and posterity. Greek philosophy will be represented by *Plato*, *Aristotle* and *Plotinus*, the Renaissance by the *Platonic Academy in Florence* and *Giordano Bruno*; modern philosophy, in its one line of development by *Bacon* and the *Système de la nature*, in its other by *Spinoza* and *Leibnitz*, and at its last [3] stage of development by *Kant* and *Hegel*. By means of introductions and concluding essays to the individual presentations the connection between the fragmentary parts will be established.

The complete justification of the choice of the representative systems must be given by the presentation of them itself. Yet I must here, briefly, and more by way of hint than of elaboration, set out the conception of the course of the history of philosophy that underlies the choice, and this all the more since I begin with one of the systems in the middle of the series, so that in the presentation of it there will be no natural place for such a development.

In my view the whole history of philosophy, from its first beginning until our own day, divides into only *two* great, *completed* periods: Greek philosophy and that of modern times. They are separated by a great interval; perhaps a similar one will come to lie between the philosophy of our time and that of the future, which will rest on a richer development of the individual sciences, especially the natural sciences. *Greek* philosophy I regard as the beginning of philosophy; for the Orient knew only the infinity of fantasy, not that of thought. The philosophical work of Greece was, with the nature-life of the Orient as its presupposition, to discover the *idea*, to grasp the universe in intuition as the infinite, living, harmonious *work of art*, which received its true reality through form, the idea, the eternally existing plastic thought. The thought of *beauty* was the fundamental thought of Greece; it governed Greek thought as it governed Greek life, life in the state and the moral life of the individual. The dissolution of Greek thought is grounded in the inner contradiction in beauty's *immediate* union of its elements, form and material, in the impossibility of making the material, matter, be wholly absorbed in form, of making "the non-being" vanish over against being, which has all reality in itself but constantly

needs the material in order to realize this reality. It is this inner contradiction of which Greek thought after Aristotle becomes conscious and which it vainly seeks to resolve within its own domain, until in Neoplatonism it raises itself above its foundation, nature, [4] in order to find in a higher region a reconciliation which, given its peculiar character, it could not find there, but carries the contradiction with it over into the new element, and, in the service of a new spirit, exhausts its last strength in a fruitless attempt. For this development the natural representatives are to be sought in *Plato*, who gathers up in himself the whole older Greek philosophy, first utters the fundamental thought of Greece, and first draws the universe under the dominion of the idea; — in *Aristotle*, who determines the last genuinely Greek formula for the unity of form and matter, who by means of it supplements Plato, who, while Alexander subjugates a world for Greece, wins the riches of a world for Greek thought, and with them gives nourishment to a millennium; — and finally in *Plotinus*, the greatest Greek thinker in the time when Greece had become a stranger to itself, when a new principle of life was already moving the world, and the last energetic attempt of Greek thought to assert itself only showed its impotence and heralded the victory of the new age.

The whole period from the fall of Greece to the rebirth of the sciences occupies no place in the history of philosophy. I believe that the more one returns, unswayed by unclear tendencies, to the study of this time, the more decidedly one will come to the insight that all the *thought*-content on which the Christian Middle Ages fed is owed to Greek philosophy, and that one can even extend this proposition so that in everything essential it holds for the Renaissance as well. Christianity could not and would not develop a philosophy out of itself; it had denied the powers from which such a philosophy would have to develop, abandoned the ground from which it would have to spring up. In that Christianity wishes to accomplish what Greece had not been able to accomplish because it rested in the thought of beauty: to tear spirit loose from nature as the one true and real, to posit nature as the essenceless, the evil, to demand death as the condition of life, to move reality over into a kingdom that “is not of this world”, it places itself in a merely negative relation to the forms and powers of human and natural [5] life; its demand remains always only this: to deny them. There can therefore be no talk, in the *strict sense*, of a Christian philosophy, any more than of a Christian art, a Christian state, a Christian ethics. It is a misuse of words to speak so; one does it only by overlooking, intentionally or unintentionally, that Christianity did not come into a *new* world, but that it came into a world in which a great period of culture was just coming to its close, that it found there the whole rich inheritance of antiquity, and that, when the

consistent hope of the first Christian age of an imminent annihilation of natural reality was disappointed, it had to accommodate itself to the *alien* reality, speak its language and use its riches, yet without ever being able or willing to enter into a unity with it; so that everything in the way of thought, of art, of forms for an ethical human life, that has developed *simultaneously with* Christianity has not proceeded *from it*, but only *under its influence*, frequently in struggle against it, from the natural ground of human life, fertilized by the thought of antiquity.

It was only in the fifteenth century that thought, which had gained strength in its bondage, ventured, inspired by the new revelation of antiquity, and borne up by a richly unfolded secular life, and by a nature no longer alien to spirit, to develop a philosophy independent of the authority of the Church. It was still a period of transition; thought still had to struggle with fantasy for dominion, and did not have the strength to develop a new content out of itself alone; but in the philosophy of antiquity it found a content in which the human spirit recognized itself in its reality, and with enthusiasm it seized this content and formed it anew. It was the bacchantic period of thought: with an enormous confidence, with an unshakable *faith in man*, it reveled in the new riches, and formed new systems, in adherence to a *self-chosen* model. The thought-content of these systems [6] is that of antiquity, as it had been prepared through the last Greek philosophers: it was a grandiose pantheistic view of the divine universe, in which man held an exalted place as the point of union between the spheres, as a microcosm that mirrored the universe in itself. The character of the systems was still predominantly theological, but different from that of scholasticism. Nature exerted a stronger attraction on spirit, and the view of nature pushed itself, consciously or unconsciously, more and more in under the view of the divine. The universe became a harmonious unfolding of the life of the Godhead, and faith in the God-man transformed itself into faith in the divine, microcosmic human spirit.

But as thought was thus drawn toward nature, which throughout the Middle Ages had been banished, and at most had been only an object for fantasy, the eye had, on the one hand, to be opened to the natural conditions under which the human spirit stands; on the other hand, the struggle between the new direction and the inherited one, which still kept a secret power, had to lead to a dualistic separation between the natural and the supernatural, between body and spirit, between a sensualist and an idealist theory of knowledge, between a materialist and a spiritualist conception of the principles of existence. Through this dualism, which was bound to bring dissatisfaction and skepticism with it, attention was directed to the necessity of a firm starting point

for thought, a secure method for its development, and at this point begins *the philosophy of modern times*, which breaks off the tradition of antiquity and seeks, independently and self-consciously, to unfold a new content of thought.

As an inheritance from the Middle Ages the new philosophy had received the presupposition of a dualism between spirit and nature, a dualism which in principle was given with Christianity. For thought, which independently sought after truth, there lay two separate spheres, as it were two worlds; but in the unity of self-consciousness lies a protest against every dualism, a demand for the unity and coherence of knowledge. [7] But the dualistic presupposition must determine this unity in such a way that one of the opposites swallows up the other, that in the union the peculiarity of the one is given up. This will prove to be the case in the systems that mark the end points of this philosophical epoch. And the consequence that is drawn in them is the conscious or unconscious mainspring of the earlier systems, which rest on the same fundamental presupposition; by the final goal one understands their striving.

The first form under which dualism appears is that philosophical knowledge takes a double starting point, from nature or from spirit, and this double starting point, by which the character and essential object of knowledge are determined in essentially different ways, constitutes for modern philosophy in its progressive development a double series, which, however, by the nature of the case, was bound at once to acquire points of contact, since both proceeded from the presupposition of the power of spirit to know, since nature retained its mighty power of attraction for both, and since both likewise began by borrowing their method from the natural sciences and mathematics.

Bacon and *Descartes* mark the double starting point for thought. *Bacon* posits *experience*, directed toward nature and its real fullness, as the principle of knowledge; he makes nature the essential object of thought, the source of truth, and natural philosophy the mother of the sciences. But he will not let experience lose itself in the particular; he wants to find the creative forms, the unities of nature, the universal in the concrete, and he acknowledges the activity of thought and the demand of idealism. But in the principle of experience lies the danger of the consequence that the I behaves passively, that, as merely receiving through the senses, it receives only the finite, that this finite, conceived strictly as finite, is conceived mechanically, and that mechanism is carried over to spirit as well. The premises for all these consequences are already given in *Hobbes*; in part the consequences are also drawn, and the final goal of this direction of knowledge hinted [8] at; but a remnant of a rationalist element in him, and the fact that his interest turned essentially toward the practical, prevented him from becoming for the development of

philosophy what *Locke* later became.

While empiricism thus quickly developed its consequences, the opposite direction, which seeks to develop the world of thought out of the inwardness of the thinking I, had taken definite shape in significant systems. *Descartes* sought, through doubt about everything, through the separation of everything heterogeneous, back to the unshakable presupposition of doubt, the I, which was determined as one with thought and as sundered from matter and extension. But in order to obtain a content he must leave this point of unity; he must take refuge in that from which the I has separated itself as its opposite, and which it cannot even *think* as its opposite without cancelling the abstract relation of opposition. Through God thought comes back to the material; the soul acknowledges, as if under compulsion, its connection with the body, even though this connection is reduced to a minimum of space and to the most abstract form of influence. But the connection of mind and body is again conceived as a *composition* of two heterogeneous things; the thinking and the extended substance remain separate, and *Geulincx* and *Malebranche* draw the consequences of occasionalism. The divine substance in *Descartes* remains standing outside reality, separated from the two substances that fill reality, and akin only to the thinking substance. Thought's striving for the unity of knowledge is thus hampered at two points. But *Spinoza* removes the ambiguity in the concept of substance (cf. the Introduction): the infinite unity of the divine substance fills everything, and thereby the determinate substances are posited as its attributes. Thought and extension are posited in the unity of parallelism as equally justified, and the preponderance is even on the point of passing over from thought to matter, God is on the point of coinciding with nature; but the attribute of thought then reaches out again [9] beyond extension, nature is again conceived through an abstraction of thought, and thought asserts the significance that it had as starting point. — In opposition to *Spinoza's* pantheistic absorption of finitude, *Leibnitz*, within the same fundamental direction, holds fast to the interest of the age, individuality, and by his doctrine of monads asserts the subsistence of the individual, while against empiricism he asserts the right of idealism, the validity of the *a priori*; and the theological background of his system preserves the element of infinity and strives toward unity. In *Wolf* his philosophy was reduced from speculative depth to the clarity of the understanding, was systematized and diluted, and thereby made fit to pass into the common consciousness in the form in which we find it again in the *German popular philosophy*, the apotheosis of the understanding, where the finite, spiritless I, the parody of *Leibnitz's* monad, became the center of the universe, indirectly and unconsciously made into an absolute, while the absolute vanished into

the relative, the infinite into abstractions, so that finitude fills the whole territory of philosophy.

At this stage of development the idealist direction meets, at the boundary of the unphilosophical, with French materialism, which was the consistent development of the Lockean philosophy.

In *Locke* philosophy had returned to self-consciousness; but not, as in Descartes, in order to develop out of the I a content that lay originally in it, but in order to demonstrate the passivity of the I in relation to the object, in order to approach the unity of thought and being by reducing the former to the passive copy of the latter. The inconsistencies that still remained in the Lockean philosophy were removed as it passed over to France. *Condillac* drew from it the consequence of sensualism, and in the French materialists the concept of spirit vanished, and the difference between thought and the material object of thought became only a difference of degree within mechanically moved matter. With this development the last consequences of empiricism had been drawn; the opposites had been reduced to unity, but in such a way that the one was annihilated. A corresponding development had not been reached by the contemporary idealism. The idealism of [10] *Berkeley* was only formal; under another name it kept the whole content of realism. The *Scottish* philosophy rested on a postulated *experience*; the *German* was idealism only in abstracto, and aimed unconsciously at the goal of the opposite direction. *Rousseau*, finally, did indeed point to a definite starting point for a more vigorous idealism; but without clarity and without carrying it through.

At the close of the eighteenth century everything was prepared for a decisive turn in philosophy. Materialism had drawn its ultimate consequence; idealism was languishing, but was not exhausted; in its abstract presupposition there lay an incitement to a new form, and dissatisfaction with its content was bound, in one equal to the task, to call forth the consciousness of what lay at its ground and from that to draw out a development. The way out that still stood open to thought was to make all actual being into *thought being*, to posit thought as the source of all reality, and out of the I, which is one with the absolute and with the true essence of nature, to develop a system that appears at once as the system of thought and of reality. It is this direction that German philosophy took at the end of the last century, and which culminated in *Hegel*. It is, despite all its difference from, indeed its opposition to, Christianity, the last philosophical consequence of Christianity's conception of the relation between the spiritual and the natural. *Not Berkeley, but Fichte and Hegel are the opposites and the parallels of abstract materialism.*

In *Kant*, in whose doctrine of *transcendental apperception* this direction is given as

in a germ, it still appears limited and bound by its opposite. Kant does not rest on a single one of the contemporary directions, but on both; in accordance with the whole tendency of his time, he proceeds from a critique of consciousness, but in consciousness he acknowledges both the active and the passive moment, and thus asserts the right [11] of idealism while acknowledging the significance of empiricism. He does not yet put everything objective into self-consciousness, teaches as yet no monism of thought; on the contrary, it is precisely with him that the opposition between thought and being is made the object of philosophy; but objectivity is thinned out for him into an abstract *Ding an sich*, which at every moment threatens to coincide with the most abstract form of the I. This consequence *Fichte* drew, in that the I, as practical, was posited as producing the not-I; and *Schelling* removed the ambiguity that lay in the determination "the I", by conceiving it as the absolute I, identical with nature intuited under the forms of self-consciousness, whose identity in the ideal and the real series of potencies it became the task of philosophy to grasp. The method that was to realize this demand was set forth by *Hegel*. For him pure logical thought becomes all reality, its eternal movement within itself the source of all reality, nature its stepping out of itself, spirit its return to itself, the method the inner movement of thought itself, and therefore one with the system of philosophy, and this system equal to reality.

With Hegel a whole series of development stands completed; what is later than he is only endeavor that does not yet belong to history. *His system on the one side, French materialism on the other, represent the end points of the doubly developed philosophy whose presupposition is the dualism of the Middle Ages.*

The choice of the systems that are to represent the philosophy of modern times will have found its justification in what has been set out. *Bacon* and the *Système de la nature* mark the beginning and the end of a consistently progressing series that goes from empiricism to materialism. *Spinoza* represents the beginning of the opposite series because he was the first to state consistently what Descartes only hinted at. *Leibnitz*, as the one who philosophically integrates Spinoza and contains in himself the fruitful [12] germ of a subsequent development, represents the conclusion of idealism's first main stage (as dogmatism). *Kant* and *Hegel* enclose the most recent philosophy.

For the period of transition the choice has been more difficult, and the isolation of its systems, the manifold and incoherent character of their tendencies, will always make the preponderance of any single system conditional. But *the Platonic Academy* in Florence represents, as a collective individual, the first enthusiastic adherence to the rediscovered antiquity, while *Giordano Bruno* most vigorously develops and most fully

sums up the thought-content of his time, in a form that bears the stamp of a spirit moved by the passion of thought, in which poetry and philosophy, the great powers of that time, contend for dominion. —

In presenting the individual systems my position will be essentially that of historical characterization, and critical only insofar as inconsistencies in the carrying out show themselves in the course of the reproducing development, especially in failed attempts to take up what is excluded by the one-sidedness or deficiency of the principles. It is thus essentially *the execution of the fundamental thought*, not the fundamental thought itself, that becomes the object of criticism. The criticism of the fundamental thought itself is, for all the earlier systems, given in the historical development; the task with the individual system is only to bring that thought out in its whole peculiarity and determinacy, and thereby to demonstrate its historical justification as a link in the development of thought. That criticism would be unjustified which approached the systems with a demand for the solution of definite problems that the systems have not set themselves. If a system could succeed in closing itself up into a real whole without particular problems coming forward, that would be a sign that the problems were falsely posed, that the task would be, not to solve them, but to dismiss them.

In order to bring out the fundamental thought completely, it will be necessary to include everything in the detailed execution that gives an insight into the inner motives of the system, or throws a more definite light back on the principle. Even what is [13] connected with the principle only by looser threads, but has acquired a peculiar historical significance, may not be missing from the presentation.

I have begun the series of monographic presentations with Spinoza, partly for the external reason that the material here lay ready in the greatest completeness, partly for the internal one that is given in the importance of his system and in the great influence it has had on the development of philosophy in this century. I have had all the less hesitation in beginning in the middle of the series since each individual monograph constitutes a whole by itself, which will have its completeness even without the others.

In the presentation of Spinoza I have seldom mentioned the earlier literature. Those who are familiar with it will soon see that account has been taken of everything in it that is even moderately significant, including what belongs to the most recent time¹⁾. I

¹⁾Besides the well-known works on the history of philosophy, partly in its whole extent, partly for shorter periods, by *Brucker*, *Tennemann*, *Tiedemann*, *Buhle*, *Hegel*, *Schleiermacher*, *Ritter*, *Feuerbach*, *Erdmann*, *K. Fischer* (*Gesch. der neueren Philosophie* Bd. I.), *Cousin* (*fragments de philosophie Cartésienne*), and *Bouillier* (*histoire de la philos. Cartésienne*. Paris 1854. 2. Vol.), as well as the monographs by *Sigwart* (*der Spinozismus historisch und philosophisch erläutert mit Beziehung auf ältere und neuere Ansichten*), *Schaarschmidt* (*Descartes und Spinoza*), *Helfferrich* (*Spinoza und Leibnitz*), *Montbeillard* (*de l'Ethique de*

have thought that the right way of using that literature, and the one best serving the [14] unity of the historical presentation, would be, after having used it as an aid to avoid misunderstandings and an incomplete conception, then to let the connected reproduction of Spinoza's thoughts itself, by its unity, prove itself the right one, and at the same time to reject the false conceptions in an indirect way. If one succeeds in rendering a system in its wholeness from its living center, then this organic wholeness itself will prove the correctness of the conception in the whole and in the particular, and will of itself remove the false or incomplete conception.

With this preface, whose length must find its excuse in the fact that much has had to seek its place in it which in a connected history of philosophy would have found a place in the book itself, I now hand this work over to the not numerous public that books of this content can count on finding in Denmark. The remaining monographs will be published as quickly as circumstances allow me. Next after this one will follow the two treatises on *Francis Bacon of Verulam* and the *Système de la nature*, which, on account of their relation to each other, will appear simultaneously.

Copenhagen, 6 April 1856.

H. Brøchner.

Spinoza), *Erdmann* (Vermischte Aufsätze), and *Trendelenburg* (Ueber Spinozas Grundgedanken und dessen Erfolg), I have used what is to be found of critical and polemical developments of Spinozism in *Leibnitz* (especially in the work edited by *Foucher de Careil*: réfutation inédite de Spinoza par Leibnitz), *Wolf*, *Jacobi*, *Herder*, *Mendelssohn*, *Maimon*, *Schelling*, *Hegel*, *Baader*, *Herbart* and *Trendelenburg*. The writings of Spinoza's contemporary theological and philosophical opponents have been accessible to me only in part. They yield profit only through their misunderstandings.

Benedict Spinoza

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[15]

Quicquid est, *in Deo* est; et nihil sine Deo esse neque concipi potest. — Eth. I. prop. 15.

Æternum illud et infinitum ens, quod Deum seu naturam appellamus, eadem, qua existit, *necessitate* agit. — Eth. IV. præf.

Summum mentis bonum est *Dei cognitio*, et summa mentis virtus Deum cognoscere. — Eth. IV. prop. 28.

[16]

Introduction

The Historical Genesis of Spinozism.

[17] If, in order to understand a philosophical system in its historical significance in the widest sense, in order to grasp the moving forces which, often only dimly sensed by the system's originator, work through it, in order to see its justification and the limit of that justification, it is necessary to cast a glance over the whole course of development of human thought; then, in order to grasp a system in its determinate form, in order to follow its fundamental thought into its consequences, and in order to discover its historical and psychological genesis, it is sufficient to go back to the nearest great division in history, where the new beginning forms a gulf between itself and the past and comes forward with the justified claim of what is peculiar to independence. We also find that the systems which follow immediately after such epochs see in them the limits of their historical connection, and, often with a misjudging disdain for the past, take them only as the starting point for a consistent development of thought. Thus Spinoza's historical parallel, Fichte, in his first appearance goes back only to Kant, and Spinoza himself only to Descartes.

[18] With Descartes (cf. the Preface, p. 8) the one line of development of modern philosophy began, with the demand to develop the content of philosophy out of self-consciousness, from the thinking I, according to a fixed method. Indications of this direction had already been given in earlier thinkers. The *French skeptics* had pointed back to self-consciousness, *Campanella* had again recalled Augustine's inference from the I's thinking to its being; but these indications had stood as isolated; they had not been pursued into their consequences. They come to be so only when Descartes, casting off tradition and turning polemically not so much against the already retreating scholastic philosophy as against the revived thought of antiquity, leads back through doubt about everything to the I as the secure point of attachment, and, as doubt becomes a separating-out of everything that does not belong to the essence of the I, determines that essence as thought, and now, in an immediate intuition (*simplici mentis intuitu*),

not through an inference — for *cogito ergo sum* is no inference — lets the thinking I confirm itself as being (*sum cogitans*). In the starting point there is thus given thought's immediate certainty of itself, its immediate self-confirmation, its active separation from and opposition to that whose essence is not determined as thought, and which, consistently, ought to have been posited as a non-being. But in this separation and opposition thought loses its content¹⁾, and while the demand is made, to develop knowledge out of itself, no way is left open by which it might, from itself alone, arrive there again. The concept of *God* must here pave the way. Descartes arrives at it in that doubt, which, more deeply understood, was thought's holding fast to itself in the separating-out of everything that was alien to it, is understood as the sign of finitude, and the doubting, finite I now finds in itself the idea of the infinite being, an idea that guarantees the existence of this being, since it can have its origin only from such a being, not from the finite I, as otherwise the effect would contain a greater reality than the cause. In the [19] representation of God as perfect is now found the representation of his veracity; it gives us confidence in the truth of our clear and distinct ideas¹⁾; for the infinitely perfect being cannot will to deceive; that would presuppose an imperfection. But among the clear and distinct ideas Descartes counts, by giving the concept of thought an extent that stands in opposition to his deeper conception of it (in that not only *intelligere* and *velle*, but also *imaginari* and *sentire* are counted under it), the idea of a body that is united with the mind as well, and through this body the connection is opened with the world of bodies, with nature, which, despite its opposition to the essence of thought, constantly exercises a magical power over Descartes's thought and becomes its essential and dearest object, while he as it were shuns the more concrete domains of spirit, especially the ethical.

In the opposition to mind, the independence of nature from mind is given; as the mind is conceived as substance, the body must also be conceived as such; the thinking substance gets over against itself an *extended* substance; for in the case of nature, conceived *through* thought, abstractly as its opposite, quantity, extension, becomes the essential determination. — Separated from these finite substances, *the infinite substance, God*, comes to take its place. Since *thought* is the starting point, God is determined in such a way that thought finds itself again in him; extension is excluded from his essence.

¹⁾This consequence holds for Descartes, not for Spinoza. In the former the I is sundered from nature, and nature is excluded from God's essence; in Spinoza the I as thinking is, in God, in unity with the essence of nature.

¹⁾Consistently understood, the clear and distinct idea itself is the criterion of truth, since in it thought is in unity with itself and confirms itself. *Cogito ergo sum* is the first form of the thinking I's self-confirmation, the idea of God as the absolute essence of thought its highest form, and, in the concept, its first. But when doubt is understood as finitude, the clear and distinct idea becomes uncertain, and must be supported by the representation of God.

But since the *I* is the starting point, and fixes itself from pure activity into a thinking [20] *being*, it does not vanish in God, although his essence becomes the absolute essence of thought; the consequences of this concept are not drawn, they are merely hinted at¹⁾, and the concept of substance is held in an ambiguity that makes it possible to preserve a doubtful independence for the finite *I*'s. Descartes does indeed determine substance as: *une chose, qui existe en telle façon, qu'elle n'a besoin que de soi-même pour exister* (principes de la philos. I, 51)²⁾ and by this definition it is restricted to God; but it is at once extended again to those of the created things that do not need *other created* things in order to exist, but need for that only God's *concoctus ordinarius*, while the rest of the finite is called the *qualities* or *attributes* of these substances. From the "*uncreated substance, which thinks and is independent*" (I, 54), are then distinguished the two classes of *created substances*, the *corporeal* and the *mental*, each of which has its own peculiar attribute, which constitutes their nature and essence, and on which their other attributes depend. Thus *extension* in length, breadth and height constitutes the essence of the extended substance, *thought* that of the thinking substance (I, 53). The two classes of finite substances have nothing in common, but the consciousness of their union in man, who is conceived as a *composition* of both, forces Descartes to the hypothesis of a point of contact in the glandula pinealis (*conarion*), the immediate seat of the soul in the brain, through which the motions of the body communicate themselves as sensations to the soul, and the soul's thoughts as motions to the body³⁾; but the possibility [21] of this transformation in the communication he does not demonstrate, and it cannot be demonstrated from his principles.

Instead of ending with a unity of knowledge that is coherent and grounded in itself, Descartes therefore ends with a double, unreconciled opposition: the opposition between the thinking and the extended substance, and between the finite substances and the infinite. For the thinkers who attached themselves to him, the two problems decisive for his whole thought were thus set: to find the unity between mind and body, and the unity between God and the finite, and thereby to reconcile the double discord.

The consequences of Descartes's conception of the essence of the two finite substances were drawn by *de la Forge*, *Geulincx* and *Malebranche*, in that the difference of essence was held fast, and the union was sought, not in man, through a fantastic hypothesis, but

¹⁾In that the thought of the infinite is given a priority over the thought of the finite (cf. Ep. I, 119), and it is posited as originally being in us (pr. phil. I, 20-22 and elsewhere).

²⁾I cite from: *Oeuvres philosophiques de Descartes* publiées d'après les textes originaux par L. Aimé-Martin. Paris 1839.

³⁾This hypothesis Descartes does not, however, hold to consistently, since already in him there are hints of the theory of *Causæ occasionales* developed by his school, by which divine causality becomes what is at work in both mind and body, mediating between the changes of both.

through a postulate in God, who in both series of substances produces corresponding changes, while the finite substances are only occasions (*causæ occasionales*) for each other's changes. And *Geulincx*, *Malebranche* and *Clauberg* alike carried the consequences of the relation set up by Descartes between the infinite and the finite thinking substances so far that only the presuppositions of religious representation prevented the fusion of the finite thinking spirit with the infinite. It was also only these presuppositions that kept *Malebranche* from positing, with decisiveness, *real* extension as an attribute of God.

Only by abandoning those representations could the strict consequence of the Cartesian concept of substance be drawn, and the second problem be carried further; but as the consequence was drawn with regard to this problem, the changed conception acts directly on the conception of the first problem, and a new formula is set up for its solution. This development takes place in *Spinoza*, and since he has thought to the end what his predecessor had left standing ambiguous, he becomes the real representative of the direction indicated by the latter.

For Descartes *thought in the form of the I* had been the center; from the I he had [22] taken his starting point, and even over against the infinite, which was conceived under the same fundamental concept, he had held fast to it, and had rejected the problems that threatened its existence¹⁾. But since the I was determined as *thinking*, to the exclusion of the conditions of individuality, its essence was determined only by the *universality* of thought, and the consequence had to be drawn that lets the independent subsistence of the finite form vanish, and posits the essence, thought in its infinity, as the one being. The thought of the infinite does not tolerate limitation by a finite subsisting by itself, and all the less since it is not a secondary but the original thought; for the limited — Descartes had already stated this — is grasped only through the unlimited; the latter is the positive, that which lies at the ground; limitation is a determination within it and presupposes it²⁾. The *first thought* of the thinking substance is the thought of infinity, the thought of God; but in this thought it is not separated from the thinking infinite, it is in unity with it: an independent position for the finite thinking substance becomes an impossibility. What Descartes called finite thinking substances must therefore change their name and become *modifications of the one infinite substance*; they must have their reality only in it. And the same holds of the *extended* substances. They are posited by

¹⁾Thus especially the problem, sharpened by Descartes's conception of conservation, of the relation of divine omnipotence to the self-activity of the finite substances, in particular to human freedom.

²⁾How Spinozism's peculiar determination of the essence of the infinite substance leads to determining the general proposition that the finite cannot exist *alongside* the infinite in such a way that what makes it finite is only something negative (that limitation is negation), so that the finite is not merely in the infinite, but is in it *only as modification*, will be shown later (cf. chapter 3.).

[23] Descartes as created by God, existing, like the thinking ones, solely by his continued conservation, but the essence of extension is not posited in God; he is determined only as thinking, although in Descartes this determination has significance only as opposition to extension. But the cause can be the cause only of what is grounded in its nature; it can impart only what it itself has in itself; if, therefore, God is posited as cause of the extended substances, extension as infinite must be posited in God, and just as the thinking substances had their reality only as modifications in God, the same must hold of the extended ones. Only thereby is the contradiction in Descartes also removed, that the thinking and the extended substance are grasped solely through the attribute that constitutes their essence, without there lying in their concept a relation to God, of whom they thus become independent with regard to essence, while with regard to existence they are dependent on him. This contradiction between dependence and independence is removed only when that which Descartes conceived as independent substances is conceived as attributes of the one infinite substance, which is undivided in both, so that both express its essence wholly, and while they are independent of each other, in that each by itself expresses the *whole* essence of substance, they are at the same time in unity by expressing the *one* substance (cf. chapter 2.)

If now, as the presentation of Spinoza's philosophy will show, that philosophy is wholly concentrated in his concept of substance, and this concept develops immediately as a consequence of what was given in Descartes, then it follows that it is not necessary to pursue the origin of Spinozism further back.

Some have wished, deceived by a superficial similarity and misunderstanding the peculiarity of Spinozism, to trace it back to the doctrine of emanation of the *Kabbalah*. The development in the following chapters will show how incompatible Spinoza's conception of eternal being, of the finite as being only in the infinite and, according to its truth, with its limitation cancelled, is with the emanation doctrine's conception of finite existence [24] as having arisen through an unfree unfolding in *time*, as independent and as fallen away. The scarcely appreciative manner in which Spinoza expresses himself about the Jewish tradition (cf. tract. theol.-pol. Cap. 7 and 9), and the few and indefinite references to the views of Jewish thinkers (Ep. 21, 29. Eth. II, 7, schol.) are not suited either to prove a closer relation of dependence.

But while such a relation of dependence with regard to what is essential, to the fundamental thought of the system, is rejected, there is not thereby rejected either an influence of other philosophers on particulars of the execution, or a general influence of certain tendencies of the age and of Spinoza's Jewish nationality. On Spinoza's doctrine

of the state *Hobbes* had an effect, perhaps also *Hugo Grotius*, although Spinoza does not name him; for the determination of the relation of religion to philosophy *Herbert of Cherbury* may have had significance, for the sharper conception of the problems prepared by Descartes *Arnold Geulincx*¹⁾. On Spinoza's pantheistic fundamental view the pantheistic elements that had remained in the spirit of the age from the period of transition may have had influence; on the strict conception of substance, God, as the one being, the Jewish representation of God. But every external influence, whether through definite theories or through the whole spiritual atmosphere of the age, is in Spinoza worked up into inner consistency; his system forms a whole that is understood from itself, from one principle.

If, ahead of the actual presentation of Spinoza's philosophy, we wish for preliminary orientation to indicate this principle and its immediate consequences for the form of his thought and for his method, then the elements for this lie in what was developed above concerning his relation to Descartes. As the concept of substance is conceived in such a way that in its unity it fills the whole of existence, it governs thought as its not merely essential but, strictly speaking, its only object. In substance thought finds all reality; [25] in it, it finds itself. But the fact that all reality is in substance grounds the *pantheistic* conception. The fact that thought is immediately in unity with substance, which is its own infinite, objectified essence, and at the same time the essence of extension, gives thought its immediate certainty and the system the character of *dogmatism*. The fact that all *reality* is enclosed in the concept of substance entails that this concept must unfold itself for thought, and the character of this unfolding, which is in the element of eternity, not of time, must be determined by the form of natural law, necessity. For since thought has first separated nature out from itself as its opposite, and determined it by the abstract concept of extension, this conception acts back upon thought itself, which must seek its content in nature; and as thought and extension are united in the unity of substance, mechanical necessity, the law of abstractly conceived nature, becomes the law of thought and of substance. And even though in substance, as the one existent, necessity is not an external necessity, not compulsion, but an inner necessity, determined by its own essence, a *libera necessitas*, the concept of *causality* nevertheless displaces that of purpose, and this both on account of the influence of the concept of nature on the concept of substance, and on account of the strict holding fast to the concept of infinity in opposition to anthropomorphic representations.

The *method* of the system is determined immediately by the fundamental concept.

¹⁾Especially with regard to the conception of individual minds as *modi* in God, and of extension as *res singularis* and infinite.

Thought is not separated from its object; the object is the reality in thought, thought's own reality; the unfolding of the object must therefore give the form of thinking its stamp; the object's necessity, conditioned by the concept of causality, determines the [26] *mathematical* form of the *development* of thought¹⁾, while the starting point and end point of thought becomes *immediate intuition*, corresponding to substance's being in itself.

A *division* of philosophy from its principle Spinoza has not given, but only hinted at. It will be brought out in the following chapter what peculiar difficulties had to arise for him on this point, and these difficulties will become still clearer in the closer development of his doctrine.

¹⁾Not exactly the synthetic method, which Spinoza has used only in the Ethics and in the Principia phil. Cartes., and whose use instead of the analytic he ascribes especially to a didactic purpose, but in general the method that proves with mathematical stringency, which, with mathematical necessity, links to what is clear and simple in itself the firmly chained series of consequences.

Chapter One.

Spinoza's Life and Writings.

The life history of a thinker is the history of his thought, for the content of his life is [27] his thought. His outward life does not acquire an immediate interest, as does that of an outwardly acting personality, whose life stamps itself on his own time as it itself bears that time's stamp. It becomes either wholly indifferent, or of significance only insofar as its agreement with his thinking offers a guarantee of that thinking's power to permeate a human life. The interest becomes a derived one; it cannot become essential, for in the appropriation of the content of thought the personal relation to the thinker vanishes, and must vanish, if the appropriation is to become complete and free. One can therefore, in the case of a thinker, even if one demands more than the genesis of his thought, be content with a light outline of his life, provided only that this outline is definite enough for the stamp of his thought to become visible through it; one can renounce all those details, significant even in their apparent contingency, that make the outline into a finished picture. As regards Spinoza, such contentment is necessary; he has found only one somewhat more detailed biographer, the Lutheran pastor *Colerus*¹⁾, and this [28] simple-minded, honest narrator, who despite his theological antipathy is appreciative of the philosopher he did not understand, has found in Spinoza's simple, outwardly uniform life only scant material to impart, and his reports are completed only a little by the details that are found in the preface to Spinoza's posthumous writings, in *Bayle* (in his *Dictionnaire historique et critique*), in "La vie de Spinoza par un de ses disciples" (probably the physician *Lucas*), Amsterdam 1719, and in *Nicéron*, Kortholt and Leibnitz.

From the character of Spinoza's thinking, as it already shows itself in the way in which he conceived his predecessor's principle and carried it further, one might expect that his life would not be like that of many of the thinkers of the period of transition, especially the Italians, whom thought seized as a restless, never satisfied, consuming

¹⁾La vie de Spinoza, tirée des écrits de ce fameux philosophe et du témoignage de plusieurs personnes dignes de foi, qui l'ont connu particulièrement. The Hague 1706. 8. An earlier Dutch edition appeared in Utrecht.

passion, and, filling them as with prophetic frenzy, tossed them unsteadily about the world as its heralds, and let them, proud of their calling, collide defiantly with the established order, to end as martyrs of the idea. In Spinoza we must expect that the calm of the fundamental view will cast its light over his life, that the vanishing of the finite in the infinite will stamp itself in resignation, in a giving up of all the more concrete relations of life in order to live only for knowledge, for the unity of thought with the divine in intellectual love.

This we also find confirmed when we read the few and meager reports that have been handed down to us about Spinoza. They are insufficient to form for us a whole and full picture of a human life, but sufficient to let us follow a break with everything that is not the infinite, with nationality, with the faith of the fathers, with love for a woman, with outward esteem, in order to live solely in and for the highest. —

Baruch Spinoza was born in Amsterdam on 24 November 1632. His father was a Jewish merchant who on account of religious persecution had left his fatherland, Portugal. [29] From the few traits of him to be found in the son's biographers, one gets the impression of a clear intellect and of freedom from prejudice in religious views. As the family's circumstances were only modest and the son early revealed excellent gifts, he was destined for the learned estate and entrusted to the instruction of rabbis, among whom *Moses Morteira* has a name in modern Hebrew literature. This instruction continued after the early death of Spinoza's parents, and to it was later joined, in accordance with the precept of the Talmud, training in a craft, the making of optical glasses, in which he gradually attained a great perfection. It was not long before his clear intellect, sharpened by Talmudic subtlety but driven by a thirst for truth that did not let it find rest in the artificial edifice of the rabbis, embarrassed his teachers and at once roused both the pride of his co-religionists and their secret unease. Already before he was 20 years old, faith in the authority of the rabbis had been destroyed in him, and his thought, which found no satisfaction in their doctrine, sought the truth in itself. Unfortunately it is precisely for the years that lie between the first trace of an awakening independence in Spinoza and his decisive break with his people and his religion that the biographers are poor and in disagreement. For internal reasons the author of "*la vie de Spinoza*" seems on this point to deserve credence in preference to Colerus, who imagines the course of Spinoza's education after the pattern of the Christian learned schools, and therefore brings in at an earlier point humanistic elements of development with which Spinoza only later came into contact. According to that biographer's account it seems as if Spinoza let his thoughts ripen in silence; but as they took on a firmer form, and his

doubt extended from Jewish learning to the Jewish religion, the mistrust of his teachers and fellow believers was aroused, and it was strengthened by his withdrawing more and more from the synagogue and seeking the company of Christians. His teachers, who had seen in him a future pillar of the synagogue, now became hostile to him, and sought by peremptory commands to bring him back; the congregation sought to buy [30] him back with an annual stipend of 1000 guilders, and, when that did not help, to get rid of him by assassination. This too failed, and now they resorted to the last means, the excommunication of the apostate; and soon afterwards the rabbis, supported by the Reformed clergy, succeeded in prevailing upon the magistrate of Amsterdam to banish him from the city for a time. From this time on Spinoza stands as a stranger to his people and its religion. His Jewish name Baruch he exchanges for its Latin form Benedictus, and philosophy becomes the occupation of his life.

Already at the time when he began to feel a stranger among his people, he had sought, outside the narrow circle of Jewish learning, to procure the means for a richer scientific development and for humanistic culture. From the freethinker, the physician *Frants van den Ende*, he learned the classical languages, especially Latin, and with its help he gained access to the study of the natural sciences and of philosophy, in which he soon chose Descartes as his guide. When he had been excommunicated, van den Ende took him into his house for a time, and a romantic light falls over this period of his life through his love for his teacher's gifted daughter. She preferred one of his fellow pupils, and his love now sought its object in the divine.

Spinoza's excommunication from the synagogue falls about the year 1660, and in the same year, probably, his removal from Amsterdam. He spent a short time with a friend in the country near the city; the following year he settled in the village of *Rynsburg* near Leyden, where in 1663 he published his first work: *Principia philosophiæ Cartesianæ*, more *geometrico demonstrata*, to which *Cogitata metaphysica* form an appendix. In 1664 he moved to *Voorburg* near The Hague, and from there, after a five-year stay, at his friends' urging, to *The Hague* itself, where he lived the rest of his life.

On this part of Spinoza's life Colerus is more detailed, at least detailed enough for [31] his narrative to give us an impression of its strict, earnest, solitary, energetic character. We see Spinoza working strenuously and without interruption toward his goal: the knowledge of God, of nature, and of the unity in which we are with nature, and toward the calm elevation above the human passions that is acquired through the clarity of knowledge. Once, Colerus relates, he had not left for 3 months the simple room he occupied at the house of the painter van der Spyck in The Hague, so deeply did he

immerse himself in his studies. By his extraordinary frugality he made it possible for himself, although he had to work for his living, to devote most of his time to them. His biographer tells us circumstantially and with naive details how meagerly he lived, how little he spent, although in his outward appearance he always maintained a certain modest elegance, how few and simple were the effects found after his death, and how disinterested he was in his dealings with his sisters and with his richer friends and patrons.

Besides the many whom curiosity drew to him, there were many who were affected by Spinoza's personality. His deep knowledge impressed them, while his lively and witty conversation, his humanity, his openness and fidelity, and the nobility of his character (cf. Oldenburg's remarks in Ep. 1) attracted them; but only few of them understood him, and his relation to them became more a humane relation of goodwill, and theirs to him one of admiration. From his letters, which are all replies, one sees that only one single one of his correspondents, the anonymous writer who wrote the letters 61, 63, 65, 67, 69 and 71, designated by various marks, was capable of penetrating more deeply into his philosophy, and for Spinoza, whose life was his thinking, only a unity in thinking could ground a real relation of friendship. How little he was understood by those who drew near to him and felt attracted by him one can best infer from his correspondence with *Oldenburg* (cf. p. 40), which, with a single interruption, continued from 1661 until [32] Spinoza's death. Even from the last of these letters it appears that Oldenburg, who after all spent his life in the company of philosophers and men of science, had still not managed to grasp a single one of Spinoza's thoughts, and the same must naturally have been the case with all those who wished to follow Spinoza without becoming aware that they would have to give up the whole foundation on which their circle of representations rested.

Even before Spinoza's writings had drawn more general attention to him, we see from his letters that he had been noticed by scholars and drawn into the correspondence that was so important and so eagerly used an aid to the scientific life of that time¹⁾. His first work at once won him a name, but also provoked attacks from the strict Cartesians²⁾. His fame rose still higher through the *tractatus theologico-politicus*, published in 1670³⁾, but in a still greater proportion than his fame grew the number of his opponents, especially

¹⁾Spinoza's correspondence seems, according to remarks in L. Meyer's preface to his *Opera posthuma*, to have been fairly extensive, and the collection of letters found in his writings (74) has probably made up only a small part of it. In the Great Royal Library here in this city there is an unprinted note from Spinoza to *Grævius*, but its content is without significance.

²⁾On Spinoza's relation to these cf. Ep. 19.

³⁾Not only scholars became attentive to him, but also political personages: thus, besides Jan de Witt, the Prince of Condé, who invited Spinoza to a meeting with him in Utrecht in 1673, and Fr. of Luxembourg.

among the clergy, and their fanatical attacks were the reason why Spinoza's most important writings were published only after his death. Only by this reserve could he procure for himself the peace on which he set so high a value, and which was so necessary to him, and for its sake he also declined the honorable offer to take up a professorship of philosophy in Heidelberg, which was made to him in 1673 by the liberal-minded Elector *Carl Ludvig* through his councillor, who was evidently only little pleased with [33] this commission, the Heidelberg professor *Ludvig Fabritius*.

In the political events of his fatherland Spinoza took no active part, but he followed them as an observer, with the interest that his view of the political relation was bound to give them. His conception of the indispensability of freedom for the attainment of the end of the state (cf. chapter 7) made him an adherent of the republican form of state and attached him to those who defended it against monarchical tendencies, especially to *Jan de Witt*, who became his protector and benefactor, and whose lamentable death filled him with bitter grief.

His relation to religion was given in his conception of its essence. For himself his philosophy was his religion: the knowledge of God is love for him and unity with him. Over against others, for whom the common religious representations had kept their significance, he sought to hold fast to the practical and humane element in religion, and to conceive it in such a way that it could become an approximation to true knowledge and to true agreement among men. Passing over the dogmas, he brought forward what could serve as an incitement to love, concord and honesty, and emphasized the significance of obedience and the value of common worship. Precisely this formed the most frequent subject of those conversations with his housemates in which he sought rest from more strenuous occupation, and in which he knew how to mix earnestness with kindness, and often with cheerful humor and good-natured irony.

Spinoza's health had been weak from his youth; strenuous mental work and night watches undermined it still further, and a consumption developed which on 21 February 1677 put an end to his life in his 45th year. His Christian biographer relates circumstantially how patiently and steadfastly he had borne his sufferings, how calm and gentle his death was, and he rejects the untrue rumors that were in circulation concerning the manner of his death. Another theologian (*Kortholt*) wonders that an atheist could have [34] so beautiful an end, and those who could not comprehend this, and did not have such good information as Colerus, spread rumors that Spinoza had died of fright at coming to share the fate of Jan de Witt, or by suicide.

A portrait of Spinoza that is still preserved shows us a face in which the dark com-

plexion, the curved nose, the strongly marked mouth and chin point to his Oriental nationality, while the high, powerfully formed forehead, the firm and fine line of the eyebrows, and the lively, clear eye betray the keen thinker. The expression of the face bears the stamp of the earnestness of resignation, but also of the calm in the infinite that is acquired through it.

Of Spinoza's *writings*, the two that appeared in his lifetime have already been named above. The first of these, *Renati Des Cartes Principiorum philosophiæ pars I & II*, more geometrico demonstratæ par *Benedictum de Spinoza*, Amstelodamensem, — to which *Cogitata metaphysica*, in quibus difficiliores, quæ tam in parte metaphysices generali quam speciali occurrunt quæstiones breviter explicantur, are attached as an appendix, originally came into being through an external occasion, part of it having been worked out for the use of a pupil whom Spinoza was instructing in the Cartesian philosophy, but did not consider ripe for initiation into his own views, already independently developed at that time (cf. Ep. 9). As Spinoza, at his friends' request, worked it up for publication, there are indicated, in the course of the presentation of Descartes's doctrine, the points where difficulties that are insoluble from Descartes's standpoint make necessary consequences that lead toward Spinoza's own¹⁾, and in the whole design of the presentation the way is [35] paved for his own conception. This character of the work indicates the purpose of its publication.

While this work was thus meant to prepare the reception of Spinoza's philosophy, the next was to make room for it by marking out the boundary between theology and philosophy and thereby securing a neutral territory for philosophy, and by demonstrating the compatibility of free thought and free speech with the end of the state and with its peace. This is the immediate task of the *Tractatus theologico-politicus*, continens dissertationes aliquot, quibus ostenditur, libertatem philosophandi non tantum salva pietate et reipublicæ pace posse concedi, sed eandem nisi cum pace reipublicæ ipsaque pietate tolli non posse, which appeared in 1670. The essential content of this treatise will be developed in chapter 7, where Spinoza's conception of religion and the state is presented. It appeared without Spinoza's name and was quickly suppressed at the

¹⁾It is especially in the problem of *God's relation to extension* (cf. pr. ph. C. I, 9. schol. 16. 21. II, 2. schol., Cog. met. I, c. 2.), in the determination of the concept *creatio* (cf. pr. ph. C. I, 12. Cog. met. II, c. 10), and of the concept *finite things*, existing *extra Deum* and *in se*, in the question of the compatibility of this last concept with God's properties, such as omniscience, omnipresence, immutability (cf. pr. ph. C. I, 11 dem. 12, coroll. 2. Cog. met. I, c. 2. II, c. 1. 3. 7. 10 f.), and finally in the problem of *human freedom* (cf. Cog. met. I, c. 3. II, c. 11 f.), that difficulties show themselves, for whose solution from Spinoza's own standpoint hints are given (thus, e.g., with regard to the concept of creation, which is cancelled in that it is restricted to apply to existentia, not essentia, and in that its application to modi is denied). On his relation to Descartes Spinoza has also expressed himself in Ep. 2 (from 1661).

instigation of the clergy, but a few years later (1673) was published again under various fictitious titles¹⁾. Later it was Spinoza's intention to publish it anew, accompanied by [36] notes¹⁾, but he was prevented from doing so by his early death. The notes he had wished to add are included in the French translation by *St. Glain*, which appeared in 1678 in Leyden under the title: *La clef du sanctuaire par un savant homme de notre siècle*. Besides this French translation, for which two other titles are also found: *Traité des cérémonies superstitieuses des Juifs tant anciens que modernes*, and: *Reflexions curieuses d'un esprit désintéressé sur les matières les plus importantes au salut tant public que particulier*; — there is a Dutch one by *Joh. Henrik Glasemaker* from 1693, and several more recent French and German ones.

Only after Spinoza's death²⁾ were those writings published that are the real source of our knowledge of his philosophy. His friend *Ludvig Meyer* published this collection in the year of his death (1677) under the title: *B. d. S. Opera posthuma* (it was by Spinoza's wish that his name was not mentioned). It contains, besides Spinoza's chief work, *Ethica*, *ordine geometrico demonstrata*³⁾, the two unfinished treatises, *tractatus politicus* and *tractatus de emendatione intellectus*, as well as 74⁴⁾ letters from and to him, and, as an appendix, an unfinished *Compendium grammatices linguæ hebrææ*. The collection was translated into Dutch in the same year by *Jarrig Jellis* under the title: *De nagelate Schriften van B. d. S.*

Of the *Ethics* Spinoza had already made a draft early on. In the oldest of his letters [37] to *Oldenburg*, from 1661, the first definitions are given, though in a form somewhat different from the present redaction of the *Ethics* (cf. chapter 2), together with the main propositions of the first part of the *Ethics*. This is of importance for Spinoza's development, since it furnishes a proof that, already when he published *Principia phil. Cartes.*, he was clear about his fundamental concept, which diverged from Descartes's¹⁾.

¹⁾Such as: *Danielis Heinsii operum historicorum Collectio prima*. Editio secunda priori editione multo emendatior et auctior. Accesserunt quædam hactenus inedita. Lugd. Batav. 1673. 8. — and: *Francisci Henrici de Villacorta*, doctoris medicinæ, a cubiculo regali Philippi IV et Caroli II archiatri, opera chirurgica omnia, sub auspiciis potentissimi Hispanorum regis Caroli II. Amstelod. 1673. 8.

¹⁾Cf. Ep. 75 (added in Bruder's edition). The treatise is mentioned besides in Ep. 8. 14 ("tractatum de scriptura"), 17. 19 f. 47 and 49.

²⁾Shortly before his death Spinoza destroyed a treatise, *de Iride*, and a Dutch translation of the Old Testament with notes that he had begun, of which the Pentateuch was finished. Lost are the greater part of his letters, a treatise on the devil, and a defense, written in Spanish, of his leaving the synagogue.

³⁾It is divided into 5 parts: *de Deo*; *de natura et origine mentis*; *de origine et natura affectuum*; *de servitute humana seu de affectuum viribus*; *de potentia intellectus seu de libertate humana*.

⁴⁾The 75th letter, which is added in Bruder's edition, was found a few years ago in Holland and published by *H. W. Tydemann*. It is to Lambert van Velthuisen.

¹⁾For Spinoza's relation to Descartes it is also of significance that he began the study of Descartes's writings only after long independent thought.

The essential defects he finds in his predecessor's philosophy he states in the same letter (Ep. 2). In a letter from *Simon de Vries*, written in February 1663 (Ep. 26), definite propositions of the first book of the *Ethics* are cited. In a letter to *Blyenbergh* from 1665 (Ep. 36, cf. Ep. 38) Spinoza refers, with regard to the concept of appetite, to the development in his "*Ethica necdum edita*", where it is found in the third book. In the correspondence with *L. Meyer* (Ep. 63–71) from the last years of Spinoza's life (1675–76), propositions from the various parts of the *Ethics* are frequently cited, which had then probably been brought into its final form. Finally, *Oldenburg* in a letter from 1675 (Ep. 18) urges Spinoza to publish "*tractatum illum — — quinque-partitum*". From these citations, and from many developments in the letters that agree almost word for word with the *Ethics*, it is thus seen that this chief work of Spinoza had long been finished in draft, in which form it had been communicated to several of those who stood closest to him²⁾; but from the variants in the citations, which, where they are of importance for the determinations of concepts, will be touched on later, one sees at the same time that he constantly occupied himself with it anew in order to find the most exact expression for his thought.

[38] The treatise *de intellectus emendatione* is, according to the editor's statement, one of Spinoza's first works, with which he constantly occupied himself, but without ever bringing it to completion. It is mentioned already in 1663 in a letter from Oldenburg (Ep. 8) as: *opusculum, in quo de rerum primordio earumque dependentia a prima causa, ut et de intellectus nostri emendatione tractas*. Later it is mentioned in several letters (Ep. 42. 63 f.). The essential part of its content (cf. chapter 5) is taken up into the 2nd part of the *Ethics*, especially in the scholia to propositions 17 and 40. Having determined the knowledge of the eternal and of our unity with it as the highest and true good, in opposition to the untrue, perishable goods, and having set it as the task to attain this knowledge, the treatise develops the various forms of knowledge, of which the knowledge of reason proves to be the only one that leads to the goal. Its instruments are the true ideas, which contain certainty in themselves, and the true method is the one that shows how the mind links the ideas together according to the norm of its highest idea. In the *first* part of the treatise the true ideas are now distinguished from *ideæ fictæ, falsæ* and *dubiæ*, which belong to the imagination, and the difference between the imagination and intellectus, the source of the true ideas, is determined. In the *second* part the rules are given for how the unknown is derived with certainty from the known, in such a linkage that our mind becomes the subjective rendering of the objective essence of nature as a

²⁾This is also said expressly in the editor's preface: "*ea (i.e. the Ethics) namque ante multos annos a diversis fuit descripta et iis communicata.*"

whole and in its parts. Here the treatise is now led, through the distinction between what is conceived through its proximate cause and what is conceived through its essence alone (*sola essentia*), to treat the laws for the definitions of “created and uncreated” things, since knowledge advances only through the definitions, which express the peculiar essence of things. As the transition was now to be made to the statement of the means by which *res particulares æternæ*, the essential object of reason, can be derived from the highest concept, the treatise breaks off at the decisive point, after the powers of the intellect and its properties have still been treated only briefly. According to the plan of the treatise (p. [39] 371) it still remained, first, to develop the order in the linkage of knowledge, and then the idea of the most perfect being. It will be shown in the development of the fundamental concepts of Spinozism (chapter 2) that precisely at the point where the treatise was broken off an insuperable difficulty arises for Spinoza, so that it is not accidental that it had to remain unfinished.

The *Tractatus politicus*, which is likewise only a fragment, was written shortly before Spinoza's death. In the first 5 chapters he develops with extraordinary sharpness and clarity his conception of natural right, of the concept of the state, of the right of the sovereign power, of the extent of its authority, of the relation of states to one another, and of the end of the civil community. In the 6th and 7th chapters he treats monarchy, in the 8th–10th aristocracy, both that in which one city is the head of the whole state and that in which several cities form a federal state. In the 11th chapter the development of democracy is begun, but here the treatise is broken off after a few general determinations have been given. Besides the complete presentation of this form of state, Spinoza would also (cf. the preface) have treated “the laws and other special political questions.”

The collection of *letters* found in the *Opera posthuma* probably makes up only a small part of the correspondence Spinoza carried on. Besides one letter (Ep. 48), written by a stranger to one of Spinoza's acquaintances concerning the *tractatus theologico-politicus*, it contains 32 letters to and 41 from Spinoza. Most of the letters were originally written in Latin, 24 (namely 30–41, 43–47, 50 and 55–60) in Dutch, and were translated into Latin by L. Meyer. Besides a good deal of information about Spinoza's personal circumstances and about his writings, the letters contain numerous developments, partly of points that are touched on in his works but here as a rule come out in a modified presentation, called forth by questions and misunderstandings; partly of such points as are either not at all or only in passing mentioned elsewhere (thus of various Christian dogmas, of physical, [40] mathematical and optical problems, of logical determinations and the like). A great part of the letters, and precisely of those most important in philosophical respect, are to and

from unnamed authors. Under several of the different marks one and the same author, the editor of his posthumous writings, seems to be hidden. For not only Ep. 29, but doubtless also Ep. 62, 64, 66, 68, 70 and 72 are addressed to him, although the letters to which these are replies are dated from various foreign cities, and in part purport to have been written by someone other than the one who sent them to Spinoza. Among the named correspondents, next after *Leibnitz*, with whom Spinoza exchanged a few words on the occasion of a writing sent to him, *Heinrich Oldenburg* is the best known, and the one to whom the greatest number of letters is addressed. Under Cromwell he was envoy of the Lower Saxon Circle in London and later held the same post under Charles II, who was well disposed toward him and, when the English Society of Sciences became royal in 1662, made him its secretary. He was an eager intermediary between several of the philosophers and scholars of that time, and, despite his slight capacity for grasping a deeper thinking, not without an eye for the peculiarity of talents and recognition of it, and, though not free from a motive of vanity in his approaches to superior personalities, yet animated by a real interest in the development of the sciences. The other named correspondents are: Spinoza's friend *Simon de Vries*, the Dordrecht merchant *Willem van Blyenbergh*, the Heidelberg professor *Joh. Lud. Fabritius*, *Albert Burgh*, who made an unsuccessful attempt to convert Spinoza to Catholicism, and *Peter Balling*. By their initials alone are designated, among others, *Ludvig Meyer* (Ep. 29) and the Spaniard who had gone over to Judaism, *Isaac Orobio de Castro*, as well as perhaps *Joh. Bredenburg* (who in 1675 wrote against the tractatus theol.-pol.) and the Mennonite *Jarrig Jellis*, the translator of Spinoza's Opera posthuma.

[41] Spinoza's *Compendium grammatices linguæ hebrææ*, which forms an appendix to his posthumous writings, is of no significance for his philosophy; at most, particulars of the terminology (thus the use of the designation *attribute*) and the conception of the relation of the parts of speech to one another, in that they are all, with the exception of interjections and conjunctions and certain particles, brought under the concept *Nomen*, can have some interest.

Besides the writings left unfinished at Spinoza's death, he had also, according to Meyer's statement, laid the plan for an "*integra philosophia*", to which there are frequent references in the tractatus de emendatione intellectus (in the preface and in many of the notes) and perhaps in Ep. 74; and for an "*Algebra breviori et magis intelligibili methodo*".

In what relation this *integra philosophia* would have stood to the Ethics, and into which particular sciences it would have divided itself, Spinoza has not indicated. In the introduction to the treatise de intellectus emendatione he enumerates, but, as he

expressly adds, without systematic order, the various sciences that all aim at the same goal, the highest human perfection, i.e. the knowledge, common to all men, of the unio, *quam mens cum tota natura habet*. To this, he says, there belongs first the knowledge of nature, and next a society that can lead to that knowledge as easily and securely as possible. Besides, attention must be given to moral philosophy and to the doctrine of the education of children, and, since health is no slight means to attaining the intended goal, a complete medicine must be set up; and since much that is difficult is made easy by art, and art can save us much time and afford us much advantage in life, mechanics must by no means be neglected. But above all a way must be found to heal the intellect, and, so far as this can be done before science (*initio*), to purify it, so that it grasps things with ease, perfectly and without error. — This enumeration indicates in essentials the same sciences as Descartes's division (cf. Descartes's letter to the French translator of the *principia philosophiæ*); but whereas with Descartes they form a single series, in which morals becomes the concluding but unattainable science, with Spinoza the series is divided, in accordance with the parallelism between the two attributes that man knows. If we wish to bring the enumerated sciences into a systematic order, the doctrine of knowledge becomes an introduction, but as such incomplete, since it can become clear only after the fundamental thoughts of the system have been developed. The fundamental science becomes the knowledge of nature, i.e. of substance, God. This becomes the metaphysical part of the system, in which the general concepts both of ethics and of physics are developed. To it there then attaches, on the one side, ethics¹⁾ with politics and pedagogy, on the other side mechanics and medicine. But on Spinoza's fundamental conception there can be no question, in the strict sense, of a real separation of the sciences, and the parallelism he set up between thought and extension, the difficulty of carrying out which would have shown itself precisely in the more special physical domain, was bound to prevent both series from being carried out, since this would have led either to too great a fusion or to too great a separation. It is therefore surely not accidental that Spinoza treated only the one series, and he can hardly have intended to give more of the other than "generalialia in physicis" (cf. Ep. 63). At a later point we shall see that the opinion expressed by the editor of his posthumous writings, that Spinoza in his *integra philosophia* would have developed "*veram motus naturam atque qua ratione a priori tot varietates in materia deducendæ essent*", could not, by the nature of the case, have been fulfilled.

In Spinoza's chief work, which has come down to us under the title *the Ethics*, the

¹⁾Ep. 38: *magnam Ethices partem, quæ, ut cuivis notum, metaphysica et physica fundari debet.*

essential content of the enumerated sciences is found. The doctrine of *knowledge*, which [43] can only be developed completely after the metaphysical foundation, which is the object of an immediate certainty, has gone before, is given in the second part of the Ethics, summarily in prop. 40, schol. 2. The general part of *metaphysics* is found in the first book of the Ethics; the general *physical* propositions, which are presuppositions for the more special ethical part, are given in the second part of the Ethics, prop. 13. *Politics* is given in its foundation in the doctrine of the affects, in which the principles of a *pedagogy* also lie, and its fundamental concepts are determined in Eth. IV, 37. schol. 2. For *mechanics* and *medicine* there are, by the nature of the case, only few elements to be found, but in the development of the parallelism between the mind's power to think and the body's power to act (cf. especially Eth. III, 28. dem. V, præfat., Ep. 45) lies the fundamental principle for the conception of them. — Knowledge of Spinoza's system thus rests essentially on the Ethics; the presentation must proceed from it, and the other writings serve only to complete it on particular points.

Of *editions* of Spinoza's writings there are, besides the original, separate ones, 3 collected editions: by *Paulus* (Jena 1802—3. 2 vols. 8.), *Gfroerer* (Stuttgart 1830. 8. In this, however, the Hebrew grammar is missing) and *Bruder* (Leipzig 1843—46. 3 vols. 12. Stereotype edition.) The Ethics, tractatus politicus and de emend. intellectus are included in: Renati des Cartes et Spinozæ dissertationes philosophicæ ed. C. *Riedel* (Leipzig 1843. 2 Vol. 12.) Of more recent translations there are two complete ones: a German one by B. *Auerbach* (Stuttgart 1841. 5 vols.) and a French one by E. *Saisset* (Paris 1843. 2 Vol.).

Where page numbers are given with the citations in this treatise, they refer to the original editions when another edition is not expressly named.

Chapter Two.

The Fundamental Concepts of Spinozism.

What was developed in the Introduction concerning Spinoza's relation to Descartes [44] leads immediately to the point from which his system can be surveyed. When the concept of substance is taken in its strictness, it becomes the all-embracing concept, hence also the starting point, and a starting point that can no longer be abandoned. Whereas Descartes had to proceed from the finite I, Spinoza proceeds from the absolute essence of this I, from the infinite, and can begin only with this because *only* the infinite is. It is therefore not through a deduction that this is reached; it is the object of an immediate certainty; in it thought thinks only itself in its infinity. It is not in conflict with this that proofs of the existence, infinity and unity of substance are found in Spinoza, and that not merely in *principia phil. Cartes.*, where in essentials the Cartesian demonstration is reproduced and Spinoza's distinctive conception is only hinted at, but also in the *Ethics* (I, 7. 8. 14). For this demonstration has only the significance of something formal, of a development of concepts for the subject, not of something that grounds. This will become clearer in its place when the essence of human thought in its relation to substance has been developed.

I. The stated conception of *substance* now underlies its definition: *Per substantiam intelligo id, quod in se est, et per se concipitur; hoc est id, cujus conceptus non indiget conceptu alterius rei, a quo formari debeat.* (*Eth.* I, def. 3, cf. *Ep.* 27.). Substance "is conceived through itself" (*concepitur per se*) in that its concept is not formed, i.e. derived, from a higher concept (as, e.g., that of motion from that of extension), but is itself the highest concept. It is "in itself" (*in se*), not in another (as *modus* is in substance). But in the determination that it is in itself and is conceived through itself, there lies immediately [45] that it also is *per se*, that it is the *cause of itself*¹⁾; for the concept of an effect includes the concept of the cause ("effectus cognitio a cognitione causæ dependet, et eandem involvit." *Eth.* I, ax. 4); what therefore includes only its own concept cannot be an effect except of

¹⁾De emend. intell. pag. 386 puts side by side: *esse in se*, and: *causa sui*.

itself. But since it is its own cause, its existence is not contingent, but *necessary*, posited with its essence: Per *causam sui* intelligo id, cuius essentia involvit existentiam, sive id, cuius natura non potest concipi nisi existens. (Eth. I, def. 1.). This unity of existence and essence is *eternity*: per *æternitatem* intelligo ipsam existentiam, quatenus ex sola rei æternæ definitione necessario sequi concipitur (Eth. I, def. 8.)²⁾. And since eternity is the absolute affirmation of the existence of a nature, there follows from it immediately *infinity*, while everything finite is ex parte negatio (Eth. I, 8. schol. 1.). But in the concept of infinity lies *unity*, both as exclusion of *plurality* (for this presupposes not merely a mutual limitation, but also a separation between essence and existence, and moreover, since it is not given by the definition of the thing, an *external* cause, cf. Eth. I, 8 schol. 2), – and as exclusion of *divisibility*³⁾.

[46] Substance is thus determined as the eternal, infinite, one, which is through itself and is conceived through itself. All reality is concentrated in its concept; in it thought has the infinity of its essence and the unity of knowledge.

Predicated of substance, the concepts of unity and of infinity denote the same; for as a merely *numerical* determination unity has no application to substance¹⁾. But infinity is not conceived as the negation of a positive finite, but as the positive essence of the negative finite²⁾. As negations both determinations would lead to an abstract, undifferentiated emptiness and lifelessness, but thought seeks in them precisely the expression of fullness. And in the determination: cause of itself, it intuits activity, and with activity the absence of difference is removed. When unity is determined by infinity and activity, we are led to the two concepts which in the Spinozist system, together with substance, make up the fundamental concepts: the concept *attribute*, and the concept *mode*.

Infinity excludes limitation, for limitation negates. But limitation takes place only through what is of the same kind, not through the heterogeneous: Ea res dicitur *in suo genere finita*, quæ alia eiusdem naturæ terminari potest. Ex. gr. corpus dicitur finitum, quia aliud semper maius concipimus. At corpus non terminatur cogitatione, nec cogitatio

²⁾Æternitas = infinitas et necessitas existentiae; Eth. I, 23. dem.

³⁾In these determinations of the concept of substance we find again the traces of the genesis through which it has arisen. When substance is posited as unity of essence and existence, it is posited as the objective essence of thought distinguished from the sensible; for sensibility separates essence and existence, limits the intellect, and the intellect finds only itself again where that separation is sublated, where it affirms itself in the unity of thought and existence. In the determination of substance as causality we find again the consequence of the fact that thought, distinguished from the sensible, in order to arrive at a content, must seek this in nature; for it is from nature that the determination of causality is taken, and transferred to thought. But it will appear that it is again deprived of its distinctive conditions and distinctive significance, so that nature asserts itself only as thought, i.e. as sublated nature.

¹⁾Cf. Ep. 50. 39 ff., princ. ph. Cart. I, 11. schol., Cog. met. I, 6. Eth. I, 8.

²⁾On the relation between the infinite and the indeterminate cf. Eth. I, 8. schol. 1. II, def. 5. Ep. 29. 41. 64. Cog. met. I, 6. De int. em. p. 360.

corpore (Eth. I, def. 2.). Infinity can therefore include within itself, without being cancelled as infinity, as it were a new infinity, a multiplicity which, on account of the difference of kind, entails no limitation, and such a multiplicity becomes, as compatible with infinity, compatible with unity. It is even demanded by infinity, since everything that expresses essence and includes no negation belongs to it (Eth. I, def. 6. explic.). [47]

II. With this multiplicity, which without cancelling infinity is posited within the unity of substance, the concept of the *attribute* is given: per *attributum* intelligo id, quod intellectus de substantia percipit tanquam eiusdem essentiam constituens (Eth. I, def. 4). This definition must not be misunderstood as if the words: id, quod intellectus — — percipit, were to make the attribute a *merely subjective* conception¹⁾. The misunderstanding has, however, a great authority to lean on; I must therefore refute it more fully. Already the closing words of the definition: tanquam eiusdem essentiam constituens, contradict the subjective conception, still more the whole character of Spinozism (cf. chapter 5, the doctrine of knowledge) and definite statements of Spinoza's. If one first compares the two places in the letters where definitions of the attribute are given, one will find that in the one place (Ep. 2, written 1661, cf. Ep. 4) it is determined in essentials in the same way as the Ethics determines substance: notandum, me per *attributum* intelligere omne id, quod concipimus per se et in se, adeo ut ipsius conceptus non involvat conceptum alterius rei; — likewise, that in this letter the definition of the attribute is attached directly to the definition of God without the concept of substance coming in between¹⁾. In the [48] other place (Ep. 27, from 1663) *substance* is first defined as that, quod in se est et per se concipitur, hoc est, cujus conceptus non involvit conceptum alterius rei. Then there is added: *Idem per attributum intelligo, nisi quod attributum dicatur respectu intellectus, substantiæ certam talem naturam tribuentis*. Many places in the Ethics point to the same thing. Thus already the definition of *God* as the substance *consisting* of infinitely many attributes (*constantem infinitis attributis*) states the real unity. Likewise the expressions in Ethics I, 15. schol.: hinc conclusimus, *substantiam* extensam unum ex infinitis Dei

¹⁾To elucidate the relation between substance and attribute, the use of the determination *essentia* in Princip. phil. Cart. and Cog. metaph. may serve. It is set on the one hand as synonymous with *definitio* (pr. ph. C. II, 15. schol.) and with *conceptus*, on the other hand as synonymous with *natura* (cf. pr. ph. C. I, 4. ax. 11 not. and def. 9, with II, 15. schol.), with *vis*, qua in meo esse me conservo (pr. ph. C. I, 7. schol., Cog. met. II, 1), with *potentia* (pr. ph. C. II, 2. schol.) and with *perfectio* (Cog. met. I, c. 6), and there is talk of *essentia formalis*, i.e. objective (Cog. met. I, 2). The subjective and the objective conception are thus, in accordance with the whole character of Spinozism, in unity. In accordance with this character substance too had to be determined both as that which *is in itself* and as that which *is conceived through itself*.

¹⁾One also sees from Ep. 2 ff. that the first 4 propositions of the Ethics were originally set out as axioms, and that the series of propositions then began with the present prop. 5. Just as in the use of the concept of substance a formal deviation has taken place from the Ethics in its present form, so too the determination *accidens* is used instead of the determination *modus*, whereas Spinoza later distinguished them.

attributis esse. The proofs of propositions 10, 19 and 20 in the first book of the Ethics rest on the same presupposition. In the proof of prop. 10 the peculiarity of substance, that it can be conceived through itself, is transferred to the attribute as *constituting the essence of the former* (tanquam eius essentiam constituens). The *eternity* of substance is transferred in prop. 19. demonstr. to the attribute as that, quod divinæ substantiæ *essentiam* exprimit, hoc est, id quod ad substantiam pertinet²⁾. The same expressions are used in the proof of prop. 20, and therefore in Coroll. 2 to this proposition it can be concluded: Deum sive omnia Dei attributa esse immutabilia³⁾. It leads to the same result [49] when Eth. II, 40. schol. speaks of *essentia formalis*¹⁾ attributorum. Likewise the way in which Spinoza conceives our knowledge of the attributes (cf. Ep. 28. Eth. II, 40 schol. 2) points to their objective reality. And finally the proofs of Eth. I, 4 and 30²⁾ state expressly that it is not merely in the intellect (intellectus) that the attribute is equal to substance.

The attribute³⁾ is thus of one essence with substance; it is conceived, like substance, through itself, and is eternal and infinite. It is infinite despite the plurality of the attributes, since limitation has significance only within the same genus. It is *in suo genere infinitum*, since we can deny infinitely many attributes of it; it is not *absolute infinitum*, since to the essence of the absolutely infinite belongs everything that expresses essence and includes no negation (Eth. I, def. 6 explic.). This *ens absolute infinitum*⁴⁾ is *God*, i.e. substantia constans infinitis attributis, quorum unumquodque æternam et infinitam essentiam exprimit (def. 6). In the concept: *God*, the concept of substance has first reached its complete expression. Substance is the infinite; only in the unconditionally infinite, therefore, does it reach its concept. The infinite substance, God, must, as containing infinite reality, consist of *infinitely many* attributes (Eth. I, 9), each of which is conceived [50] by itself, but which do not therefore constitute several beings or several different substances: Id enim est de natura substantiæ, ut unumquodque eius attributorum per se concipiatur, quandoquidem omnia, quæ habet, attributa, simul in ipsa semper fuerunt, nec unum ab alio produci potuit; sed unumquodque realitatem sive esse substantiæ

²⁾cf. the reference to prop. 11 in the proof of prop. 21 in the first book of the Ethics.

³⁾With this one may compare princ. ph. C. I. ax. 4, where it is said that substance has more reality than an accident or a modus, but not that it has more reality than the attribute.

¹⁾Formalis means in Spinoza and the philosophers of that time the same as in our philosophical terminology: objective. What we call subjective was then called objective, e.g. esse objectivum, i.e. the essence of things as objectified in representation. In some of the scholastics, e.g. Occam, subjective (i.e. existing as subject, substance) conversely denotes what we call objective.

²⁾cf. Cog. met. I, c. 2. pr. ph. C. I, 7 schol.

³⁾The designation attribute is used more loosely not only in many places in Spinoza's earlier writings and in the Hebrew Grammar (e.g. C. 33), but also in the Ethics; thus when res, aliquid and the like are called attributes (Eth. II, 40. Schol. 1), and when it is said (Eth. IV. 37. schol. 2): apparet, iustum et iniustum, — notiones esse extrinsecas, non autem attributa, quæ mentis naturam explicant.

⁴⁾ens absolute indeterminatum. Ep. 41.

exprimit. Longe ergo abest, ut absurdum sit, uni substantiæ plura attributa tribuere; quin nihil in natura clarius, quam quod unumquodque *ens* sub aliquo attributo debeat concipi, et quo plus realitatis aut esse habeat, eo plura attributa, quæ et necessitatem sive æternitatem et infinitatem exprimunt, habeat, et consequenter nihil etiam clarius, quam quod ens absolute infinitum necessario definiendum (ut def. 6. tradidimus) ens, quod constat infinitis attributis, quorum unumquodque æternam et infinitam certam essentiam exprimit (Eth. I, 10, schol.).

At this point, however, an essential difficulty arises. The different attributes are conceived through themselves, are in themselves, without dependence on one another, without mutual limitation. In the single attribute there thus lies nothing that points to the others; it is closed in itself, contains a reality infinite in its kind, and this: in its kind, denotes no comparison. If one proceeds from the attribute¹⁾, one does not therefore arrive at a unity of the several attributes in substance; one comes in any case to conceive [51] the attribute immediately as substance, but then of course as substance with *one* attribute. Nor, by taking one's starting point from the thought of the absolute substance, will one of necessity arrive at the *plurality* of the attributes. The absolutely infinite, absolutely perfect being must, as containing infinite reality or being, have infinite attributes, Spinoza concludes. But in the premises there lies, if one disregards Spinoza's presupposition, the absolute difference of the attributes, only the exclusion of negation, and since negation, strictly taken, becomes equal to limitation, and limitation has significance only within the single attribute, the inference would lead only to the attribute in its infinity without any limitation, not to infinitely many attributes. If one imagines another historical presupposition for Spinozism, the inference could have led to positing thought as the sole attribute, so that the others became forms of thought, or extension as the sole one, so that thought became a form of it. The independence of the attributes in their multiplicity is an assumption that rests on the historical presupposition of Spinozism, on the dualism between thought and extension, whose unity was demanded. The two attributes, thought and extension (cf. chapter 5), confirm themselves immediately to the human mind, since this is corporis idea, and although already in the fact that the

¹⁾From Spinoza's standpoint one must no doubt say that it is unwarranted for thought to separate the attribute from substance, since they must immediately be seen in unity, and that thought, when it conceives substance as separated from the attributes, conceives it under a new, self-contradictory attribute, that of indeterminacy. But however much one sees the matter from his standpoint, the result remains the same, and the difficulty only takes another form. In the doctrine of knowledge (cf. chapter 5) we shall see that idea corporis and idea ideæ express one thing and are both in the mind. With one idea the two attributes are thus thought in their difference. But the objective essence of extension as different from thought is not thought; it expresses its actiosa essentia through an operation parallel with thought, which remains independent and is only ideally taken up into the mind. Here, therefore, dualism returns.

body can become an ideatum there lies a sublation of the abstract opposition, they are posited, by virtue of that dualism, as absolutely different, so that each is conceived by itself, and they are in unity only in so far as they express substance, hence in so far as their difference is abstracted from, not through themselves as these determinate ones, such that their difference is preserved. But since a *plurality* of attributes has been posited, [52] the infinity of substance must express itself in the infinity of plurality, the *infinity* of number, and the attributes are posited as *infinitely many*¹⁾.

The determination of the multiplicity of the attributes is thus conditioned by Spinoza's historical presuppositions, but the task had nonetheless to become that of bringing this determination into harmony with the unity of substance. In the rebuttal of objections given in the passage cited above, the presupposition of the several attributes is taken as starting point, and from it their independence is inferred; but the possibility of their unity despite the difference is not demonstrated. Nor does this happen through the theory of the parallelism between the series of modifications that belong to the different attributes (Eth. II, 7); for this difference remains standing as a presupposition, which is as little led back to a unity as it has issued from one. It is not sufficient (with Feuerbach) to say that precisely in that spirit and matter are conceived each by itself and through itself, in that both are independent in their concept, they express not themselves, but substance, God, and, since both are substance, they express only this, that they are substance, so that what is affirmative in them is only substance *purely as such*, which is indifferent to whether it is spirit or matter²⁾, and for which they are therefore both, *in so far as* they are something *determinate*, something *different* from each other, and in so far as one looks only at this determinateness *as* determinateness, not at the fact that it is and expresses substance, only attributes, properties, moments, that constitute the idea of God. — For in this way the peculiarity of the attribute is conceived as separable from substance, hence as something vanishing; substance, which becomes indifferent to the difference, either [53] becomes an abstraction, a *notio universalis*, really a subjective imagination (cf. chapter 5), or the difference becomes something subjective and substance indeterminate. If the difference is conceived in this inessentiality, one cannot even say that the determinacies as moments constitute the idea of God; for they become merely something subjective, the idea something real.

A closer grounding and development is, however, not to be found in Spinoza. Being led, in the endeavour to give the concept of substance fullness, by the presuppositions of

¹⁾The relation between the infinite number of the attributes and the duality of attributes that is expressed in the human being, together with the difficulty that arises at this point, will be touched on in chapter 5.

²⁾In Spinoza's conception the *peculiarity* of the attribute affirms itself precisely immediately to thought.

his time to seek this in the infinite multiplicity of the attributes, he has only sought a determination that made it possible to conceive the single ones as infinite, and this he has found in the peculiarly conceived concept of limitation, and in the distinction between what is infinite in its kind and the unconditionally infinite. He has next given the proof that, *on the presupposition of* the infinitely many attributes in the one substance, these had to be conceived in and through themselves, mutually independent. But the taking up of plurality into unity, the compatibility of the independent differences in substance, whose essence is expressed *only* in the attributes, he has not demonstrated, and, as will appear later, could not demonstrate. This is an incompleteness in his system, which the historical exposition has to point out and to illuminate, not to remove.

III. Substance, which in its unity includes the multiplicity of the attributes, now receives its further determination through the *concept of causality*. Substance is *causa sui*; this is not merely an expression of the negative fact that it is not effected by another, but has *positive* significance, since it determines God's essence as activity. This shows itself in that *essentia* is conceived as one with *potentia* (Eth. I, 34: *potentia Dei, qua ipse et omnia sunt et agunt, est ipsa ipsius essentia*) and as containing *vis agendi* (Eth. IV, 26 dem.); it appears likewise from the expression: *actuosa essentia* (Eth. II, 3 schol. cf. Cog. metaph. II, c. 11), from the conception of the attributes, thought and extension, as active, from the important Proposition 16 in the first book of the Ethics ("ex necessitate divinæ naturæ infinita infinitis modis sequi debent")¹⁾, from the proof of prop. 36 in the same book, from the concept *idea ideæ* (cf. chapter 5), and from the doctrine of the affects, which rests throughout on the view of activity. [54]

When the determination *causa sui* receives positive significance, there is posited in the identity of what effects and what is effected a constantly vanishing, or rather *eternally vanished*, difference, and through this difference as difference we arrive at the third Spinozist fundamental concept, the concept *modus*²⁾. "Per *modum* intelligo substantiæ affectiones, sive id quod in alio est, per quod etiam concipitur"³⁾. (Eth. I, def. 5). Since *modus* is determined as being *in another* and *conceived through another*, it is determined as *posited by another*, by that in which it is and through which it is conceived (Eth. I, 16. Coroll. 1, 25). Determined as effect, *modus* is different from substance, its cause, and when it is now determined by a plural (*substantiæ affectiones*), and is

¹⁾Actiones, quæ ex ipsius [Dei] naturæ necessitate consequuntur. Eth. IV. App. Cap. 4.

²⁾As synonyms are used: *modi*, *modificationes*, *affectiones*. From *modus* Spinoza distinguishes *accidens* (Cog. met. I, c. 1), which in Descartes is synonymous with it and is still used thus by Spinoza himself in Ep. 4. The designation *affectio* is used in Cog. met. I, c. 3 as a synonym of *attribute*.

³⁾Modificationes are: Id, quod in alio est, et quarum conceptus a conceptu rei, in qua sunt, formatur. Eth. I, 8. schol. 2.

brought together with the determination: *single things* (*res particulares nihil sunt nisi Dei attributorum affectiones sive modi, quibus Dei attributa certo et determinato modo exprimuntur*. Eth. I, 25. Coroll.), then this difference, since what is posited by substance and is in substance is determined by plurality and limitedness, seems to become an absolute one, and to acquire retroactive force to overturn the conception of the concept of substance.

The determination: singularity and limitation, leads us to the problem of *the relation* [55] *of the infinite to the finite*, and the question might at first seem to have to be put thus: how does the infinite in Spinoza produce a finitude, how does the *transition* take place from the former to the latter? But in this form the problem has already been given a skewed position, since, forgetting the system's fundamental thought, reality is granted to the finite. If the fundamental concept, the system's starting point, is held fast, then the task must on the contrary become precisely this: to conceive the relation of the infinite to the finite in such a way that it is seen that there can be no question of a transition from the former to the latter, *that the finite is not as finite*, that nothing is without substance, and that the very knowledge of the nothingness of the finite does not come to be — hence is not subject to the form of finitude; — but *is eternal*⁴⁾.

It might seem that the determination of substance as *causality*, of God as *causa omnium rerum* (Eth. I, 16. Cor. 1), would have to settle the problem of the being of the finite in the opposite way. *Real* causality includes a temporal relation, and with time finitude is given, if not independently subsisting finite things. But Spinoza evades this consequence partly through the concept *causa sui*, in which causality is as it were bent back upon itself; partly by laying down that God is the cause of all things *eo sensu* (in the same sense) in which he is called *causa sui* (Eth. I, 25. schol.), for which reason he must be determined not as *causa transiens*, i.e. as acting over upon another, but as *causa immanens*⁵⁾, as indwelling cause (Eth. I, 18, cf. Ep. 21); partly, finally, indirectly, by developing the difference that, on the ordinary conception of the causal relation, arises between cause and effect, with respect both to essence and to existence (Eth. I, [56] 17. schol.)⁶⁾ — which, if finite things were conceived as independently subsisting, would lead to the sublation of the concept of substance, and, applied to the concept: *causa sui*,

⁴⁾With regard to the problem of *finite things* cf. Eth. II, 8. Cor. 9. Cor. Ep. 58. Pr. phil. Cartes. I, 5. 7. Cog. metaph. I, c. 2. II, c. 4. 7).

⁵⁾*agentem sive causam immanentem.* Gr. hebr. c. XII. — In the Index to the Opp. posth. the determinations *causa immanens* and *natura naturans* are put side by side (see below).

⁶⁾That the argumentation in this place is polemical against the ordinary conception of the concept of causality is seen from other places, e.g. "God has also formaliter (objectively) something in common with finite things." Ep. 4. cf. Eth. I, 25. Coroll. (Prop. 10 in the 2nd Book of the Ethics, which concerns the *single* modus, has no application here.)

to absurdities.

If we look more closely at the significance of the concept of causality in Spinoza, we also see that the peculiarity of its conception cuts off that consequence. *Causality coincides for Spinoza with logical consequence*¹⁾: “Everything proceeds with necessity or follows always with the same necessity from God’s infinite nature, *in the same way* in which it follows from eternity to eternity from the nature of the triangle that its three angles are equal to two right angles” (Eth. I, 17 schol.); — and in the 16th Proposition of the 1st Book cited above the proof is drawn from the fact that from the definition of every thing (i.e. from the essence of the thing) several properties follow with necessity; since, therefore, from the absolutely infinite attributes of the divine nature, each of which expresses an essentiality infinite in its kind, infinitely much must follow in infinite modifications.

Through this logical conception of causality the temporal determination is removed²⁾; the relation comes to lie within the element of eternity, which is not determined by time, measure or number, the determinations of finitude and of imagination (Ep. 29).

While the concept of causality, on Spinoza’s conception, thus did not lead to finitude, finitude is likewise excluded when in causality we press the concept of substance as the infinite causa sui. Causality is in unity with the essence of substance; through it this essence realizes itself. But since the effect of the causal substance is substance [57] itself, the infinite causality is exhausted in the infinite effect; there remains no room for an effecting of something finite, and in the essence of substance there is found no point of attachment for it. What follows from the essence of substance follows with necessity; but necessity includes infinity¹⁾. And since substance is determined as the infinite, absolutely real being, which is unity of essence and existence, there remains as little room for an actual existence separated from it as for an essence separated from it. Even if the existence of the modification, in Spinoza’s usage, is determined not by eternity but by duratio²⁾, which is the expression of the existence that follows not from the essence of the thing but from the nature of the cause, yet duratio, on account of the infinity of the cause, is to be thought as infinite when the effect is seen in its truth, i.e. in

¹⁾Spinoza can therefore also designate logical consequences as actiones. In this conception too it is confirmed that the Spinozist substance is the objectified essence of the intellect. Therefore in the doctrine of knowledge, too, agere is posited as equal to Intelligere (Eth. IV, 24. dem.).

²⁾God’s priority is a priority of causality; Pr. phil. Cart. I, 12. Coroll 4.

¹⁾cf. Eth. I, 7, demonstr. with I, 8. schol. 1.

²⁾*Duratio est indefinita existendi continuatio* (Eth. II. def. 5). Eth. II, 45. schol.: durationem, hoc est existentiam, quatenus abstracte concipitur, et tanquam quædam quantitatis species. With regard to the relation between æternitas and duratio cf. Eth. I, def. 8. explic., prop. 23. dem., Cog. met. I, c. 4. II, c. 1. 2; with regard to the relation between duratio and essentia Eth. I, 24. dem., IV. præf.

its unity with substance, and only when it is separated from this by an abstraction do the determinations of finitude come forth (Ep. 29).

Spinoza's conception of these determinations of finitude leads to the same result: limitation, plurality, divisibility, time, number and measure. *Limitation* is conceived only as negation (Ep. 50); it therefore becomes unthinkable when one proceeds from substance (the attribute); for since limitation can take place only through what is of the same essence, it would have to take place through the attribute itself, and this, as what limits, would have to be conceived as the negation of what is limited, hence as its own negation (Ep. 50). Limitation is therefore excluded by the concept of substance; and [58] when it is seen from the standpoint of a hypothetically assumed finite, it becomes, as something merely negative, something vanishing.

The determination *plurality* does not lie in the definition of the thing, but presupposes an external cause (cf. Eth. I, 14 schol. Ep. 41). If one follows this proposition back, then, as the series of causes is led back to the first cause, the unity of substance will exclude plurality, hence finitude. — The determinations *divisibility, time, number, measure*, which arise when duration and quantity are separated by an abstraction from substance and from "the eternal order" (cf. Ep. 29), lead to contradictions that cannot be resolved: an infinite series that can form no unity, an infinity of parts that cannot manage to make up a whole, a *greater and lesser* infinity. But these contradictions are removed when the representation of the finite, single things is removed; only the reality that is ascribed to these as finite calls those forth.

But while the consideration of all these concepts thus leads away from an existing finite, it might seem that Spinoza himself has made an attempt to derive the finite from the infinite in Propositions 21–23 of the first book of the Ethics. They read: "Everything that follows from the absolute nature of one of God's attributes must always have existed and existed as infinite, or is eternal and infinite through this attribute." — "What follows from one of God's attributes, in so far as it is modified by such a modification as exists with necessity and as infinite through the attribute, must also exist with necessity and as infinite." — "Every *modus* that exists with necessity and as infinite must with necessity have followed either from the absolute nature of one of God's attributes, or from an attribute modified by a modification that exists both with necessity and as infinite." — A kind of gradation is given here: the *attribute*; that which is *immediately produced by God* (immediate a Deo productum), and *that which is produced mediante infinita quadam* [59] *modificatione* (cf. Ep. 65 and Spinoza's answer in Ep. 66, where as examples of the second kind are adduced, under the attribute of thought: *intellectus absolute infinitus*, under that

of extension: *motion and rest*; as an example of the third kind: *facies totius universi*, quæ, quamvis infinitis modis variet, manet semper eadem). But the gradation remains within infinity, and if one compares with these propositions the 28th proposition of the same book: “Every single thing, or every thing that is finite and has a limited existence, cannot exist or be determined to activity except by another cause which is likewise finite and has a limited existence; and this cause in turn cannot exist or be determined to activity unless it is determined to existence and activity by another, which is likewise finite and has a limited existence, and so on to infinity” — then not only is the derivation not carried from the infinite to the finite; *but such a transition is expressly posited as impossible*, since with the finite the series that runs on to infinity and is never concluded is given. If one proceeds, therefore, from the infinite, one arrives only at the infinite, never at the finite; if one proceeds — by a hypothesis — from the finite, one arrives, in the infinite series, only at the finite, never at the infinite³⁾.

With the determination *modus* we have thus not yet stepped out of infinity. Already in the designation: *modus* or *modificatio*, there is given a being, not in itself, but in another, whose affection it is. This other is the infinite immanent cause, substance. And through closer determinations it is now secured that *modus*, although being in the [60] infinite, shall not by its heterogeneity with it come to be *outside* the infinite and thus cancel it as such. The intermediate determinations by which Spinoza seeks to remove the incompatibility within the infinite are chiefly three: the concept of *infinite modi*, the conception of *modus under the form of eternity and necessity* (*sub specie æternitatis et necessitatis*), and finally the conception of *modi* as a whole, as a *universal individual*, as *natura naturata*.

If one puts the question thus: how can modifications, i.e. determinations, limitations, be thought in the infinite? then the concept: *infinite modi*, pushes the answer a step back. When infinite *modi* are laid down, the question takes the form: how can *modi* be thought as infinite? The answer to this is prepared by the conception of *modus* under the form of eternity, and is attempted decisively in the conception of *modi as a whole*. When reason *thinks* *modus*, it conceives it not under the determinations of time and space, — which are the determinations of imagination, but under the form of eternity and necessity, in God, i.e. according to its truth.¹⁾ But when it is conceived thus, it is conceived not

³⁾Spinoza's conception of the relation of the different kinds of knowledge to one another leads to the same consequence (cf. especially *Eth.* V, 28). The clear and distinct knowledge that comprehends under the form of eternity and necessity (*sub specie æterni*) cannot arise from inadequate knowledge, whose object is the imagined finite, but only from another clear and distinct knowledge. Here is the same express denial of the transition, which will become evident when the nature and kinds of knowledge have been developed (cf. chapter 5 and chapter 8.).

¹⁾For Spinoza the expressions: *res in se spectata*, — *vere spectata*, — *ad Deum relata*, are synonymous.

as single and finite, but in its immediate connection with its eternal infinite cause; its definition becomes the definition of substance (Ep. 29), its existence essential, necessary, infinite existence (Eth. II, 45. schol.). Necessary existence conflicts with the essence of finitude; through the conception of modi as necessary and eternal one is therefore led to the conception of the totality of the modifications as *infinite unity*. Limitation is negation, not something positive; what, when a finite is presupposed, separates modi from one another in representation is, seen in thought, something vanishing; but when [61] this negative is removed, the closed unity is posited. This gives the determination of the *universal individual* (Eth. II, 13. Lemma 7, schol.; cf. chapter 4). This universal individual is *natura naturata*¹⁾ as a whole (Cog. metaph. II. c. 7. 9.). One cannot say of it that it is *composite*, one cannot ascribe *parts* to it; for parts would presuppose a subsisting limitation, composition the reality of limitation; but the limit is here posited precisely as the non-real.

Through these intermediate determinations infinity is upheld, finitude and its forms excluded from substance. Substance is, as *causa sui*, *the unity of natura naturans and natura naturata*. As cause it is *naturans*, as effect *naturata*; but in substance, whose essence is eternity, this difference has eternally vanished: limitation, finitude, time, number, measure, are no reality, only a semblance, which cannot even be said to vanish, but, seen in its truth, only *to have vanished*.

The interest of infinity is thus upheld; but the other interest, which brought forth the determination modus: that of conceiving substance as what is infinitely full in itself, not in a resting fullness, but in one eternally producing itself, not indeed in such a way that there could be question in its element of a development, but yet of an activity,²⁾ — is not [62] satisfied, and this interest, which is thought's, philosophy's own interest, brings forth inconsistencies in Spinoza which cannot be removed. In the indeterminate infinity spirit affirms its abstract-universal essence, denies itself in its singularity; but its aim is self-affirmation. The act of *philosophizing* has reality only through singularity, only through the fact that human thought does not immediately melt together with the infinite. If infinity is held fast in that abstract form, then the being of the finite in representation too,

¹⁾*Natura naturata* (the expression was already used by Giordano Bruno and Hobbes) Spinoza determines (Eth. I, 29 schol.) by its opposition to *natura naturans*. The latter is: id, quod in se est et per se concipitur, sive talia substantiæ attributa, quæ æternam et infinitam essentiam expriment; hoc est — Deus, quatenus ut causa libera consideratur. — *Natura naturata* is: id omne, quod ex necessitate Dei naturæ sive uniuscuiusque Dei attributorum sequitur, hoc est, omnes Dei attributorum modi, quatenus considerantur ut res, quæ in Deo sunt et quæ sine Deo nec esse nec concipi possunt.

²⁾Therefore Spinoza can speak of an *infinitus amor*, quo Deus seipsum amat (Eth. V, 36). For this concept the view of activity is the presupposition. (Cf. chapter 6 and chapter 8.)

however decisively it is posited as semblance, as essenceless, becomes incomprehensible.¹⁾

By positing activity, and by letting infinitely much follow from it in infinite modifications, Spinoza sought to escape the emptiness of abstraction, and to give thought a content and thinking a possibility. But the fullness vanished in the same moment it was posited; it became a fleeting semblance, since that which was to give the fullness became a semblance. The finite things could be posited only hypothetically, as a semblance that casts its reflection into itself, for they exist only in human representation, which itself, as finite, is something vanishing. Nothingness is mirrored in nothingness. Only when the limit receives a reality and thereby the modifications subsistence can substance receive a content, and therefore such a significance of the limit must come forth in Spinoza, precisely through that inner conflict in thought, and even if it is again dismissed, it nonetheless asserts a kind of validity. Determinations must be sought for what does not immediately merge into substance. This cannot, even if it is determined negatively, since substance is determined as infinite reality, be wholly removed by thought, for thought would thereby negate itself. When substance is thought, thought has as it were the [63] *memory* of finitude; this must force itself forward again and thereby the inconsistencies arise.

These, therefore, Spinoza has not been able to avoid either. It is already inconsistent to occupy thought with finitude in its apparent subsistence; for through this very occupation with it the finite receives a significance it could not receive according to the fundamental concepts.¹⁾ But the inconsistency comes forth more definitely when there is talk of a *difference in the finite*; for the old Aristotelian proposition: τοῦ μὴ ὄντος οὐκ ἔστιν εἶδος, always retains its validity. The difference is posited as a difference of *degree* in the being of the finite; but such a difference of degree is, even if by holding fast the proposition that all limitation is negation one forces it back into being merely quantitative, nonetheless sufficient not to let the finite vanish entirely. It is likewise an inconsistency when there is talk of: the *order* in nature, the series of causes, ordo et constitutio totius naturæ, series et ordo causarum, which are distinguished from leges naturæ æternæ; for in this *series* the single things assert a significance *as* single. It is an inconsistency when from the active eternal laws an infinitely *manifold* is derived as consequence (Eth. I, 16). It is an inconsistency when it is said of natura naturata, which is conceived as unity, that it is one “although its parts vary in infinite ways” (quamvis partes eius infinitis modis

¹⁾It is this contradiction on which already the Eleatics stumbled. When all non-being is excluded, so that only being is, and being now as the One embraces thought, the existence of the non-being in thought as semblance becomes inexplicable, precisely because thought is posited as one with being.

¹⁾Yet here the dialectical element comes forth again, that this significance, as resting on time, ceases again to be significance with the vanishing of time as something non-real.

variant); for even if limitation and change are posited as constantly sublated, they are nonetheless posited again in order to be sublated. It is an inconsistency when there is talk of *res particulares æternæ*, of *æterni cogitandi modi*, which are determined as parts of *infinitus intellectus*; for through eternity the limitedness that lies in the concepts: [64] singularity and part, is sublated. It is an inconsistency when Spinoza ascribes *positive* significance to *modi* for the knowledge of God (Eth. V, 24); for although this is not to be understood as if experience were to supplement an originally abstract idea of God, but that the idea of God eternally revealed to us comes to consciousness in its fullness and makes the vanishing imperfect knowledge a semblance, yet, since positive significance for this full concept is ascribed to *modi as modi*, that which makes them *modi*, the limit, receives positive reality. It is finally an inconsistency to speak of a knowledge of God and an *amor intellectualis* issuing from it in the human mind determined as a *modus*, albeit as an eternal *modus*; for in this determination the heterogeneous, limitedness and infinity, are tied together (cf. chapter 9).

These contradictions thus remain in Spinoza's doctrine of the modifications. They are not accidental, but necessary consequences of the fact that *human* thought thinks the concept of substance. The inconsistency of ascribing significance to the finite, *if only in order to sublate it again*, is the condition for there being any philosophizing, for thought not coming to a halt at once in the immobility of abstraction.¹⁾

¹⁾How much this problem occupied Spinoza, and how clearly he was conscious of the degree to which his conception of the finite must be a stumbling-block for his contemporaries, is seen everywhere in his writings, and especially in the evasive manner in which he expresses himself on it still in the last years of his life, and toward the one of his friends who seems to have understood him best (cf. Ep. 70–72). Just as for Spinoza substance is the real starting point that is no longer abandoned, so the finite is a hypothetical starting point that is constantly *only* abandoned; but precisely herein lies a contradiction.

Chapter Three.

The Immediate Consequences of Spinoza's Conception of the Concept of Substance.

The constituting determinations of the Spinozist concept of substance: *infinity* and *causality*, must become the decisive ones for the further unfolding of the system. The concept of substance was, after all, for Spinoza the all-embracing concept; its basic stamp must therefore be found again in every one of his thoughts. In the following chapters this will appear in the more special developments; at this point it will be shown with respect to the general metaphysical relations.

We saw that the concept of *substance* in its completeness coincided with the concept of *God*, and that *God* was determined as the absolutely infinite being. When infinity is now strictly held fast, there is excluded first and foremost from the concept of God every representation that could make it finite in an anthropomorphic way. Therefore there are excluded from it the determinations: *intellect, will, desire, love*¹⁾ etc., because they do not express the absolutely infinite attribute of thought, but only a determinate modification of it (cf. chapter 5). Therefore the fundamental Christian representation of God's becoming man is excluded, since on Spinoza's conception it is as self-contradictory that God, the infinite substance, should have taken on the finite nature of man as that the circle should have taken on the nature of the square (Ep. 21).

The necessarily existing active infinite (*causa sui*) must act according to the necessity [66] of its essence, since outside it there is nothing that could determine it. This necessity, as inner, is *free* necessity (*libera necessitas*, Ep. 62),¹⁾ freedom; God is *causa libera* (Eth. I, def. 7). As one with necessity this freedom is not a *liberum decretum*, not indifference (cf. Ep. 60); God's power is not, like the power of kings, arbitrariness; it is bound by the law

¹⁾Love as *passio* is naturally excluded from God. On the other hand, in the 5th Book of the Ethics there can be talk of an active amor, quo Deus se ipsum amat, and of which man's amor intellectualis Dei is "a part." This love is to be paralleled with infinitus intellectus (cf. chapter 5), since it is idea Dei seen from another side.

¹⁾Since this necessity becomes an inner one, God's very essence as expressing itself in activity, it does not become fatalism, since the latter separates fatum from God (Ep. 23. 49. 62.).

of his own essence (tr. polit. II, 7). The relation to time, the separation between essence, intellect and will, which a *liberum arbitrium* presupposes, conflicts with eternity, by which God's essence is determined. The essence is the power; the necessary existence gives the necessary activity. But the concept of necessity is sharpened by what was the deeper ground of Spinoza's thought. Substance is the objectified essence of the intellect; but this essence must, according to Spinoza's historical presupposition, be determined by the abstract expression for that in which the intellect has its content, i.e. by the abstract concept of nature, and therefore the necessary causality is determined in such a way that the *concept of purpose* is excluded. The denial of this concept, which is decisive for the system's character, is no doubt motivated from the concept of God's perfection (the concept of infinity), but what is the deeper ground of the polemic, and what conditions the one-sided conception of the concept of purpose,²⁾ is the unconscious influence of the concept of nature on Spinoza's thought.

[67] In the Appendix to the 1st Book of the Ethics Spinoza develops the psychological origin of this concept. The representation of God as acting according to a purpose, he says, is grounded only in human prejudices, which arise from the fact that men are born without knowledge of the causes of things, but with appetite for what is useful to them and with consciousness of this appetite. The consciousness of appetite, combined with unconsciousness of its grounds, calls forth the fancy of human *freedom*, and through this fancy the consciousness of appetite is transformed into a representation of acting according to a purpose, and this representation now governs, as conclusive, the conception of things, and since these are viewed from man's standpoint, and at the same time as independent of man, it is transferred to the divine, despite all the absurd consequences and despite all the contradictions that arise from this representation. But the transference of the concept of purpose to God turns nature upside down. For that which in reality is cause is regarded as effect and conversely; what by its essence is the earlier is made the later, what is the highest and most perfect the most imperfect,¹⁾ and finally, — what is decisive, — an imperfection is thereby ascribed to God; for when he acts for the sake of a purpose, he necessarily desires something which he is not in possession of. (Eth. I, 36. schol. IV, præf.).

The exclusion of the concept of purpose meets with the exclusion of the anthropomorphic determinations in removing the representations that underlie the view of a

²⁾In the representation that God should act *sub ratione boni* Spinoza sees only a subjection of God to a *fatum*, since it "posits something outside God which God in his acting has before him as a model and strives after as a goal" (Eth. I, 33. schol. 2).

¹⁾The more immediately something proceeded from God, the more perfect it had to be posited as being, whereas on that representation, conversely, the last became the most perfect.

personal God. In its place enters the *necessity of the power of nature*, which also becomes the form of thought, and the significance of this concept of necessity for Spinoza's whole system he himself states when in Ep. 21 he calls it *præcipuum fundamentum eorum omnium, quæ in tractatu, quem edere destinaveram* (the Ethics), *habentur*, and in his summarizing survey of the first book of the Ethics (in the Scholium to prop. 36) puts the [68] determination: *quod [Deus] necessario existat*, which is supplemented by: *quod ex sola suæ naturæ necessitate sit et agat*, before all the others.¹⁾

If we pass from *natura naturans* over to *natura naturata*, we find again the stamp of the same fundamental thought. The necessity of causality, which expresses the essence of the cause, must express itself in the effect, which only has its being in the cause. When the *infinity* of substance entailed that everything that is had to be in God, and could not be conceived without him (Eth. I, 15); that the single things had to be conceived as affections or *modi* of God's attributes, by which these are expressed in a determinate, limited way (Eth. I, 25 Coroll.); that God is not only the efficient cause of the existence of things, but also of their essence (Eth. I, 25); then it lies therein that God was called the cause of all things in *the same sense* as he was called *causa sui*, that every determination to activity in the thing is a determinedness by God (Eth. I, 26); that, since God's acting is in unity with the necessity of his essence, there can be in nature nothing contingent (Eth. I, 29); that things could not have been produced by God in any other way or in any other order than they have been produced (Eth. I, 33), and that all that we conceive as being in God's power must necessarily be (Eth. I, 35). And in this existence held together by the bond of necessity no independent starting point for an acting can form itself; there can be no question of an individual *freedom*, of freedom of choice (cf. Ep. 62), any more than of contingency and possibility. These representations have their origin only in the imperfection of the human faculty of knowledge. Validity for things belongs to the concepts of *necessity* and *impossibility* (although the latter, as mere negation, naturally cannot be an affection of a being — *entis affectio*. Cog. met. I. c. 3). For a thing is called [69] *necessary*,¹⁾ either with respect to its essence or with respect to its cause. For a thing's existence follows with necessity either from its own essence or definition, or from a given efficient cause (Eth. I, 33. schol. 1). The opposite of the necessary is the *impossible*, a determination we use when either the essence (the definition) contains a contradiction or when there is no external cause that is determined to produce the thing. On the

¹⁾Eth. IV, præf: *æternum illud et infinitum ens, quod Deum seu naturam appellamus, eadem qua existit necessitate agit.*

¹⁾Necessity thus includes, in its double significance, freedom and compulsion, and one can speak of a *libera* and a *coacta necessitas* (Ep. 62, cf. 58. 60. Cog. met. I, c. 3).

other hand the designations: *the contingent* and *the possible*, express only a defect in our knowledge. For when, considering merely a thing's essence, we find nothing that with necessity affirms or denies its existence, we call it *contingent*; *possible* we call it when, looking to the causes by which it would have to be produced, we do not know whether they are determined to produce it (Eth. IV, def. 3 and 4).²⁾

Just as little as the determinations: contingency, possibility and freedom, can those determinations find application to *natura naturata* which do not express it in its necessary connection with its cause, but only in its contingent relation to human imagination. Therefore such determinations are excluded as order and confusion, good and evil, perfection and imperfection, beauty and ugliness; and such determinations as are not "notiones castæ, quæ naturam, ut in se est, explicant", but "notiones ex vulgi usu factæ", [70] which merely express nature as it is referred to the human senses, e.g. visible and invisible, cold and warm, fluid and solid and the like (Ep. 6). In nature everything proceeds with eternal necessity and with the same perfection from God's necessary essence; nothing belongs to any *modus* but what lies in its concept, and this concept is determined not by the contingent, untrue relation to us, but by the necessary, true relation to God (cf. Eth. II, 32. Ep. 58). The closer development of this will be given in chapter 5.

If, finally, we pass from *natura naturata* conceived in its true relation to the divine, in which, on account of the inconsistencies in Spinoza developed in the previous chapter, it has nonetheless not been possible to avoid bringing in determinations that strictly speaking are excluded by its concept, over to *natura naturata* separated in abstraction from its cause, to the infinite series of the hypothetically held-fast finite, then we find here again the determination of necessity. The detached finite in its limited existence has not in itself a determining ground to be and to act, but must be determined to it by another. But this other becomes here, in the domain of the finite, another finite, which again demands another finite cause, and so on to infinity (Eth. I, 28). Through this abstract conception of the finite, therefore, the determining of things by God (cf. the proof of the cited proposition) is conceived as their determining of one another, running on in an infinite series.¹⁾ At this point the system takes on the character of a strict determinism; but it is easily seen that determinism in Spinoza must acquire an essentially different significance than in the systems in which a real existence is ascribed

²⁾Cog. metaph. I, c. 3. *Res possibilis* — dicitur, quum eius causam efficientem quidem intelligimus, attamen an causa determinata sit ignoramus. — Si autem ad rei essentiam simpliciter, non vero ad eius causam attendimus, illam *contingentem* dicemus — — quia ex parte essentiae nullam in ipsa reperimus necessitatem existendi — — neque etiam implicantiam sive impossibilitatem. In the Ethics I, 33. schol. 1. the expressions are used as synonyms.

¹⁾Determinedness becomes in finite things a *finite* determinedness, hence not by God, but by something finite.

to the single. Since the single, conceived in its truth, is conceived in the infinite, the determinedness of the one finite by the other, coming from without, is transformed into its determining by the infinite, which is its true essence. Determinism thus becomes a merely apparent one, and it will appear at a later place (in chapter 6) that the same holds [71] of the egoism that becomes a consequence of the conception of the unity of essence and power in the single as well; for since the limit of singularity is something merely negative, that which constitutes egoism vanishes.

The representation of necessity as *external* compulsion is thus connected with the untrue representation of a finite subsisting for itself; when this representation gives way to the true idea of the infinite, external necessity becomes an *internal* one, becomes freedom, i.e. determination by the law of its own essence; the causal relation in substance, its relation to itself as *causa sui*, embraces every relation of necessity, just as we saw above that the concept of substance included the modifications within itself. In God, the only *causa libera* (Eth. I, 17. Coroll. 2), the single *modi*, conceived under the form of eternity, in their unity with him, receive their freedom (cf. the 5th Book of the Ethics: *de libertate humana*). The problem of the finite is here the same as in the previous chapter; the difficulties that remain here follow immediately from what was developed there.

Chapter Four.

Spinoza's Concept of Nature.

When one speaks in Spinoza of a concept of nature, as distinct from the concept of substance, it must be remembered, as was developed in the second chapter, that this distinction is a vanishing one, an eternally sublated one. Substance as causal posits as effect *natura naturata*, but in this it posits not another, but itself; as cause of it, it is *causa sui*, unity of what effects and what is effected, and this unity is expressed in that the same designation determines cause and effect, *natura naturans* and *natura naturata*.

Nature becomes the common name; God and nature become synonyms. "We have [72] shown that nature does not act according to a purpose," thus Spinoza refers back to what was developed in Eth. I, 36 schol., where this is proved with respect to God. "Æternum illud et infinitum ens, quod *Deum seu naturam* appellamus, eadem qua existit necessitate

agit" (Eth. IV. præf.) – "Ipsa *Dei sive naturæ* potentia" (Eth. IV, 4. dem.). – "Cognitionem unionis, quam mens cum *tota natura* habet" (De intell. emend. pag. 360). – "Ex *natura*, sub quovis attributo considerata, infinita sequi" (Eth. III, 2. schol. cf. Ep. 21. 58)¹⁾. In these quotations, therefore, *natura* denotes that which embraces all attributes, the whole of existence, and produces itself; its concept is not restricted to what we call nature in opposition to spirit, even if the name bears traces of the significance that nature as nature had for Spinoza's conception.

In nature, conceived as synonymous with *causa sui*, as unity of *natura naturans* and *natura naturata*, there are now included (cf. chapter 2) the independent attributes and their infinite modifications. Of the infinitely many attributes only two are perceived by the human mind (cf. chapter 5), namely *extension* and *thought*, because only these two are comprised in the idea of the mind. To the development of these two attributes and their relation the development of the concept of "nature" therefore restricts itself. The determinate limited thought, the *idea*, and the determinate limited extension, the *body*²⁾, have their positive subsistence in the attributes of thought and extension, which both belong to the infinite substance (Eth. II, 1. f.), but as independent. The same substance therefore acts in both attributes, posits the modifications of both, and that in such a [73] way that the modifications of the single attributes form coordinate and *parallel* series¹⁾. The concept of each single modification includes only the concept of the attribute of which it is a modification, and has God for its cause in so far as he is considered solely under this attribute, and not under any other. Ideas are thus not imprints of things, not effects of objects, and these are just as little a consequence of the ideas. The objective being of things follows, in so far as they are not modifications of thought, not from the divine nature as thinking, but from the attribute through which they are conceived. The parallelism in the independent series is grounded in the fact that the concept of the effect includes that of the cause (Eth. I, axiom. 4); thus *the order and connection of ideas* (i.e. of the modifications of thought) becomes *the same as the order and connection of things* (Eth. II, 7)²⁾. "Just as the extended and the thinking substance were seen to be one and the same substance, which was conceived now under the one, now under the other attribute, so a modification of extension and the idea of this modification are one

¹⁾cf. Eth. IV. 50. schol.: qui recte novit, omnia ex *naturæ divinæ* necessitate sequi, et secundum æternas *naturæ* leges et regulas fieri.

²⁾Per corpus intelligo modum, qui Dei essentiam, quatenus ut res extensa consideratur, certo et determinato modo exprimit. Eth. II, def. 1.

¹⁾cf. Ep. 4. De intell. emend. pag. 378 f., princ. phil. Cart. I, 21.

²⁾The concept of a connection and agreement in the whole of nature Spinoza develops in Ep. 15. Against the vulgar representation of an "order" in nature determined by its relation to the imagination, on the other hand, he polemicizes. Eth. I, 36 schol.

and the same thing, but expressed in two ways. — Thus, e.g., the circle that exists in nature, and the idea of the existing circle, which is also in God, are one and the same thing, which is determined (explicatur) by different attributes. — For the objective being (esse formale) of the idea of the circle can be conceived only through another modus of thought as proximate cause, this again through another, and so on to infinity, so that as long as things are considered as modi of thought, we must explain the whole order of nature or the connection of causes by the attribute of thought alone; but in so far as they are considered as modi of extension, the whole order of nature must just as fully be explained by the attribute of extension alone, and the same holds of the other attributes.” [74] (Eth. II, 7. schol.)¹⁾.

If, after having seen the general determination of the relation of the attributes to one another within nature in the wider sense, we now consider the attribute that constitutes what we in the narrower sense call *nature*: the attribute of *extension*²⁾, whose concept is presupposed where the essence of the human mind is to be developed (cf. Eth. II, 13), then it is at once striking how different Spinoza's conception of the concept of extension becomes from that of his predecessor Descartes. In the latter, extension was excluded from God's essence and posited as a determination of resting, passive matter, or rather: the determination matter merged into the determination extension, conceived as resting, so that motion and difference are brought in by a new postulated act of God; and since extension is conceived as passive, it is conceived as divisible to infinity. In Spinoza extension is conceived as *attribute*³⁾, hence not only as infinite and *indivisible*, but also as *active*. The last determination is given in that the determination of causality, under which substance was conceived, immediately acquires validity for the attributes. Each attribute expresses an *actuosa* essentia; from each follows an infinity (Eth. III, 2. schol. II, 3. schol.). Where thought and extension are set against each other by Spinoza, cogitandi potentia and *agendi* or *operandi* potentia are sometimes opposed (e.g. Eth. III, 28. dem. Ep. 45).

Just as the determination of extension as active is an immediate consequence of its [75] conception as one of the attributes of substance, so also are its *infinity* and *indivisibility* (cf. Eth. I, 8. 12. 13. Coroll. 15. schol.). These two determinations, of which Descartes could admit only infinity, are on Spinoza's conception inseparable. What deceives us

¹⁾Through this parallelism of thought and extension the Spinozist fundamental concept again expresses itself: causality — in opposition to purpose. In the concept of purpose lies the priority of thought, the determining of extension by it; this preponderance is excluded in Spinoza along with the concept of purpose, and in that parallelism the mode of operation of natural necessity is stamped.

²⁾In Eth. I, 15. schol. the expression is used: *substantia corporea*.

³⁾On the relation of extension to God cf. princ. phil. Cartes. I, 9. schol. Cog. met. II.

with regard to indivisibility is “that quantity is conceived by us in a twofold way, namely abstractly¹⁾ or superficially, namely as we imagine it, and as substance, which happens only through the intellect (intellectus). When, therefore, we have our attention directed to quantity as it is in representation, which happens frequently and more easily, we shall find it finite, divisible²⁾ and composed of parts; but when we have our attention directed to it as it is in the intellect, and conceive it as substance, *which is very difficult*, then it will be found to be infinite, unique and indivisible. This will be sufficiently clear to anyone who knows how to make a distinction between representation and intellect, especially when it is borne in mind that *matter* is everywhere the same, and that one does not distinguish parts in it except in so far as we conceive matter as determined (affectam) in different ways, for which reason its parts are distinguished only modaliter, not realiter. Water, e.g., as water we can imagine divided, so that its parts are separated, but not in so far as it is corporeal substance; for in so far it can be neither divided nor separated. Likewise water comes to be and passes away as water; but in so far as it is substance, it neither comes to be nor passes away” (Eth. I, 15. schol.)³⁾.

[76] In the conception of the essence of *extended substance*, therefore, Spinoza stands in sharp opposition to Descartes. On the other hand he comes closer to him in the conception of the finite modi of extension (see below). Not only does he lay down, like Descartes, that extension receives no other real modifications than those that are given with motion and the determinations connected with it: figure and position, so that all other determinations, e.g. qualitates tactiles, express only an imaginary relation to our senses (Ep. 6), but, according to his conception of the finite, he must posit every determinedness to motion in the single modus of extension as called forth *from without*, even if the moved thing’s own nature becomes a contributing factor (cf. Eth. I, 28 and II, 13. schol.), and he must let the changes called forth from without in the world of bodies take place solely according to the laws of mechanics (Ep. 9). But this agreement again loses its foundation as the finite, the condition of the mechanical, vanishes.

The expressions: *extension*, *extended substance* (corporeal substance), *quantity*, *matter*, Spinoza uses as synonyms, and in so far as the determination extension most nearly leads

¹⁾“A substantia abstractam.” Ep. 39.

²⁾With regard to infinite division cf. Ep. 6. De int. emend. pag. 385; princ. phil. Cart. II, 5. schol. — On the concept: *empty space* cf. Ep. 6.

³⁾cf. Ep. 29: As the expression of substance, extension cannot be limited or divided without its concept being cancelled. “Quare ii prorsus garriunt, ne dicam insaniunt, qui substantiam extensam ex partibus sive corporibus ab invicem realiter distinctis conflata esse putant. Perinde enim est, ac si quis ex sola additione et coacervatione multorum circulorum, quadratum aut triangulum, aut quid aliud tota essentia diversum conflare studeat.” — At this point the element of spirit in the concept of substance determines the element of nature, just as the latter at many other points determines the former.

to the representation of what is intuited as at rest, the determination *matter* seems to be a more suitable designation. In one of his last letters (Ep. 72, of 15 July 1676)¹⁾ he also seems to be inclined to substitute this latter designation for the former, no doubt precisely in order to get the active moment expressed²⁾. Spinoza's utterances in this letter were called [77] forth by an inquiry from a friend: (Ep. 69) how the existence of bodies determined by motion and figure could be derived a priori from the concept of extension. Spinoza first restricts his answer (Ep. 70) to extension as Descartes had conceived it, namely as a *moles quiescens*, and shows that on this conception it becomes absolutely impossible to deduce the existence of bodies a priori, since matter at rest will continue to be at rest when it is not set in motion from without by a stronger cause. When the question is repeated (Ep. 71) and he is urged to state his own view, he answers evasively (Ep. 72): "quod petis, an ex solo extensionis conceptu rerum varietas a priori possit demonstrari, credo, me jam satis clare ostendisse, id impossibile esse, ideoque materiam a Cartesio male definiri per extensionem; sed eam necessario debere explicari per attributum, quod æternam et infinitam essentiam exprimat. Sed de his forsitan aliquando, si vita suppetit, clarius tecum agam. Nam hucusque nihil de his ordine disponere mihi licuit." — The evasiveness in Spinoza's answer no doubt has its ground in the fact that the question that was put touched the two points of his doctrine that were most foreign to the conception of his contemporaries and the hardest stumbling-block for it, namely: *the unity of extension, i.e. of matter, with God*, and *the non-reality of finite things*. Seen from substance and in substance, and that is: seen in its truth, the finite is sublated as finite; there can therefore be no question of deducing it a priori from the infinite, indivisible extension; for precisely for a priori knowledge, which is the knowledge of substance, it does not exist¹⁾. But precisely because the way out sought by Descartes, the arbitrary intervention [78] of a personal God, was cut off, the problem had to present itself more sharply; the difficulties that emerged in chapter 2 with the general question about the finite had to repeat themselves here within the single attribute, and the intermediate determinations given there had to be sought applied here.

¹⁾cf. the quotation of Eth. I, 15. schol. given above.

²⁾That Spinoza did not adopt *materia* as attribute instead of *extensio* may well also have its ground in regard for the common representation of God.

¹⁾In Spinoza's answer, therefore, emphasis must no doubt also be laid on the words: *rerum varietas*. For if the single things are thought as really different, hence as really subsisting singulars, then they naturally cannot be deduced, since as such they are untrue and are such only through something negative.

As the *infinite modi* of extension¹⁾ there are now determined *motion* and *rest*²⁾ (Ep. 66, cf. Eth. I, 32. Coroll. 2.); as their product, *facies totius universi*. — The *finite modi* are the *bodies*. *They are not deduced from the former*; for such a deduction is, according to what was developed in chapter 2, impossible, and it is not replaced by the postulate that, since the nature of the universe is absolutely infinite, “this absolutely mighty nature must determine its parts in infinite ways and compel them to undergo infinite changes”³⁾; for precisely the concept *variatio* cannot be derived from the infinite. The finite bodies are [79] *presupposed hypothetically*, in such a way that the conception of them as single is held in suspense (Eth. II. def. 7), and *are then led back* to the infinite modifications¹⁾.

In the 2nd Part of the Ethics, 13th Proposition, schol., *the general propositions of physics* are stated as the foundation for the subsequent development of the ethical fundamental concepts. “Simple bodies (*corpora simplicissima*)²⁾ are either at rest or in motion, and now in quicker, now in slower motion. Only thereby, not by a difference in substance, are they distinguished from one another; they all agree in this, that they include the concept of the same attribute and are determined by motion and rest.” Since they are conceived as single, the determination to motion and rest must proceed from another body, which again must be determined by a third, and so on to infinity (cf. Eth. I, 28. and above p. 70). The determinedness received they retain until an opposite one is posited in them by another body, and every such affection is determined both by the nature of the acting and of the affected body. With this the determinations are given for the bodies conceived as simple (*simplicissima*), which are distinguished only by motion and rest, quickness and slowness; for the *composite* bodies (*composita*) closer determinations are required. “For when several bodies of the same or different size are so held together by the others that they lie close against one another (*ut invicem incumbant*), or when, moved with the

¹⁾In scrutandis rebus naturalibus ante omnia investigare conamur res maxime universales et toti naturæ communes, videlicet *motum et quietem*, eorumque leges et regulas, quas natura semper observat et per quas continuo agit, et ex his gradatim ad alia minus universalia procedimus. tract. theol.-pol. pag. 88. — Corpus humanum non est absolute, sed tantum certo modo *secundum leges naturæ extensæ per motum et quietem* determinata extensio. Princ. phil. Cart. præf. editoris.

²⁾This: motion *and* rest, must be taken copulatively, so that it becomes synonymous with: the relation between motion and rest, which then again finds its expression in *facies totius universi*. Rest can, on Spinoza’s conception of substance, only become a relative determination, a difference of quantity within motion. Only in single bodies can there be talk of a motion by itself and a rest by itself, but this separation falls away with the real existence of finite bodies.

³⁾Ab hac infinitæ potentiæ natura eius partes infinitis modis moderantur et infinitas variationes pati coguntur. Ep. 15.

¹⁾In the preponderance of the concept of causality too lies the impossibility of holding fast a subsisting single; for the effect does not separate itself from the cause; there is no principle of individuation.

²⁾The concept: *corpora simplicissima*, is relative and arbitrary; for when bodies are conceived as limited, single, they are separated from substance, and must be conceived as *divisible to infinity* (Ep. 29). Precisely through this contradiction of Spinoza’s definitely developed conception that determination shows itself to be hypothetical.

same or different degree of speed, they communicate their motions to one another in a determinate ratio, then these bodies can be called *mutually united*, and are all together said to make up *one body or individual*, which by this union is distinguished from the rest.” The concept of individuality is thus not an inner determination from an abiding centre; for such a centre is made impossible by the conception of the finite; — but a determination given from without, contingent and relative. Its relativity now appears also from the extensions that are given it, and which precisely from the standpoint of mechanism dissolve it at the subordinate levels¹⁾. Partly it is extended, as regards the body composed of the most simple parts, in that the individual is regarded as the same²⁾ even if some of its parts are separated off, provided only that as many others of the same nature come in their place; — likewise even if the parts become larger or smaller, provided only that during the increase or diminution they retain the same ratio of motion and rest; — likewise, even if some of the parts change the direction of their motion, provided they continue to move and to communicate their motion to one another in the same way as before, and finally, even if the composite individual as a whole is moved or rests, or takes this or that direction, provided only that each of its parts retains its motion, and, as before, communicates it to the others. Partly the concept of the individual is extended to what is composed of several different individuals, whose affections can therefore become so much the more manifold without harm to the identity of the individual. And since such new compositions can again be composed to infinity, one comes to see “*that the whole of nature is one individual*”³⁾, whose parts, i.e. all bodies, vary (variant) in infinitely many ways without any change in the whole individual.” [80]

The direction in this development is thus the same as in the general problem of the finite. The single bodies are not derived from infinite extension, but since one provisionally proceeds from the representation of *single* bodies, which conflicts with the fundamental principles, the concept of individuality is given an elasticity that first makes the determination relative, and finally brings it to vanish as it coincides with infinity. But during this retrograde movement, this venous current, which leads everything back to the centre, without an arterial current leading it out again from there, there is nonetheless an endeavour, through the very vanishing, to give the infinite a fullness, and for intuition there forms a fleeting image of an infinite life of nature, eternally moved in itself, ordered by eternal laws and embracing everything finite, in which the thought of the organism [81]

¹⁾Spinoza's conception of the limit as merely negative must also make the concept of individuality relative.

²⁾retinebit suam naturam absque ulla formæ (i.e. of the essence) mutatione.

³⁾cf. Cog. metaph. II, c. 7.

is as it were mirrored¹⁾. But this image is a vanishing one; for the finite is not merely in the process of vanishing, but has eternally vanished²⁾.

Only in the form of lemmas to the Ethics has Spinoza developed the most general propositions of his physics (“*generalia in physicis*”). A more detailed elaboration was cut off by his principle, and however much Spinoza occupied himself with the study of nature, his deeper interest could nonetheless not rest on nature in its concrete fullness³⁾, which vanished in the radiance of substance, just as, according to the belief of antiquity, the finite had to perish when it had seen the infinite; — it could rest only on the abstract [82] metaphysical concept of nature. And yet it is psychologically and dialectically interesting, in him, as in general in the idealist thinkers of that period, to see how nature, which is pushed back by thought and is conceived only in thought’s form, because thought everywhere seeks itself, continues as it were to tempt, so that not only is the thinker drawn to the study of it, but also the determinations of nature, however volatilized, unconsciously insinuate themselves into the conception of the essence of thought. In Spinoza we have already seen samples of this in the determination of the concept of substance; we shall see it still more clearly in the determination of the human mind.

The general propositions of physics followed as simple consequences of the general metaphysical foundation and the hypothetically taken starting point. The closer carrying-through of them, had such become possible, would only have formed a parallel to the Ethics, and would therefore have yielded no more philosophical gain than we already have in the latter. The Ethics lent itself, as we shall see, to such a closer elaboration; in it we shall therefore find the real complement to the abstract metaphysical foundation.

Chapter Five.

The Human Mind.

¹⁾The view of eternal laws of nature, which govern a change and bind it under unity, must, carried through consistently, lead to the view of a mutual communication of an original motion, a circulation of motion, hence of an organism; but the concept of the organism is foreign to Spinoza, and already a reciprocal action cannot be thought in the series of causes and effects. But that concept is hinted at, and only through it does thought receive a content.

²⁾On the relation of this conception of nature to the Leibnizian doctrine of monads cf. chapter 10.

³⁾For the conception of the concrete objects of nature in their *particulares differentiæ* receives its interest essentially from the fact that these prove capable of being reduced to the general mechanical principles (Ep. 6).

Through the second of the two attributes known to man, the attribute of *thought*, we arrive at the determination of *the human mind*. Thought is immediately certain to us as an attribute of God; for every single thought includes its concept (cf. chapter 4). God is *res cogitans, ens cogitans infinitum*. The *infinite modification* of the attribute of thought is *intellectus absolute infinitus* (Ep. 66)¹⁾. As a *modus*, intellectus, even as infinite, belongs [83] to *natura naturata*, not to *natura naturans*; it is not the absolute cogitatio itself, but its infinite effect (Eth. I, 31 f.). Synonymous with intellectus infinitus²⁾ stands *idea Dei*. Like the former, it follows from “the absolute nature of the attribute” (Eth. I, 21 dem.), it expresses God’s essence and everything that follows with necessity from it (Eth. II, 3), and by the unity of God’s essence it is *one* (Eth. II, 4)³⁾ and infinite (Eth. II, 8). — The *finite* modi of thought are the *ideas*: per *ideam* intelligo mentis conceptum, quem mens format propterea quod res est cogitans (Eth. II, def. 3)⁴⁾. In the conception of the idea and its relation to intellectus infinitus and idea dei, the determination of extension and its modi must serve as a guide. Spinoza views the ideas as limiting one another just as bodies do (Eth. I, def. 2), he speaks of the *composition* of ideas, just as of the composition of corpora simplicissima, and since limitation in the sphere of ideas, as in that of bodies, is conceived only as negation, the individual unity of the idea, like the concept of the individual in the corporeal, becomes a relative concept, from which, as it is extended [84] through the vanishing of the negative limitation, one arrives at the universal individual in the sphere of ideas (corresponding to the universal individual in that of extension), that is: at the infinite *idea Dei*¹⁾, in which all limitation is cancelled, and which, in the same way as its analogue in the sphere of extension, must be conceived as unchanged under the infinite alternation of the parts. When it is said of this idea Dei that it is in *God* (Eth. II, 3), this is in the same sense in which everything that is, is in God (Eth. I, 15. 25. Coroll.); it has its positive subsistence in him as *natura naturata in natura naturans*²⁾.

¹⁾This is also designated as intellectus *actu* infinitus (Eth. I, 30), not in order to distinguish it from an intellectus *potentiâ*, which Spinoza does not recognize; but in order to express that this intellectus is equal to intellectio itself (Eth. I, 31. schol.).

²⁾The difference between intellectus and idea is only a difference of name, just as, in the sphere of finitude, the difference between mens humana and the idea which constitutes man’s essence. When intellectus infinitus *Dei* is spoken of, this expression becomes perfectly parallel to *idea Dei*.

³⁾Cog. metaph. II, c. 7: idea dei, per quam omniscius vocatur, unica et simplicissima est. Nam revera deus nulla alia ratione vocatur omniscius, nisi quia habet ideam sui ipsius, quæ idea sive cogitatio simul semper cum Deo exstitit; nihil enim est præter eius essentiam, nec illa alio modo potuit esse.

⁴⁾The idea is called mentis *conceptus*, not mentis *perceptio*, in order to signify that the mind does not relate passively to the object, but is active.

¹⁾Since intellectus and idea are synonymous, the same thing is expressed when it is said that all eternal modi of thought, as a unity, constitute God’s eternal and infinite intellectus (Eth. V, 40. schol.).

²⁾In the Ethics V, 30. dem., where reference is made to Eth. II, 3, idea Dei seems to be attributed to God as absolute infinitus, but in this place too it is God as *causatum* that has this idea of himself as *causa*, and substance as *causatum* becomes equal to *natura naturata* in its infinity. Meanwhile the difference

Represented as *single*, the ideas stand parallel to the single bodies, and form a series parallel to the series of things (cf. chapter 4). God's cogitandi potentia is thus equal to his actualis agendi potentia, i.e.: what follows objectively (formaliter) from *God's infinite nature* follows subjectively (objective) in the same order and with the same connection in [85] God from *God's idea* (Eth. II, 7. Coroll. cf. Ep. 15; de emend. intell. pag. 368)³. To every thing there thus corresponds an idea, which subjectively expresses what is objectively in the thing. It is the thing's idea, its mens, and every natural individual has such a mens; they are all animate, though in different degrees (Eth. II, 13. schol.), since the excellence of the idea, i.e. its greater reality, is dependent on the object's degree of reality.¹

At this point, where the presuppositions are given for determining the essence of the human mind, the problem of the relation between the two attributes that constitute it and the infinitely many attributes comes forward again. From the parallelism between the attributes it would seem that one could draw the consequence that every thing was determined as a modus of all attributes, and that the mind apprehended them all, not merely the modus of extension, the body (cf. Ep. 67). But Spinoza avoids this last consequence by saying: *quamvis unaquæque res infinitis modis expressa sit in infinito Dei intellectu, illæ tamen infinitæ ideæ, quibus exprimitur, unam eandemque rei singularis mentem constituere nequeunt, sed infinitas; quandoquidem unaquæque harum infinitarum idearum nullam connexionem cum invicem habeat* (Ep. 68). But since the modi of all the other attributes are apprehended through cogitatio, whose modus the idea is, and [86] since the idea becomes an idea ideæ, i.e. idea cogitationis, one is led either to split the attribute of thought into an infinite number of attributes, or to set the infinite attributes in unity in the attribute of thought, or to let the latter vanish in the others; in any case one does not escape conflict with the fundamental view.

between idea Dei and cogitatio in its immediate, infinite certainty of itself is on the point of vanishing, and this is also the case where absolutus intellectus Dei or intellectus divinus is spoken of without closer determination (Eth. II, 11. Coroll. V, 40. schol. I, 33. schol. 2. II, 40. dem.). — As a motive for Spinoza to guard against intellectus being attributed to God as natura naturans, one may well assume the endeavor to cut off the anthropomorphic representations that go with that concept (cf. Ep. 58. pag. 570 and the line of proof in Eth. I, 33. schol. 2. and I, 17. schol., where one must not overlook that the argument is ex concessis).

³Therefore the ideas of the non-existing finite things or modi must also be comprehended in the same way in God's infinite idea as the objective essence of these things is comprehended in God's attributes; from which it thus follows that, so long as the single things do not exist except insofar as they are comprehended in God's attributes, their subjective essence (esse objectivum) or their idea does not exist except insofar as God's infinite idea exists; and when the finite things are *said* to exist, not merely insofar as they are comprehended in God's attributes, but also insofar as they are said to endure (durare), then their ideas also include existence, by which they are said to have duration (Eth. II. 8).

¹For the more the object of the idea can at once act and be acted upon, the more apt is the mind to perceive at once (percipere) several things, and the more the object's actions are dependent on itself alone, the more apt is the mind to understand distinctly (Eth. II, 13. schol.).

By the determinations of the relation of the ideas to things, *the human mind* is not posited as qualitatively different from the mentes of other things. It is a determinate modification of the attribute of thought; what constitutes its actual being is the idea of an actually existing *single* thing (Eth. II, 11), and this thing is the *body*, i.e. an *actually* existing determinate modus of extension (Eth. II, 13). This is given by the fact that we have ideas of the body's affections, which could not take place if the body were not the mind's object. Man thus consists of mind and body, hence of parallel modifications of the two attributes, and the meaning of the union of mind and body (*unio mentis et corporis*) is clear from the foregoing. The mind is *idea corporis*; but since the idea, albeit in a limited way, expresses the *actuosa essentia* of thought, it must be conceived, not as an image of the body, but as active, and *idea corporis* thus becomes an *idea ideæ* (*idea mentis*), which is united with the mind in the same way as the mind is united with the body. The body and the idea of the body were the same thing, apprehended under two different attributes; the idea and the idea of the idea the same thing, apprehended under the same attribute, that of thought. The idea of the idea is the essence of the idea (*forma ideæ*) insofar as it is considered as a *modus cogitandi* without regard to the object (Eth. II, 20 f.). If there were only an *idea corporis*, thought would be passive in the relation; the activity of thought conditions the idea of the idea, the determinate idea's knowledge of itself.¹⁾

The conception of the mind as *idea corporis*,¹⁾ and the transfer, conditioned thereby, [87] of the relations of extension, of the representation of limitation and composition²⁾ to the modi of thought, the ideas, now governs Spinoza's doctrine of the human mind as knowing and willing. It is only by constantly remembering the parallelism between the two attributes that one understands Spinoza's theory of knowledge, and it is the view of this parallelism that underlies the distinction, essential to the theory of knowledge, between the *adequate* and the *inadequate* idea. "The human mind is a part of God's infinite intellectus, and when one says that the human mind perceives (*percipit*) this or that, one says nothing other than that God, not insofar as he is infinite, but insofar as he

¹⁾The comparison between Spinoza's conception of *idea mentis* and the Fichtean conception, already prepared earlier, of the synthesis of self-consciousness is instructive (cf. chapter 10). Spinoza's *idea mentis* is not abstract self-consciousness ($I = I$), but the mind's *concrete immediate self-certainty* in its knowing — *self-feeling*, one might say, if this expression did not contain a formal contradiction, of which, however, Spinoza himself is guilty when he uses the expression *sentire* for *percipere*.

¹⁾Eth. II, 19: *mens humana est ipsa idea sive cognitio corporis humani*. — Eth. III, 57. schol.: *idea seu anima eiusdem individui*. — On the mind's relation to the body cf. Ep. 15. 68. De intell. emend. pag. 368. Eth. V. præf.

²⁾The idea that makes up the objective essence of the human mind is not simple, but composed of many ideas, since the human body is composed of many individuals, each of which is in turn composite (Eth. II, 15. 13. post. 1.).

is determined (explicatur) by the nature of the human mind, or insofar as he constitutes the essence of the human mind, has this or that idea; when, on the other hand, we say that God has this or that idea, not insofar as he merely constitutes the nature of the human mind, but insofar as he, together with that of the human mind, also has the idea of another thing, then we say that the human mind perceives a thing partially or *inadequately*" (Eth. II, 11 Coroll.).³⁾

[88] In the development of the human mind as knowing, the same conception of the finite is carried through that we met in the development of the concept of extension and already earlier in the development of the general metaphysical foundation, and the same striving to lead the finite back to the infinite repeats itself. Just as we saw there that finitude could be conceived in a twofold way: according to its truth, as vanished in the infinite, and confusedly, untruly, as subsisting in and for itself, so it shows itself also here, and this twofold mode of conception makes the essential distinction between the *kinds of knowledge*.

If one starts from the hypothetical presupposition of an existing finite in its multiplicity, this leads to the kind of knowledge that Spinoza designates as *imagination*. The human body is affected in manifold ways by the other bodies, and the mind expresses these affections. Since the body's affections are determined both by the nature of the affecting and of the affected body (cf. Eth. II, 13. Lemma 3), their ideas include the nature of both bodies. "The affections of the human body whose ideas represent to us the external bodies as present we call the images of things (imagines), although they do not reproduce the forms of things, and when the mind in this way considers bodies, we call it *imagining*" (Eth. II, 17. schol.).¹⁾ But from the origin of imagination it follows [89] that the ideas of external things express the state of our body more than their nature (Eth. II, 16. Coroll. 2 cf. 25 f.), and that they expose us to errors, since the body retains the affection, and hence the mind the idea of the foreign body as present, until a new affection excludes the former (Eth. II, 17). From the determination given above of the adequate and inadequate ideas it follows that through imagination, which apprehends things as single and distinct, no adequate knowledge can be reached, since its ideas must all contain what is not understood from the human mind alone. For when the finite is

³⁾Eth. III, 1. dem. [ideæ] quæ — inadæquatæ sunt in mente, sunt etiam in Deo adæquatæ, non quatenus eiusdem solummodo mentis essentiam, sed etiam quatenus aliarum rerum mentes in se continet. — De intell. emend. pag. 380: Certum est, ideas inadæquatas ex eo tantum in nobis oriri, quod pars sumus alicuius entis cogitantis, cuius quædam cogitationes ex toto, quædam ex parte tantum nostram mentem constituunt. — The human mind is composed of adequate and inadequate ideas. Eth. III, 3. dem.

¹⁾Eth. III, 56. dem.: quatenus imaginamur, sive quatenus afficimur affectu, qui naturam nostri corporis et naturam corporis externi involvit; cf. de intell. emend. pag. 384. Eth. II, 49. schol.: Verborum et imaginum essentia a solis motibus corporeis constituitur, qui cogitationis conceptum minime involvunt.

conceived as finite, it becomes a link in the infinite, continuing chain of finite causes and effects, and as a link it points beyond itself and requires, in order to be understood, a preceding link as cause, and thereby it becomes impossible that the idea of the thing held fast as single and isolated can be adequate; for that would presuppose a detachment from the series as independent, an understanding solely through the very nature of the finite link. Although, therefore, the mind is *idea corporis*, *cognitio corporis*, this idea, considered as single, is nevertheless not adequate, i.e. clear and distinct, and no more is the idea of the human mind (Eth. II, 28. schol.)¹⁾. For the mind only knows the human body, and only knows it as existing, through its affections; for whereas the human body itself, as effect, is not understood through itself but through its cause, the affections that follow from its nature include the body's concept, and through them the mind therefore knows the body, and through the ideas of them, itself. But since the ideas of these affections include the nature both of one's own and of the foreign body,²⁾ the knowledge of the former, just as little as that of the latter, becomes adequate through the human mind alone, and hence neither does the mind's knowledge of itself through [90] itself as single. The ideas of the affections, referred to the human mind alone, are like consequences without premises, *ideæ confusæ*. For they are in God, not insofar as he is considered as determined by the idea of the human mind alone, but insofar as he is considered as determined by several other ideas.¹⁾ The same consequence follows with regard to the human body from what is relative in the concept of the individual, since the parts of the body retain an independence as separate individuals, each of which must be understood through its own particular cause, different from the human body (cf. Eth. II, 19–29). The lack of adequate knowledge also expresses itself as defective knowledge of the *duration* of our body and of the external bodies.²⁾ For since their existence as single things does not depend on their essence, but on “*communis naturæ ordo et rerum constitutio*”, which we cannot survey in its infinity, the knowledge of existence becomes in high degree incomplete, and we apprehend things as *contingent* and *perishable*, determinations which thus express only a defect of our thought, not a property of the thing.

Through imagination, then, which rests on the untrue conception of the finite as subsisting, no true knowledge is attained. It is called forth by the chance collision of

¹⁾Through this contradiction: that the mind, which according to its essence is *cognitio corporis* (et mentis), becomes *non*-knowing, imagination and the corresponding conception of finitude show themselves as untrue, as non-being.

²⁾Therefore the concept *imaginatio* can be applied to our knowledge of *ourselves*.

¹⁾In this relation lies the possibility of the abstract conception of *modi* as separated from their cause.

²⁾The concept *duratio* is, in its difference from eternity, a relative concept which has no significance for true knowledge (cf. chapter 8).

things (*rerum occursu fortuito*); the mind is determined from without, and links its ideas together, not according to their eternal and necessary connection, according to the order of reason, which is the same in all men, by which it understands things through their first [91] causes; but by the *memory* of the chance linking of the body's affections. Its connecting of the ideas is what we, in modern terminology, would call that of the association of ideas (*Eth. II, 18. schol. 29, schol.*). Imagination is affected only by the single (*De intell. emend. pag. 383*), it apprehends the infinite as finite, limited and divisible (*Ep. 29*), is therefore unfit to apprehend the divine,¹⁾ and since all ideas have their truth only through God, *all* ideas of imagination²⁾ become inadequate, mutilated and confused (*mutilatæ et confusæ*); it becomes the source of *ideæ fictæ, falsæ* and *dubiæ* (cf. *de intell. emend.*), from which errors arise, as well as of *entia imaginationis*, which express not the essence of things but their untrue relation to us as single beings (see below).

But the untruth of imagination does not exclude a true knowledge; for imagination became untrue through the untruth in the finite; but to the finite in its true conception, conceived such that limitation is a mere negative, and the finite as being in the infinite, there corresponds the true kind of knowledge, whose foundation this conception is. For what was untrue in the former kind of knowledge was not something positive:³⁾ there would then be in God a positive false *modus* of thought, which is impossible; rather it consisted in the privation of knowledge that lay in the inadequate, incomplete and confused ideas. Since the human mind, whose individuality is relative, makes up only as it were a fragment of a more comprehensive idea, a part in a composition, its knowledge is incomplete, as it were mutilated; when the limitation is cancelled and the whole is posited, i.e. *when the idea is led back to God*, it is true⁴⁾, i.e. it agrees [92] perfectly with its ideatum, and every idea that is complete in us is true. But that which is common to all things, and which is equally in the parts and in the whole,¹⁾ does not exclusively constitute the essence of any single thing, and can therefore only be apprehended adequately. Hence the consequence that there are certain ideas or concepts which are common to all men, and which are in all as adequate, i.e. clear and distinct (*Eth. II. 38. Coroll.*).²⁾ They are the ideas of that which is at once proper to and common

¹⁾Ep. 60: *Deum enim non imaginari, sed quidem intelligere possumus*; cf. *Eth. II, 47. schol.*

²⁾Cf. *Eth. III, 56. dem.*

³⁾Cf. *de intell. emend. pag. 392*; *princ. phil. Cart. I, 15.*

⁴⁾Since all ideas, led back to God, are true, i.e. adequate, and are seen as inadequate only insofar as they are referred to the mind of a single thing, the same law of necessity governs both the adequate and the inadequate ideas in their consequences. *Eth. II, 36.*

¹⁾In the sphere of bodies what was common was that they all belonged to the same attribute, and that they had the possibility of motion — faster or slower — and rest. *Eth. II, 13. Lemma 3.* The meaning of "the common" for the other attributes is evident from this.

²⁾*Per ideam adæquatam intelligo ideam, quæ quatenus in se, sine relatione ad obiectum consideratur,*

to the human body and the external bodies, and which is equally in the single part and in the whole. And since such a common element is the foundation of an adequate knowledge, the mind must become all the more apt to understand adequately, the more things the body has in common with other bodies (Eth. II, 39. Coroll.). The adequate ideas now become the source of true knowledge; for the ideas that follow from them must also be adequate.³⁾ The kind of knowledge proceeding from them is that of the *intellect* (intellectus). What is peculiar to it is not merely to be *true*, but to have certainty of its truth, since the idea, as active, is not something mute like a picture on a tablet, but the living act of thought, which affirms itself and immediately gives certainty (Eth. II, 43. schol.).¹⁾ Since it apprehends things truly (vere), it apprehends them not, in the [93] manner of the imagination, as contingent, but as *necessary*, and since the necessity of things is the very necessity of God's *eternal nature*, it apprehends them under a form of *eternity* (sub quadam æternitatis specie. Eth. II, 44. Coroll. 2).²⁾ This lies also in the fact that the foundations of reason (rationis fundamenta) are concepts which express *that which is common to all things*, and which therefore, since they do not express the essence of any single thing, must be apprehended without any relation to time, under the form of eternity. But this true conception of the single existing things necessarily includes *the idea of God's eternal and infinite essence*. For the existence of things is not [94] thought, separated from its cause, as duration; but *according to its nature* ("loquor de ipsa natura existentiae". Eth. II, 45. schol.), as proceeding from the eternal necessity of

omnes veræ ideæ proprietates sive denominationes intrinsecas habet. Eth. II. def. 4. The distinguishing mark of the true idea was agreement with its ideatum (cf. Eth. I. axiom. 6. Ep. 64), and this is a denominatio *extrinseca*. — As synonyms for ideæ adæquatæ are used: claræ et distinctæ, e.g. Eth. II, 28; cf. Eth. II, 13. schol.: adæquate sive distincte.

³⁾On the significance of consequence for truth cf. de int. emend. pag. 375 f.

¹⁾Intelligere is equal to certum esse, idea equal to ipsum intelligere. Eth. II, 43, schol. Certainty can therefore be posited as one with the essentia obiectiva itself (the idea), which also becomes synonymous with truth. De intell. emend. pag. 366 ff. Intellectus becomes the clearest of all (Eth. I, 31. schol.); truth its own proof (Ep. 74. De intell. emend. 378. 382). Certainty as something positive is different from the negative: not to doubt: per certitudinem quid positivum intelligimus, non vero dubitationis privationem. Eth. II, 49. schol. The idea as idea contains affirmation and negation (ibid). Since the knowledge of reason contains certainty of its truth, *probability* is excluded from its domain (cf. Ep. 15. 60); likewise it is posited as independent of *experience*, which refers only to finite *existence* (nam experientia nullas rerum essentias docet; sed summum, quod efficere potest, est, mentem nostram determinare, ut circa certas tantum rerum essentias cogitet. Ep. 28), and can never become a counter-proof against what we understand clearly and distinctly (princ. phil. Cartes. II, 6. schol. End.)

²⁾Sub specie æternitatis et necessitatis. Eth. IV. 62. dem. — Eth. V, 29. schol.: res duobus modis a nobis ut actuales concipiuntur, vel quatenus easdem cum relatione ad certum tempus et locum existere, vel quatenus ipsas in Deo contineri et ex naturæ divinæ necessitate consequi concipimus. Quæ autem hoc secundo modo ut veræ seu reales concipiuntur, eas sub æternitatis specie concipimus, et earum ideæ æternam et infinitam Dei essentiam involvunt. — Eth. V, 30. dem.: res — sub specie æternitatis concipere est res concipere quatenus per Dei essentiam ut entia realia concipiuntur, sive quatenus per Dei essentiam involvunt existentiam.

God's nature, from which infinite things follow in infinite modifications. Things are thus thought in their existence in God; for even though each single thing is determined by another single thing to exist in a certain way, the force with which they persist in their existence is nevertheless a consequence of the eternal necessity of God's nature.¹⁾ Since the idea of every thing includes the idea of God, the latter is necessarily adequate and perfect, and *the human mind thus has an adequate knowledge of God's eternal and infinite essence*²⁾ (Eth. II, 46 f.), and this infinite being and its eternity must be known to all (Eth. II, 47. schol.).³⁾

From the untrue and inadequate knowledge of imagination, then, the knowledge of reason distinguishes itself as true and adequate,⁴⁾ and this distinction is grounded in the different conception of the finite, which in the former was abstract, partial, under the form of contingency and therefore different for different people; in the latter in unity with the idea of God, under the form of necessity and eternity, and the same for all. But within adequate knowledge Spinoza again distinguishes a twofold form: *the knowledge of* [95] *reason* (ratio), which proceeds from notions communes, and gives adequate ideas of the properties of things, and *intuitive knowledge* (scientia intuitiva), which proceeds from the adequate idea of the objective essence of God's attributes to the adequate knowledge of the essence of things.

The different kinds of knowledge are thus the following three: 1) *The first kind of knowledge: opinion* (opinio) or *imagination*, which partly has its point of departure in the single things that present themselves to us through the senses incompletely, confusedly and without the order of reason — sine ordine ad intellectum (this Spinoza calls *cognitio ab experientia vaga*); — partly in signs, e.g. in the fact that, through words which we hear or read, an image of the things is called forth in us by the association of ideas.¹⁾ — 2) *The second kind of knowledge, or reason* (ratio); — 3) *The third kind of knowledge, intuitive knowledge*. As an example (which, however, must by its nature be inadequate) to illustrate the difference, he cites the problem: from three given numbers to find the

¹⁾The leading back of the single thing's idea to God therefore takes place not through a never completed approximation through the series of finite things, but by seeing things in God from the standpoint of infinity, as it were with one glance. In this conception essence and existence (*ipsa existentia, ipsa natura existentiae*) are set in unity, just as they are in substance.

²⁾The fact that the human mind knows only two of God's infinitely many attributes prevents it only from knowing God completely (*omnino cognoscere*), not from knowing him clearly and distinctly, since each attribute is known completely through itself. Cf. Ep. 60.

³⁾Cf. the enumeration of the powers and properties of reason in the treatise de emend. intell. pag. 390 ff.

⁴⁾Concerning the general relation between intellectus and imaginatio cf. Eth. IV. 59. schol. De intell. emend. pag. 384 f. Ep. 29. 60.

¹⁾Cf. tract. theol.-pol. pag. 185: intellectio pura mente *extra verba et imagines*.

fourth proportional. “Merchants have no doubt²⁾ that one must multiply the second by the third and divide the sum by the first, because they have not forgotten what they have heard from their teachers without any proof, or because they have frequently had this experience with the simplest cases (1st kind). But it can also be done by virtue of Euclid’s proposition, according to the common property of proportional numbers (2nd kind). But with the simplest numbers none of this is necessary. For when the numbers 1, 2 and 3 are given, everyone sees immediately that the fourth number is 6, and much more clearly, because we infer the fourth from the very ratio which we see at one glance that the first has to the second” (Eth. II, 40. schol. 2).³⁾

In order to apprehend more definitely the relation between the three kinds of knowl- [96] edge, it is necessary to go somewhat more closely into the Spinozistic terminology and into his relation to the concepts of earlier metaphysics.

We saw that rational knowledge took its point of departure from *notiones communes*¹⁾ and that it was these that gave the essential ground of distinction between the first and [97] second kinds of knowledge. It therefore becomes important to determine this concept, in particular to distinguish it from the *notiones universales*, *notiones transscendentales*, *generalia*, *entia rationis* and the like that belong to imagination. When we remember that *notiones communes* are adequate, that they express things according to their truth

²⁾Let the reader recall the difference between: not to doubt, and: to have certainty (see above p. 93, Note 1).

³⁾In the treatise de intellectus emendatione (pag. 362 f.) the division is somewhat different in form, but nevertheless forms a parallel to the one given in the Ethics. Spinoza there enumerates 4 modi percipiendi: 1) perceptio ex *auditu* aut ex aliquo signo; 2) *ab experientia vaga*; 3) ubi essentia rei ex alia re concluditur, sed non adæquate, e.g. when we infer from an effect to the cause, or when an inference is drawn from something universal with which a certain property always follows; 4) when the thing is understood through its very essence or through knowledge of its proximate cause. The first two of these kinds of knowledge correspond to what is later comprehended under the designation: *imaginatio*. The third should correspond most nearly to *ratio*, but some uncertainty enters, since Spinoza has not distinguished between *notiones communes* and the abstract *notiones universales* (see below), and therefore does not regard this, but the 4th kind, as adequate and secured against error. As examples of the third kind of knowledge he cites: when we have clearly apprehended that we sense this particular body and no other, we infer with clarity that the soul is united with the body, which union is the cause of such a sensation; but of what nature the essence of that union is, we do not understand perfectly from this, since by the union we as yet understand nothing other than the sensation of the effect, from which the inference was drawn to the unknown cause. Another example is: when I know the nature of sight, and know that it has the property that, according to the different distance, we see the same thing as larger or smaller, I infer from this that the sun is larger than it appears; but this is only a property (*proprium*), not *rei essentia particularis*. This kind of knowledge is thus not sufficient in and for itself, since its result is abstract. — “*Through the very essence of the thing*, on the other hand, the thing is understood when, from the fact that I know something, I know what it is to know, or when, from the fact that I have known the essence of the soul, I know that it is united with the body. By the same knowledge I know that 2 and 3 are 5, and that two lines which are parallel to one and the same third are parallel to each other.”

¹⁾Eth. II, 40. schol. 1: *notionum, quæ communes vocantur, quæque ratiocinii nostri fundamenta sunt*. Cf. tract. theol.-polit. pag. 430 (ed. Pauli): *ad notiones quasdam simplicissimas, quas communes vocant; ibid. pag. 88: res maxime universales et toti naturæ communes* (where motion and rest are spoken of).

(vere), and at the same time recall the proposition that limitation is only negation, it is easily seen that the proper meaning of: *that which is common* cannot be: the abstract element common to several really separate things; for according to their truth things do not exist as single; but that the expression must designate the *positive unity running through the many apparently single things*.¹⁾ On the whole we must remember that number, plurality, has no real meaning for Spinoza, since substance is not determined thereby; the consequences that follow from the presupposition of number as a reality must therefore vanish. *Notiones communes* thus become the ideas of the positive One, and they are therefore also communes in the sense that they are common to all the single men; for the existence of these as single, too, is after all only a semblance; they are only parts of the self-knowing idea. The subjective and the objective moment are in unity in this concept (cf. Eth. II, 38. Coroll. with prop. 37, 38 and 47, dem.).

From *notiones communes* are distinguished first and foremost *termini transscendentes* (such as ens, res, aliquid), and the commonly so-called¹⁾ *notiones universales* (such as man, horse, etc.). The former have their origin in the fact that the human body, as limited, is receptive only to a certain number of images (impressions) in distinct form, so that the images, when this number is exceeded, begin to become confused, and when it is exceeded to a high degree, are completely mingled together. But the human mind can distinctly represent to itself only as many bodies at once as there can be distinct images simultaneously in the body. When the images in the body are completely mingled together, the mind will represent them confusedly, without any distinction, and comprehend them under one concept, such as res, aliquid. — The so-called *notiones universales* have a similar origin. For so many images, e.g. of men, are formed at once in the human body that they do not indeed completely surpass the power of representation, but yet so far that the mind cannot represent to itself the small individual differences and their determinate number, but represents distinctly only that in which they all, insofar as the body is affected by them, agree, and this one designates by the universal name, and predicates it of the infinitely many single ones. But since these concepts have such an origin, they are not formed in the same way by all, but are different in each individual, in

¹⁾As a parallel one may here recall Geulincx's designation of God and the corporeal world as res singulares, outside which there were only modes of existence. One easily sees that for Spinoza the determinations realism and nominalism in the scholastic sense acquire no meaning; nor do they through propositions such as: universalium — — quæ non sunt, nec ullam habent præter singularem essentiam. Cog. metaph. II, c. 7.

¹⁾For at the beginning of Schol. 2 *notio universalis* is used in a wider sense. — As synonyms Spinoza uses: *entia metaphysica* (Eth. II, 48. schol.), *ideæ universales* (Ep. 50) and *notiones abstractæ*; the knowledge obtained through those concepts is a *cognitio abstracta vel universalis* (Eth. IV. 62 schol.). Of God's essence we cannot, since he is not determined by plurality, form a *universalis idea* (Ep. 50).

proportion to that by which the body has most frequently been affected, and which the mind most easily represents to itself or remembers (thus at the name man the one thinks first of the upright figure, the other of man's being an animal bipes, risibile, sine plumis, rationale, etc.), so that at bottom these universales notiones are *universales imagines*, [99] which each forms according to the disposition of his body (Eth. II. 40, schol. 1.).

Next, there are distinguished from notiones communes, since these express something really existing, the modi imaginandi,¹⁾ which have no corresponding existence, but have significance only as aids for imagination in holding fast, determining and representing things; thus the determinations: *species, genus, time, number, measure, opposition, order, agreement, difference* and the like, as well as those designations of something negative which express a "confused affirmation", e.g. *end, limit, darkness*;²⁾ likewise the determinations which designate only a defect in our knowledge, such as: the *possible*, the *contingent* (see above); fictions such as: *accidentia realia, formæ substantiales, qualitates occultæ*, and finally such determinations as only express a relation to us as single beings, not a determination of the essence of things,³⁾ such as *order-confusion, good-evil, beautiful-ugly* and the like (cf. chapter 6).

The *general* determinations of imagination thus do not express something existing and rich in content, but only an unreal abstraction, a generalized single, whose content is blurred, or they express only the state of imagination itself, not the nature of things. They are furthermore differently modified in each individual, since what underlies them is the single in its difference.

Through the different point of departure the character of rational knowledge becomes a different one. Notiones communes express, conceived from the fundamental concept, [100] not a confused abstraction, but the existing in its full unity; they express at the same time something real, and, since in thought the unreal separation of the single is cancelled, they express this real in the same original way in all, and become universally valid axioms.¹⁾

If one starts from this determination of notiones communes, which is the consistent one according to Spinoza's fundamental view, one has in it an essential distinction from the determinations of imagination, and intellectual knowledge can simply be opposed

¹⁾Entia non rationis, sed imaginationis. Eth. I, 36. schol. Yet the expression entia rationis is not seldom used, just as Spinoza too can set, as the opposite of what is in things, that which [is] merely in *intellectu* (de intell. emend. pag. 386).

²⁾Conversely, the infinite positive, which is only in intellectu, not in imaginatione, is designated negatively, e.g. *incorporeum, infinitum*.

³⁾Ep. 6. Notiones ex vulgi usu factæ, vel quæ naturam explicant, non ut in se est, sed prout ad sensum humanum refertur.

^{1*)}Opinionibus et documentis humano generi universalibus, hoc est notionibus *communibus et veris*;" (tract. theol.-pol. pag. 50). — Ex axiomatis intellectualibus per se notis (ibid. pag. 62). — On the relation between definition and axiom cf. Ep. 26 f.

to that of imagination as the one that rests on the true ideas, whose series proceeds in the mind in agreement with the series of real objects, in the concatenation of cause and effect, and in such a way that the mind is an automaton spirituale acting according to determinate laws.²⁾ But the difficulty comes forward when the relation between the second and third kinds of knowledge is to be determined, and the determination of this relation reacts upon the conception of the relation between ratio and imaginatio and once more makes the distinction unsettled. It will appear that the deeper reason for the difficulties that arise here is the general stumbling block of Spinoza's philosophy: the conception of the finite.

[101] The knowledge of reason (ratio) is posited as adequate and true;³⁾ it apprehends things not as contingent and untruly single, but as necessary and under the form of eternity. It leads to the knowledge of God, and the idea of God that it gives is adequate and perfect. But nevertheless the third kind of knowledge, intuitive knowledge, is posited as something higher, which gives a more excellent kind of knowledge (Eth. V, 36. schol.). If the ground of this superiority is to be stated, it is stated thus: that in that *universal knowledge* (cognitio universalis) the proof of the dependence of things on God, both with regard to essence and existence, is conducted *generaliter* and applied to the single thing, whereas in intuitive knowledge it is conducted from the very essence of the single thing. In this conception *notiones communes* then acquire the meaning of concepts of what is common to homogeneous things, which express not the individual essence of things but a *proprietas*.¹⁾ They thus come to express something abstract, and are therefore brought together with *axiomata intellectualia*, which are true but abstract.²⁾ Since the second kind of knowledge is called universal ("cognitio universalis, quam secundi generis esse dixi". Eth. V, 36. schol.), it is designated by the same expression that was used for the determinations of imagination; its concepts are called, like the general representations of imagination, *notiones universales* (Eth. II, 40. schol. 2); and since universal knowledge is conceived as general and abstract (de intell. emend. p. 381), but the general and abstract leads into the domain of imagination,³⁾ the limits between the latter and that of reason

²⁾De intell. emend. pag. 384. The expression automaton spir. is found already in Descartes (passions de l'âme Art. 16).

³⁾Cognitio *secundi* et *tertii* [generis] est necessario vera. Eth. II, 41. cf. V. 28. dem. In the Ethics IV, 31 the designation ratio is used so that it comprises both the second and the third kind of knowledge.

¹⁾Cf. Eth. II, 40. schol. 2; 39, dem. V, 12, dem. and the determination of the different kinds of knowledge in de intell. emend.

²⁾De intell. emend. pag. 380; cf. pag. 386: ex axiomatis solis universalibus non potest intellectus ad singularia descendere, quandoquidem axiomata ad infinita se extendunt, nec intellectum magis ad unum quam ad aliud singulare contemplandum determinant.

³⁾Cf. De intell. emend. pag. 363 Note h., 372, 376. On pag. 383 f. abstract, universal knowledge is expressly traced back to imagination.

become uncertain.

In contrast to this abstract and universal knowledge, the *third* kind of knowledge proceeds from the concept of God (*natura, fons et origo naturæ, ens unicum, infinitum, quod est omne esse, et præter quod non datur esse*), which cannot be conceived abstractly or universally, and from the adequate knowledge of the attributes is derived the adequate [102] knowledge of the essence of things, which follows from the necessity of the divine nature. It apprehends the ideas in their concatenation as one idea, so that the mind subjectively expresses the objective essence of nature; its knowledge of the effects becomes only a fuller knowledge of the cause. It derives nothing from the abstract, but from “*essentia particularis affirmativa*”,¹⁾ and “*ens physicum et reale*”, or from “a true and lawful definition”, i.e. one which states not merely properties of the thing, but the thing’s *intima essentia*, from which all its properties can be derived, and which does this in an affirmative form. The series that knowledge forms in the ideas is “the series of the fixed and eternal things”, not the unsurveyable “series of single, changeable things”, since the existence of these things has no connection with their essence, or, in other words, is not an “eternal truth” (*æterna veritas*). These “abiding and eternal things”, which are all simul *natura*, are, although single, nevertheless, on account of their omnipresence (*ubique præsentia*) and all-embracing power (*latissima potentia*), for us as it were universal or general definitions (*genera definitionum*) of the single and changeable things,²⁾ and proximate causes of everything; in them, as in the true law-books, are inscribed the laws according to which all single things come into being and are determined; indeed these changeable and single things are so inwardly and essentially (*intime et essentialiter*) dependent on those abiding ones that they can neither be nor be understood without them (*de intell. emend. 388 ff.*).³⁾

If, however, one compares what has thus been posited as peculiar to the third kind of [103] knowledge with what is peculiar to the second, the distinction becomes difficult. The latter too is supposed to be able to give clear and adequate ideas, and to derive from these other clear and adequate ones. But in deriving ideas from others, it knows the effect from the cause, and this cannot merely be conceived thus, that ratio, within the concatenation of the single ideas, should be able to extract adequate ideas, but not set them in connection with God, since this would conflict with the concept of adequate apprehension; for it

¹⁾De intell. emend. pag. 388: Optima conclusio erit depromenda ab essentia aliqua particulari affirmativa. Quo enim specialior est idea, eo distinctior, ac proinde clarior est. Unde cognitio particularium quam maxime nobis quærenda est.

²⁾Thus “the laws of nature extend to infinitely many things, and are apprehended by us under a form of eternity”, tract. theol.-polit. pag. 72.

³⁾Concerning the conception of the existence of things through God’s essence cf. Eth. V, 30, dem. 36, schol.

apprehends things as they are according to their essence, and according to their essence they are in God¹⁾. Knowledge is adequate precisely only when the effect is led back to God, who is the *causa absolute proxima* of all things (Eth. I, 28), in whom they are contained, and from the necessity of whose nature they follow (Eth. V, 29. schol.). But when this happens, the difference between *ratio* and *scientia intuitiva* would vanish, since God, who cannot be conceived abstractly or universally, immediately shows himself as what really is in the thing, and the thing, apprehended adequately, hence under the form of necessity and eternity, is immediately led back to the first cause. — If one would, as might seem hinted in the treatise *de intell. emend.*, by the second kind of knowledge think chiefly of the inference from effect to cause or from abstracta to abstracta, then the former would lead to “mutilated and confused ideas”, the latter to the *universalia* of imagination, hence in neither case to an adequate knowledge.

[104] The difficulty arises from the ambiguous position of the finite. If the strict concept of infinite substance is held fast, then, as was developed above in chapter 2, one can neither immediately nor mediately arrive at something finite, hence not at a subsisting plurality, but the latter is the presupposition of the abstract, universal conception. The object of knowledge would then be one, the apprehension of it in its fullness necessarily intuitive, since its being is undivided, infinite and eternal. The adequate idea would have only the infinite as its object, for it expresses its object under the form of eternity and necessity¹⁾, and therein lies infinity; it is the affirmation of thought, but the limitation of the finite is a negation. But the borrowed, fleeting existence that must be given to the finite (cf. chapter 2) gives a point of attachment for the kind of knowledge that belongs to mathematics, and for which Spinoza’s historical situation must have made it natural to him to claim a place. This, however, he cannot procure without confounding the determinations of reason and of imagination. The foundation of imagination is the single, abstract as single, which does not exist for reason; abstract knowledge presupposes such a single, even if only as leaving it behind; otherwise it would not become abstract, universal, but individual and intuitive. The indeterminate thus comes in this way to stand in a doubtful relation to the infinite, “the true abstract” in a doubtful relation to the untrue abstraction of imagination; but this uncertainty and contradiction was the consequence of the uncertainty in the metaphysical relation between the infinite and the finite. According to the consistent conception of the concept of substance, the

¹⁾Cf. Eth. V, 29. schol. 30, dem.

¹⁾Thus no agreement could arise between *intellectus* and *imaginatio*, which Spinoza nevertheless concedes (cf. *de intell. emend.* pag. 384, Ep. 29. Eth. V, 12), although the limits are not drawn and cannot be drawn. Since the mathematical figures are called *entia rationis*, i.e. *imaginationis* (Ep. 72; *de intell. emend.* pag. 387), they become a point of contact.

second kind of knowledge would have to vanish in the third; but in this infinity the individual thought itself vanishes in the infinite, philosophy becomes inexplicable, the philosophizing thought comes into contradiction with itself, and this contradiction forces upon the finite a kind of subsistence, which nevertheless cannot be determined without new contradictions coming forward.

The doctrine of the different forms of *knowledge* is decisive for Spinoza's conception of the human mind, whose essence was determined by knowledge, and for which there [105] was no principle of individuation. The *idea* is, as a *modus* of thought, by its nature prior to the other *modi* of thought¹⁾. Since it is conceived as active, it includes the *will* within itself: "will and intellect are one and the same" (Eth. II, 49. Coroll.). For the will (*voluntas*) is determined by Spinoza as *facultas affirmandi et negandi*, i.e. as the faculty by which the mind affirms and denies the true and the false (not as the desire by which the mind desires or shuns a thing). But the determination: *faculty*, is only an *ens metaphysicum sive universale*, which we form by abstraction from the single; and *voluntas* therefore comes to relate to the single *volitiones* as *lapideitas* to *lapis*, i.e. it is in reality not different from them. But since the will thus becomes the single affirmation or negation, it becomes equal to the *idea*, since in the mind there is no other affirmation and negation than that which the *idea*, as *idea*, includes. Thus, e.g., the *volitio* by which the mind affirms that the triangle's three angles are equal to two right angles is not different from the affirmation that lies in the *idea* of the triangle, which *idea* is the condition of that affirmation, and in turn cannot be thought without it, so that their concept coincides (Eth. II, 49. dem.). The single *volitio* thus becomes equal to the single *idea*, *voluntas* to *intellectus*. Conceived as single, *volitiones*, like every other single thing, must be determined to existence and action by another single thing; they are thus necessary (Eth. I, 32), and the human mind, conceived as a determinate and limited *modus* of thought, can no more have an absolute faculty of willing and not willing (an absolute and free will) than it can, under the same conception, have an absolute faculty of understanding (Eth. II, 48); it cannot become the free cause (*causa libera*) of its actions, but is determined [106] from without with necessity.

In the conception of the will, therefore, Spinoza must distinctly separate himself from Descartes, who, since he posited in God a freedom of arbitrariness, at the same time, despite the consequences of his fundamental view, conceded a similar one to man, and, by determining the human will as infinite, hence wider in extent than limited knowledge,

¹⁾Eth. II. axiom. 3.: "Modi cogitandi, ut amor, cupiditas, vel quicunque nomine affectus animi insigniuntur, non dantur nisi in eodem individuo detur *idea rei amatae, desideratae &c.* At *idea* dari potest, quamvis nullus alius detur cogitandi *modus*."

sought a ground of explanation for error, whereby the latter could be conceived, in relation to God, as a mere negation, and only in relation to man became a privation. Spinoza indeed concedes that the will has a wider extent than the clear and distinct ideas; but not than *perceptiones sive concipiendi facultas* in general, since this too, in the same way as the will, can *successively* take in infinitely many things. The conception of the will as infinite he derives from the misunderstood use of the abstract concept: faculty, that is applied to it; for since the abstract, the universal, is predicated equally of one, of several and of infinitely many particulars, whose common element it expresses, one can give it an infinite extension beyond the domain of determinate knowledge; and the same abstract conception¹⁾ likewise brings it about that the will, determined as affirmation, is predicated in general of every idea without regard to its content, and of the true and the false, so that with the power of the *same* will we affirm all ideas, and predicate the true and the false as true, whereas the ideas according to their essence contain a different degree of reality, so that the affirmations contained in them must also include a similar one, and whereas the true and the false relate to each other as ens to non-ens. The faculty of arbitrarily suspending one's judgment, too, Spinoza denies, [107] since suspending one's judgment becomes nothing other than that we see that we do not understand the thing adequately. Even in imagination there lies an affirmation, as long as another representation does not exclude the existence of the represented object. As long as this does not take place, one cannot doubt the reality of one's representation, although: *not to doubt*, is not synonymous with: *to have certainty*, which only the true idea gives. If I represent to myself, e.g., a winged horse, then I predicate (affirm) wings of the horse, and I will, according to the nature of imagination, regard the winged horse as existing as long as I have this representation alone, and only doubt the representation or deny it when another idea cancels this representation or shows it to be inadequate; but then my doubt and my denial will be *necessary*. — The ground for the freedom of the will that is drawn from its being indispensable in order to cancel the perfect state of indifference, Spinoza rejects, mockingly, since it is incompatible with his conception of the activity of thought: dico, me omnino concedere, quod homo, in tali æquilibrio [like Buridan's ass] positus (nempe qui nihil aliud percipit, quam sitim et famem, talem cibum et talem potum, qui æque ab eo distant) fame et siti peribit. Si me rogant, an talis homo non potius asinus quam homo sit æstimandus, dico me nescire, ut etiam nescio, quanti æstimandus sit ille, qui se pensilem facit, et quanti æstimandi sint pueri stulti, vesani &c.

After Spinoza, in the 2nd book of the Ethics, has developed his doctrine of the nature

¹⁾Eth. II, 49. schol.: hic apprime venit notandum, quam facile decipimur, quando universalis cum singularibus et entia rationis et abstracta cum realibus confundimus.

of the human mind, he emphasizes, against the objections that would naturally occur to his contemporaries, the advantages of his conception, and he places these in: 1) that it, by teaching us that in our action we are unconditionally dependent on God, and in our essence partakers of the divine nature, and that in all the higher degree the more perfectly we act and the more we understand God, — calms our mind and shows us wherein our highest happiness or blessedness consists, namely *solely in the knowledge of God*, by which we are led to do only what love and piety bid, and to regard virtue itself and dependence on God as reward, freedom and beatitude; — 2) that it gives us [108] equanimity in the face of what is not in our power (i.e. what does not follow from our nature), because we know that everything follows with the same necessity from God's eternal decretum as the properties of the triangle follow from its essence; — 3) that it contributes to furthering social life, since it teaches us not to hate, despise, mock, be angry or envy, and since it makes everyone content with his own and inclined to help his neighbor, not from womanish pity, partiality or superstition, but solely at the prompting of reason; — 4) finally in this, that it is of no small use to society, since it shows in what way the citizens must be governed and led, namely so that they do not become slaves, but freely do what is best (Eth. II, 49. schol.). — What Spinoza has here emphasized as the “use” of his doctrine will find its closer development and understanding in the following chapters. For through the determination of the kinds of knowledge, and of the relation between the idea and the other modi of thought, such as will, desire and the like, the foundation is given for the conception of what specifically makes up the content of the Spinozistic ethics¹⁾: the doctrine of *man in his bondage and in his freedom*, and of this the next three sections will give an account.

Chapter Six.

Man as naturæ pars. The Affects. Man's Bondage.

The thought of necessity, which in Spinoza governs the conception of nature in its unity with God and as the infinite series of individual things, must also govern the conception of the human being as acting and suffering. Since Spinoza proceeds from [109]

¹⁾“Ethica universalis”, tract. theol.-polit. pag. 46.

the concept of substance, he cannot conceive man as detached from nature's eternal, all-embracing order, as a state within its state, governed and determined only by his own groundless, unconditioned freedom. He cannot regard that which, as occurring in the human mind, betrays its impotence and inconstancy, as something accidental, as an object of lament, mockery and abhorrence, but only as something that must be comprehended in its necessity through the power of nature, that must be derived with mathematical strictness from the natural causes¹⁾. "Nothing happens in nature that can be ascribed to a defect in it; for nature is always the same and everywhere one, and its power (virtus) and power of action are always the same; that is to say: the laws and rules of nature, according to which everything happens and everything is changed from one form into another, are everywhere and always the same, and the conception of the nature of any thing whatsoever must therefore always be the same, namely through the universal laws and rules of nature. The affects of hatred, of anger, of envy and the like therefore follow, when they are considered according to their essence (in se), from the same necessity and power (virtus) of nature as the other individual things, and therefore have definite causes, through which they are known, and certain properties, which are just as worthy of being comprehended by us as the properties of any other thing, in [110] the mere contemplation of which we delight. I shall therefore treat of the nature and strength of the affects and the mind's power over them in the same manner in which I have treated of the essence of God and of the mind, and I shall consider human actions and appetites just as if the question were of lines, planes or bodies" (Eth. III. præfat.)¹⁾.

The ethics that can find its place in the Spinozistic system cannot, then, rest on the presupposition of an individual freedom, cannot set *tasks* which freedom is to realize through a choice, cannot speak of a good or evil determined by this choice. It becomes *the natural science of the human mind*; its task is not to make a demand on man, but to see the human being in the light of nature's eternal and necessary laws, and, by these laws, which express an activity, to derive what follows with eternal necessity from the concept of the human being. This task at once takes on a different form according to the twofold conception of the finite, inasmuch as man's essence is considered either as

¹⁾cf. tract. polit. Cap. I, 4: ut ea, quæ ad hanc scientiam [i.e. politicam] spectant, eadem animi libertate, qua res mathematicas solemus, inquirerem, sedulo curavi, humanas actiones non ridere, non lugere, neque detestari, sed intelligere: atque adeo humanos affectus, ut sunt amor, odium, ira, invidia, gloria, misericordia et reliquæ animi commotiones non ut humanæ naturæ vitia, sed ut proprietates contemplatus sum, quæ ad ipsam ita pertinent, ut ad naturam æris æstus, frigus, tempestas, tonitru et alia huiusmodi, quæ tametsi incommoda sunt, necessaria tamen sunt, certasque habent causas, per quas eorum naturam intelligere conamur, et mens eorum vera contemplatione æque gaudet, ac earum rerum cognitione, quæ sensibus grata sunt.

¹⁾Eth. IV. 57. schol.: Sane humani affectus, si non humanam, naturæ saltem potentiam et artificium non minus indicant, quam multa alia, quæ admiramur, quorumque contemplatione delectamur.

abstractly finite or in its unity with the infinite. In the former sense it is seen under the law of external necessity, in the latter under that of internal necessity, of freedom, since it is seen in unity with the only *causa libera*; in the former, then, man is conceived in his state of bondage, in the latter in his freedom. Spinoza keeps these two conceptions apart from each other, except insofar as the general determinations can be applied to both points of view and the definitions comprise both. He first develops the consequences of the first way of considering, in order through them to lead it back to the latter.

If man is first conceived in general as a single *modus* in the infinite, then he is determined as *acting* and *suffering*. “I call it *acting* when something happens in us or outside us of which we are the *adequate cause*, i.e. when something follows from our [111] nature, in us or outside us, that can be understood clearly and distinctly through it alone. On the other hand I call it *suffering* when something happens in us, or when something follows from our nature of which we are only the partial (inadequate) cause” (Eth. III, def. 2)¹⁾.

Since from the essence of every existing thing an effect always follows, man must always be determined, and this determinateness is the *affect*²⁾: *per affectum intelligo corporis affectiones, quibus ipsius corporis agendi potentia augetur vel minuitur, juvatur vel coercetur, et simul harum affectionum ideas* (Eth. III. def. 3.)³⁾.

This general definition of the affect now receives its closer determination through what was developed in the preceding chapters about the nature of the mind, about the relation of the attributes to each other, and about substance as acting. The mind is acting insofar as it has adequate ideas, since their effects are comprehended through the essence of the human mind alone; it is suffering insofar as it has inadequate ones, i.e. insofar as it “has something that includes a negation”, or insofar as it is considered as a part of nature which cannot be understood clearly and distinctly without other parts. The more [112] inadequate ideas the mind has, the more, then, is it exposed to passions (passive states); the more adequate, the more is it acting (Eth. III, 1. 3. schol. cf. chapter 5 and Eth. II, 11. Coroll.). Reason and acting, imagination and suffering become parallels. — From the

¹⁾ *Causam adæquatam* appello eam, cuius effectus potest clare et distincte per eandem percipi. *Inadæquatam* autem seu *partialem* illam voco, cuius effectus per ipsam solam intelligi nequit (Eth. III. def. 1). cf. Eth. IV. App. C. 1: Omnes nostræ cupiditates ex necessitate nostræ naturæ ita sequuntur, ut vel per ipsam solam tanquam per proximam causam possint intelligi, vel quatenus naturæ sumus pars, quæ per se absque aliis individuis non potest adæquate concipi.”

²⁾ Eth. III, 56. dem.: prout unusquisque — — afficitur, hoc est, prout eius natura hoc aut alio modo constituitur. — Eth. III. Affect. def. 1. explic.: per affectionem humanæ essentiæ quamcumque eiusdem essentiæ constitutionem intelligimus, sive ea sit innata, sive quod ipsa per solum cogitationis sive per solum extensionis attributum concipiatur, sive denique quod ad utrumque simul referatur.

³⁾ This definition is general, since the affect becomes an acting when we are the adequate cause of the affection, in the opposite case a suffering (ibid. explic.).

relation of the attributes to each other it follows that neither can the body determine the mind to think nor the mind the body to motion or rest (Eth. III, 2), so that the acting and suffering states of the body and of the mind are not consequences of each other, but are *simul natura*, and the mind's appetite and the body's determination are one and the same thing, which is only designated by different names (*decretum — determinatio*) according as it is seen under the two different attributes. — From the nature of substance as active it follows that the individual *modi*, as things which in a definite and limited way express God's attributes, also express his *potentia* (which is equal to his essence), and since a thing's essence can only affirm, not deny, itself, every thing can be annihilated only by an external cause, and it must, as far as it is in itself (*in se*), strive¹⁾ without any temporal limitation, to persist in its being²⁾, and this striving is the very essence of the [113] thing (Eth. III, 6 f.) and is found in the human mind both insofar as it is constituted by adequate and by inadequate ideas¹⁾. This striving, which is thus the simple expression of the actual essence as active, is the first fundamental affect. If it is referred to the mind alone, it is called *will* (*voluntas*); if it is referred both to mind and body, it is called *appetite* (*appetitus*), and this is thus nothing other than the very essence of man, from whose nature that which serves for its preservation follows with necessity, in such a way that man is determined to bring it about. From *appetitus* *cupiditas* is distinguished only in that it is as a rule referred to man insofar as he is conscious of his appetite (*cupiditas est appetitus cum eiusdem conscientia*, Eth. III, 9. schol.)

To appetite as fundamental affect, when the human being is conceived as an individual, limited link in the infinite chain of causes and effects, and its power of action is thus conceived as one which can be both increased and diminished, two others must now attach themselves: the one which expresses the transition to a greater, and the one which

¹⁾The *conatus* is conceived as a striving *to preserve* what is already present: Eth. III, 12. 13. cf. 25. 7. Coroll. 3. dem. 28 f.

²⁾*Unaquæque res, quantum in se est, in suo esse perseverare conatur* (Eth. III. 6). The expression *in se* is striking here, since strictly speaking it can be said only of substance that it is in *se*. There perhaps lies in it an intimation that the thing conceived as individual is active only in *its unity with substance*. Conceived as an individual link in the infinite chain, the human mind could, consistently, no more be conceived as active than it can have adequate ideas. What Spinoza develops from a Cartesian standpoint in *Cog. metaph. II. c. 12* finds no application to his own, which conceives the mind as *modus*, not as *finite substance*. — Perhaps, however, the expression: *quantum in se est*, might be merely an incorrect usage for: *quantum in ea est*, which expression is always used in the tract. theol.-polit. and the tract. polit. where this thought comes forward (cf. also Eth. IV. App. c. 25). The old Dutch translation gives no enlightenment, since it translates quite according to the words: "Yder ding poogt, voor zo veel als't in zich is, in zyn wesen te volharden."

¹⁾One must remember here that Spinoza, in considering the mind as the idea of the existing body, conceives this idea as composed of many other ideas, of which some are adequate, others inadequate (cf. Eth. III, 3. dem. II, 15. 19. 38), and that the inadequate ideas, which, referred back to God, are adequate, develop with the same consistency as the adequate ones (Eth. II, 36).

expresses the transition to a lesser perfection: *joy* and *sorrow*²⁾. Only these and appetite can be fundamental affects; from them all others must be derived.

Since the mind is determined as *idea corporis*, it follows, with regard to the three [114] fundamental affects, that there can be no idea in the mind which excludes the existence of the body, since such an idea would conflict with the essence of the mind, but that, on the contrary, the nature of the mind must first and foremost express itself in affirming the existence of the body¹⁾, and that it, since the idea of all that increases or diminishes our body's power to act²⁾ must increase or diminish the mind's own power to think³⁾, must have a striving to hold fast the idea which affirms the essence of the human body and to remove the one which denies it⁴⁾ (Eth. III, 10–13). With the last determination we have already arrived at the first of the derived affects: *love* and *hatred*, which in reality are nothing other than *joy and sorrow accompanied by the idea of the external cause* (Eth. [115] II, 13. schol.), and whose peculiar character becomes clear from what has already been developed.

In the deduction of the derived affects the Spinozistic fundamental view comes forward with a sharply marked peculiarity. In it he gives a *natural history of the passions*, and regards, with the naturalist's dispassionate calm, passion as a natural phenomenon proceeding with necessity from the human being. In the fundamental affects this being found, in its determinateness, its most general expression, but this general expression is now individualized by supervening factors, and from the different combinations the derived passions proceed as necessary products.

Their multiplicity is grounded partly in the nature of imagination and memory, which

²⁾*Lætitia* is: *passio, qua mens ad maiorem perfectionem transit*; — *tristitia* is: *passio, qua mens ad maiorem transit perfectionem* (Eth. II, 11. schol.) cf. Eth. III, 57. dem.: *lætitia et tristitia est ipsa cupiditas sive appetitus, quatenus a causis externis augetur vel minuitur, juvatur vel coercetur, hoc est, est ipsa cuiusque natura*. They are referred most nearly to the mind alone, *hilaritas* and *melancholia*, on the other hand, to the whole human being.

¹⁾When the mind is conceived as *idea ideæ*, it expresses itself as a striving to represent to itself what affirms its own power of acting, and when it considers itself and its power of acting, it feels joy (Eth. III, 53 f. cf. V, 15. dem.), whereas it feels sorrow when it represents to itself its impotence, i.e. when its striving to represent to itself what affirms its power of acting is hindered (Eth. III, 55. dem.)

²⁾Spinoza sets it up as a postulate that the human body can be affected in many ways by which its power of action is increased or diminished, and likewise in other ways which neither increase nor diminish it. He refers to the lemmas from physics (Eth. II, 13), and from this reference it seems to follow that the increase or decrease of the power of action must be thought to take place through the parts of the body, while the mutual communication of motion is retained, becoming larger or smaller, and through the body as a whole, likewise with that relation retained, being set in motion or rest (Eth. III, postul. 1).

³⁾*Quum supra dixerim, mentis cogitandi potentiam augeri vel minui, nihil aliud intelligere volui, quam quod mens ideam sui corporis vel alicuius eius partis formaverit, quæ plus minusve realitatis exprimit quam de suo corpore affirmaverat. Nam idearum præstantia et actualis cogitandi potentia ex objecti præstantia æstimatur* (Affect. gener. defin., explic.).

⁴⁾The latter happens through an opposite idea being remembered (held fast).

makes it possible to preserve the impression of the affections after the external objects are no longer present, and thereby to combine the passions and to set one against another; — partly in the nature of the human body as composite, since it can thus be affected in several ways at once; — partly in the interaction with the external objects, in the affection by their affections, in the collisions with their passions; — partly in the representation of the objects' difference of degree, and finally — what makes the nuancing infinite — in the infinite diversity of individuals and in the infinite multiplicity of external objects. But through all the derived passions the fundamental passions show themselves, and in reality the former are only these very ones, named with different names according to their different relations and denominationes extrinsecæ (Eth. III. Affect. defin. 48. explic.).

An affection that has taken place simultaneously with another must, according to the laws of the association of ideas, repeat itself when this other repeats itself (Eth. III, 14), and thus any object can per accidens become the cause of joy, sorrow and appetite (thus arise sympathia, antipathia, propensio, aversio, desiderium; prop. 15), and of the [116] passions derived from them (III, 50). In consequence of the property of imagination that the image of the affecting thing is preserved until the thing's existence is excluded by another idea, the represented non-present must act as something present until other ideas make it uncertain or deny it (spes, metus, securitas, desperatio; prop. 18)¹⁾.

In the relation to the external object it follows from the nature of the appetite for self-preservation that, just as with regard to ourselves we strive to affirm what gladdens and to deny what pains, we must have the same striving with regard to what we love, the opposite with regard to what we hate (pr. 25 f.), and that this striving must express itself both in representation and in action (pr. 28) insofar as it is not hindered by the representation of the consequences (metus, timor, verecundia, consternatio; prop. 39). The representation of the joy and pain of the beloved and of the hated must call forth in us joy and pain in opposite relation²⁾, and in degree determined by the degree of love and hatred. The cause of the beloved object's joy and of the hated one's pain must become the object of our love, the cause of the beloved's pain and of the hated one's joy, the object of our hatred (commiseratio, favor, indignatio, invidia; prop. 19–24). Love must include an appetite for love in return³⁾, and the joy this calls forth is determined by the

¹⁾Fear and hope are always bound together. Eth. III, 50. schol.

²⁾Yet the joy over the annihilation of the hated is mixed with sorrow, inasmuch as the hated is like us. Eth. III. 23. schol. 47.

³⁾The proof of this proposition is characteristic of Spinoza's conception. It is conducted thus: We strive, as far as is in our power, to represent to ourselves the object we love in preference to all other things. If it is like us, then, since the affection of what is like us, through representation (according to the laws of the

degree of love. If the one we love prefers another, love must turn into hatred (since the [117] appetite to represent the love in return is hindered), and the one preferred to us must become the object of jealousy (*zelotypia*). — The intensity of joy and sorrow, of love and hatred, must determine the intensity of the appetite arising from them. — Hatred arising from love must become more intense than if love had not gone before (since in all the greater appetite is hindered); the same must hold of love arising from hatred. The representation of unmerited hatred must call forth hatred toward the hater;¹⁾ the representation of undeserved love must call forth love. — Hatred must be strengthened by reciprocal hatred, but brought to waver by the representation of love in the one hated (*ira, vindicta, gratia, gratitudo*). Love and hatred toward what we represent to ourselves as free must become greater than toward what we represent to ourselves as necessary, since the free is represented by itself alone, the necessary together with something else, its cause (prop. 34–44. 49)²⁾.

Through *likeness* to what we hate or love an object can per accidens become an object of hatred or love; but since likeness at the same time presupposes difference, the same thing can become the object of a double passion (*animi fluctuatio*, which can also arise from the different influence of the same object on the composite human being; prop. 16 f. 46.). — An affect in the object like us must, when we do not already stand in a relation of affect to the object, through the representation of the affect call forth a similar one (for imagination includes the nature both of our body and of the external body, and insofar as they agree, the affects of the one are transferred to the other; — *commiseratio, æmulatio*), and the appetite which our own affections call forth is called forth by those of [118] what is like us. We must therefore strive to do what others regard with joy, and to avoid what others regard with displeasure (*benevolentia, misericordia, ambitio, humanitas, laus, vituperium, gloria, pudor, acquiescentia in se ipso, poenitentia, superbia*); we must be confirmed in our love and our hatred by the representation of agreement with those like us, while disagreement with them must call forth wavering between the opposite affects¹⁾ (prop. 27. 29. 30. 31. 45).

association of ideas, cf. pr. 27), calls forth a similar affection in us, we shall strive to call forth joy in it rather than in others, or, in other words, we shall strive that the beloved object feel joy accompanied by the representation of us, i.e. that it love us (*Eth. III, 33*). — When the individual is conceived as individual, it must be conceived as egoistic; but egoism in Spinoza is vanishing, just like finitude (cf. p. 70 f.).

¹⁾For likeness calls forth the same affect, and the fact that the hater is the only cause restricts the hatred to him.

²⁾For the same reason the object which has nothing peculiar to itself, but only what is common to several, will affect us only in a lesser degree (*admiratio, consternatio, horror, devotio, irrisio*). *Admiratio* is not an affect, but a reinforcing motive in the other affects.

¹⁾If the object of love can belong only to one, egoism must come forward (see Note 3, p. 116), and we must strive to bring it about that the one whom we represent to ourselves as rejoicing in it does not come

Finally, in the concept of the human body and of the affects lies what gives the possibility of infinitely many nuances and combinations: that the same object can affect different men differently and the same man differently at different times (pr. 51), that of each affect there are as many kinds as there are objects that affect us (since every affection includes the nature of the external object)²⁾ and that every individual's affects are different according to the difference of its essence, which expresses itself in the affects. (The passions of animals are different from the corresponding passions in men in the same degree as the essence of animals and of men is different: *fertur quidem equus et homo libidine procreandi, at ille libidine equina, hic autem humana*).

[119] In what has been developed, since man is conceived as a link in the infinite series, the affects have been conceived as *passiones*¹⁾, joy too; for although it might seem that this, as a transition to a greater perfection, would have to be an *actio*, there is nevertheless, through the quantitative difference in the relation between the adequate and the inadequate²⁾ ideas in man's mind, a possibility of thinking *an approximation* to the adequate which, so long as this has not yet been reached, must be called a *passio* (cf. Eth. III, 57. dem. 58. IV, 39. dem.).

The general determination of the affect, as a passive state in the *mind* (*animi pathema*), can now be given thus: it is *confusa idea, qua mens maiorem vel minorem sui corporis vel alicuius eius partis existendi vim quam antea*³⁾ *affirmat, et qua data ipsa mens ad hoc potius quam ad illud cogitandum determinatur* (Affect. gener. def.).

If one considers man, from the point of view that has been taken, in his relation to nature, and compares his power with the power of the external causes, then it will appear that the state dominated by the affects is to be conceived as a state of bondage, in which man's essence cannot assert itself. It follows, as an axiom, from the thought of the finite as individual, that there can be no individual thing without there being another individual thing which is stronger and by which the former can be destroyed (Eth. IV.

into possession of it; and thus the same peculiarity of human nature which was the reason why men were compassionate becomes the reason why they are envious and ambitious (prop. 32. cf. 55. schol.). — The same appetite of self-assertion, which lies so deep in human nature, also brings it about that humility and self-contempt (*humilitas* and *abjectio*) are so rare as passions, and that they are as a rule a cover for ambition and envy (*ambitio* and *invidia*) (Aff. def. 29. expl.).

²⁾Eth. III, 56. dem.: *natura uniuscuiusque passionis ita necessario debet explicari, ut obiecti, a quo afficimur, natura exprimatur.*

¹⁾In the conception of the passions as *passiones* one proceeds from the body alone (Eth. III, App., IV, 7); in speaking of them as *actiones*, from the mind; cf. tract. polit. II, 11: the strength of the mind, not of the body, determines human power (*potentia*).

²⁾Remember that: *ideas inadæquatas habere* is = *imaginari* = *pati*. cf. Eth. IV, 59 schol., V, 1. 11.

³⁾By these words there is not expressed a comparison with an earlier state; but "that the idea which constitutes the essence (*formam*) of the affect affirms something of the body which expresses a higher or lesser reality than the earlier." Through this affirming the mind passes over to a higher or lower perfection.

axiom.). The force with which man strives to preserve his existence must therefore, as [120] finite, be infinitely surpassed by the power of the external causes, so that it becomes impossible that he should not be subject to changes. Since the power and duration of an affect must be determined by the power of the external cause compared with ours, it can have an overwhelming power over our actiones, and man becomes constantly dependent on the passions and unable to defend himself against their power; he must follow and obey the general order of nature and accommodate himself to it as far as the nature of things requires. With mechanical necessity the affects struggle against each other in man; the stronger necessarily overcomes the weaker, and only an affect can remove an affect, since the bodily affection which underlies it must persist until it is removed by a stronger and opposite bodily affection.

The relative strength of the affects is calculated with mathematical certainty according to the determinations developed earlier. The present must act more strongly on us than the past and the future, and of these the nearer more strongly than the more remote. The necessary must have preponderance over the contingent, the past over the non-present contingent; the appetite that arises from joy must, other things being equal, become more powerful than the appetite that arises from sorrow. The knowledge of good and evil¹⁾, which is nothing other than the very affects of joy and sorrow as conscious, cannot overcome the affects by being true; for nothing positive in them is removed by the presence of the true²⁾; but only insofar as it is considered as an affect; and as such it can, since the appetite that arises from it must be comprehended through our essence [121] alone and be determined with regard to strength by our power alone (Eth. IV, dem.), be hindered and destroyed by many other appetites that arise from affects called forth from without, and that especially when their object is something present, while its object is something future or contingent (Eth. IV, 14–17).

From the state of bondage there is therefore no way out so long as man is conceived abstractly as individual. Just as the consequences of this conception in the theory of knowledge led to the impossibility of the mind's adequately conceiving itself, so that, as a merely *confused* idea, it came into conflict with its own concept as the idea of the body, so here too, consistently thought, the human being, which always remains suffering, comes into conflict with its own concept as active. Here too the task must be to remove this contradiction by conceiving the human being in its truth in the infinite, thus as free;

¹⁾For by good and evil is understood only what is useful or harmful to us, i.e. what increases or diminishes our power of action, thus that which calls forth the affect of joy and of sorrow, from which the idea of the affect is distinguished only in thought (Eth. IV, 8 dem.)

²⁾This is a consequence both of the equal relation of all ideas to God as adequate, and of the relation of imagination to the human body, whose affection remains even after the error is removed.

but since in the sphere of the infinite the relations of time have no significance, and a *transition* from the finite to the infinite becomes just as impossible as a transition from the latter to the former, the task cannot be to see man *successively liberating himself* from his state of bondage, but to comprehend him in his *eternally and necessarily existing freedom*, by which the bondage proves to be a semblance. Thus Spinoza conceives the matter in the last book of the Ethics, where he treats of human freedom; but as a preparation for this conception he gives developments which, while they still let the common conception of man held by representation stand as point of departure, and therefore seem to teach the *successive* liberation and to set this as a *task* for an action, on closer consideration show a necessary development of concepts and a leading back of the finite to its eternally existing essence. Yet it cannot be denied that at this point some uncertainty enters in Spinoza. While on the one hand (see below) he conceives the [122] adequate knowledge of God, in which freedom is given, as *belonging to man's* essence, thus as eternally existing; conceives human nature as a unity (*res particularis æterna*), in which men represented as individuals are so united that their drive of self-preservation, through this common element, is a drive to the preservation of the nature of other men; and lets all limitation, even that which seems to take on positive forms, like crime, vanish as something merely negative, yet on the other hand the separation of individuality asserts itself: what belonged to the human essence is posited as something rare (Eth. IV. App. c. 13. V, 42. schol.), and what was conceived as vanishing gets power to hold thought fast, so that thought, on the vanishing foundation, can erect a kind of pedagogy and a politics; and even where the human mind is conceived in its freedom and in its being in God, it still preserves its *determinate* existence in the divine intellectus (Eth. V. 40. schol.). The same urge which in the domain of the purely metaphysical forced finitude forward makes itself felt here; but here it has gained a greater intensity through the unconsciously working sympathy for the humane.

As a preparation for the true conception of human freedom Spinoza first develops *what reason prescribes with regard to the affects*, and, since a standard for judging them is thereby given, he determines them as *good* or *evil* according to their agreement with human nature; and since through these developments the relation between the *free man* and the *slave* comes forward, the way is prepared for decisively letting *liberation* show itself as an *existing* freedom.

The determination of what reason demands of us with regard to the affects becomes, since "*the demand of reason*" and "nature's appetite" are the same thing named with two names, equivalent to what follows from the concept of the human being, *idea hominis*,

which is not an ideal of the imagination¹⁾, but the expression for the human being as res particularis æterna (cf. de intell. emend. p. 388 f.). This is set up as *exemplar humanæ naturæ, quod intueamur* (Eth. IV. præf.), and since man represented as individual is referred to it as to his truth, the otherwise merely subjective and relative¹⁾ designations: *good* and *evil*, *perfect* and *imperfect*, find an application, justified from the standpoint of the individual, to that which approaches or recedes from this model, in such a way that *good* becomes that which we know with certainty to be useful to us, *evil* the opposite (Eth. IV. def. 1 and 2)¹⁾. [123] [124]

Reason cannot demand anything that conflicts with nature; since, therefore, everyone according to the necessary laws of his nature desires the useful and flees the harmful, reason must demand that everyone love himself, that he seek what is truly useful to him, that he desire what leads to a greater perfection, and, in general, that he strive, as far as his power reaches, to preserve his being. This is the demand of reason because it is the necessity of nature. *This striving is virtue itself*. Virtue is equal to man's very

¹⁾We form such a one, e.g., when, from confused images of the outward shape of many individual men, we form a universal representation of man, and now refer the individual men to this ideal.

¹⁾As these concepts are usually conceived, they designate nothing real in things considered in and for themselves; but are only modes of representation which we form according to the accidental relation of things to us (in such a way that the same thing can be called good, evil or indifferent according to our individual difference), or when we compare things with one another or with a universal representation, and then conceive the fact that the individual thing expresses less reality as a defect in its essence. But since the same law of necessity governs everything, and since everything that is and happens depends on the necessity of the infinite divine nature, everything becomes perfect according to the degree of its essence (for perfection is equal to reality, being); there remains no room for anything imperfect; nothing belongs to the nature of any thing other than what, according to the concatenation of things, follows from the determinateness of the efficient cause, and what follows from it happens necessarily. Nothing can happen against God's will, i.e. against the law of the divine nature, not even what we call crimes and the like; for that expresses not a determination of essence, something positive, but only a negation. In Nero's matricide, thus, the positive was not the crime, but the outward action and the intention, which were the same as Orestes' action and intention. What constituted the crime was that by this action he showed himself ungrateful, disobedient and without compassion. But none of this expresses essence, and therefore God is not the cause of it, although he is the cause of Nero's action and intention. The negative in the action vanishes when it is led back to God, just as the negative in the inadequate ideas vanishes by this leading back, and just as the limitation and negation in the finite modi are cancelled when they, under their apparent individuality and infinite change, are seen to be, with limitation cancelled, in the unchangeable, infinite One. In inadequate, imperfect knowledge therefore lies the origin of all those modes of representation, and they lose their significance with it (cf. Eth. I, 36. schol. IV. præf. 64, 73 schol. De intell. emend. pag. 360. Cog. metaph. I, c. 6. II, c. 8. Princ. phil. Cart. I, 4 ax. 4. Ep. 32. 34. 36. tr. polit. II, 8. tract. theol. polit. pag. 177.)

¹⁾*Good* thus becomes that which disposes the human body to be affected and to act in many ways, since the mind's power to perceive corresponds to the body's power to act. Likewise that is good which preserves the relation of motion and rest between the body's parts, since a change in this relation destroys the human body and brings it to pass over into another form. (This is *death*, but the concept of death receives with Spinoza a greater extent than is commonly given it, since it designates not merely the transformation into a corpse, but every change of such an extent that nature shows itself as another, Eth. IV, 39. schol.). — Also everything must be useful that furthers the union of men, while the opposite is harmful (Eth. IV, 38–40).

essence conceived as active²⁾, thus to humana potentia. Since it is one with man's very essence, it is desired for its own sake, and the fundamental appetite, the appetite for self-preservation, becomes its first and only foundation, since being is the condition for being happy, acting well and living well³⁾. — Since virtue is posited as one with potentia, [125] only he can act virtuously who has adequate ideas; for only insofar as we have these are we acting ("nos eatenus tantummodo agimus quatenus intelligimus." Eth. IV, 24. dem.). The complete expression for virtuous action thus becomes: ex ductu rationis agere, vivere, suum esse conservare, ex fundamento proprium utile quærendi (Eth. IV. 24). For ratio expresses the mind insofar as it comprehends clearly and distinctly¹⁾. And since it can only affirm its own essence, that toward which it bids us strive can only be to comprehend (intelligere), and only what leads to this, or hinders it, can we know with certainty to be good or evil. *The good is therefore knowledge²⁾, the highest good the highest knowledge: the knowledge of God, and the mind's highest virtue is to know God* (Eth. IV. 28)³⁾.

[126] Just as necessarily as what reason prescribed *with regard to ourselves* followed from the concept of our essence, what it prescribes with regard to *the relation to others* follows from the common concepts. Since things are individual and different only through the negation of limitation, and this is the source of impotentia, which is the opposite of power, i.e. of virtue, then, the more limitation is removed, the more must impotence be removed and virtue approached, since our power of action is increased by connection with what is of like kind. That whose nature was absolutely different from ours could be neither useful nor harmful; that which agrees with our nature must be useful, i.e.

²⁾Eth. IV. defin. 8: Per virtutem et potentiam idem intelligo; hoc est: virtus, quatenus ad hominem refertur, est ipsa hominis essentia seu natura, quatenus potestatem habet quædam efficiendi, quæ per solas ipsius naturæ leges possunt intelligi.

³⁾Eth. IV, 20. schol.: nemo igitur, nisi a causis externis victus, suum utile appetere sive suum esse conservare negligit.

¹⁾Since reason conceives things under the form of eternity and necessity, it does not conceive them in relation to time, which is only a determination of imagination, and must therefore prefer the greater good to the lesser, the lesser evil to the greater, without regard to whether they are present or future (Eth. IV. 62. 65 f.).

²⁾At this point the motives and peculiar character of Spinozism come forward, to be decisively asserted at the conclusion of the Ethics. — Spinoza does not develop the relation of the bodily to the proposition that knowledge is the proper aim of self-preservation.

³⁾Hominis, qui ratione ducitur, finis ultimus, *hoc est, summa cupiditas*, qua reliquas omnes moderari studet, est illa, qua fertur ad se, resque omnes, quæ sub ipsius intelligentiam cadere possunt, adæquate concipiendum (Eth. IV. App. c. 4). — Nulla igitur vita rationalis est sine intelligentia, et res eatenus tantum bonæ sunt, quatenus hominem juvant ut mentis vita fruatur, quæ intelligentia definitur. Quæ autem contra impediunt, quominus homo rationem perficere et rationali vita frui possit, eas solummodo malas esse dicimus (ibid. c. 5). — Beatitudo nihil aliud est quam ipsa animi acquiescentia, quæ ex Dei intuitiva cognitione oritur. — Intellectum perficere nihil — aliud est, quam Deum, Deique attributa, et actiones, quæ ex ipsius naturæ necessitate consequuntur, intelligere. — In hoc uno (i.e. intellectum perficere) summa hominis felicitas seu beatitudo consistit (ibid. c. 4).

good, since there comes to be a unity in the common nature, so that the appetite of self-preservation of the one thing immediately benefits the other¹⁾. Usefulness increases in the same degree as agreement, in such a way that if two individuals which were perfectly of the same nature were united, they would form an individual that had twice as great a power as the single one. For man, therefore, nothing is more useful than man, and men can wish for nothing better for maintaining their being than that they should all agree so perfectly in everything that the souls and bodies of all formed as it were one soul and one body, and that they all in union, as far as they were able, strove to preserve their being and to further the common useful. But as dominated by affects, men cannot be said to agree in nature; for this is a positive determination, the affect (as impotentia)²⁾ a negative one. Even the individual man in that state does not agree with [127] himself, still less the different men, who through the passions can become opposed to each other. Only as led by reason do they agree of necessity; for only rational actions are comprehended through human nature alone as proximate cause, and since *reason's* knowledge of good and evil is necessarily true, the actions that proceed from reason must necessarily contain what is a good for *human nature*, and thus for every man (cf. p. 122 f., Note 1 p. 126). When the individual is led by reason, his striving for what is useful to him becomes immediately useful to the others, and the more useful the stronger it is. For in reason, which expresses the common human nature, separation is removed, and the drive of self-preservation is no longer egoistic. The highest good of the rational man, i.e. of the virtuous man: the knowledge of God, the most perfect being, without which nothing can be *or be comprehended*, must be common to all and capable of being possessed by all, “*for it belongs to the essence of the human mind to have an adequate knowledge of God's eternal and infinite essence*” (Eth. IV. 36. schol.). In the appetite with which the rational man desires this good for himself there lies also, immediately, the appetite for it for the others, and that in so much higher a degree the greater the knowledge of God is¹⁾. At this point there thus appears the significance of the *social relation* among men (see the next chapter), and the true significance of *religion*: “whatever we desire and do, whatever we are the cause of insofar as we have the idea of

¹⁾This grounding is of significance for Spinoza's conception of *the common* (commune). The individual thing is in its self-preservation immediately one with the other, since the common is their positive unity (Eth. IV, 31 dem. cf. 35 dem.).

²⁾Eth. IV. 37. schol. 1: impotentia in hoc solo consistit, quod homo a rebus, quæ extra ipsum sunt, duci se patiat, et ab iis ad ea agendum determinetur, quæ rerum externarum communis constitutio, non autem ea, quæ ipsa ipsius natura, in se sola considerata, postulat.

¹⁾A *gradation* in the knowledge of God has significance only for the common representation, not for Spinoza's peculiar conception; cf. chapter 8.

God, or insofar as we know God, I reckon to religion" (Eth. IV. 37. schol. 1)²⁾. It appears [128] likewise here *that there are also affects which have their origin in reason, and are active*. These must be referred to two of the fundamental affects: *appetite* and *joy*; for *sorrow* presupposes a suffering. The appetite arisen from reason Spinoza calls *fortitudo* (since it expresses man's power) and divides it into: *animositas*, i.e. the appetite by which one strives to preserve one's being solely according to the prescription of reason; — and *generositas*, i.e. the appetite by which one strives, solely according to the prescription of reason, to bind other men to oneself in a relation of friendship (Eth. III. 59. schol.)¹⁾. *Generositas* thus becomes not different from *pietas*, i.e. the appetite to do good which is called forth by our living according to the bidding of reason²⁾, or from *honestas*, which in Eth. IV. 37. schol. 1. is defined quite in the same way as it³⁾.

If the determinations *good* and *evil* are applied to the individual affects, the consequence must be that those of them are called good which designate a power, and those evil which designate an impotence⁴⁾. Virtue was indeed determined as power, as self-assertion (conceived in the right sense), not as self-annihilation; for nothing positive is removed by the unity with substance. The affects that express self-assertion are good, since they express a transition to a greater perfection; those that express a hindering of [129] our essence's fundamental striving, which can take place only from without¹⁾, are evil. Good, therefore, are joy, hilaritas, and the appetite and the self-feeling that arise from reason²⁾; evil are not only affects such as sorrow, melancholy, hatred, despair, pride and the contempt for oneself (*abiectio*) that is related to pride and to envy, but also such as, even though in the man not led by reason they can become useful as a counterweight against opposite and more harmful ones, nevertheless include a sorrow and are therefore in and for themselves harmful, thus: fear, hope, humility, repentance, pity, shame. Such affects as refer themselves to a partial affection, which can attain excess, like the feeling

²⁾cf. Eth. IV, 73. schol.: vera vita et religio. On religion in the usual sense of the word cf. chapter 7.

¹⁾Modifications of *animositas* are: temperantia, sobrietas, animi præsentia etc., of *generositas*: modestia, clementia etc.

²⁾This will is dependent on idea Dei, which is posited as equal to spiritus Christi. Eth. IV. 68. schol.

³⁾*honestum* is the name for what men led by reason praise, *turpe* for what hinders the relation of friendship (Eth. IV. 37. schol. 1). *Probi* is the name for those who have a clear idea of God, by which all their actions and thoughts are determined; *improbi* for those who *do not possess the idea of God* (qui Dei ideam haud possident) but only the ideas of earthly things, by which their actions and thoughts are determined (Ep. 36).

⁴⁾nostræ actiones, hoc est, cupiditates illæ, quæ hominis potentia seu ratione definiuntur, semper bonæ sunt, reliquæ autem tam bonæ quam malæ possunt esse" (Eth. IV. App. Cap. 3).

¹⁾Eth. IV. App. c. 6: quia omnia illa, quorum homo efficiens est causa, necessario bona sunt, nihil ergo mali homini evenire potest nisi a causis externis; nempe quatenus pars est totius naturæ, cuius legibus humana natura obtemperare, et cui infinitis modis pæne sese accommodare cogitur.

²⁾Eth. IV, 45. schol. 2: quo maiori lætitia afficimur, eo ad maiorem perfectionem transimus, hoc est, eo nos magis de natura divina participare necesse est.

of pleasure and the feeling of pain (*titillatio* and *dolor*), can per accidens become both good and evil, yet the former is rather good, the latter evil. *Appetites* are on the whole good or evil according as they arise from affects that are good or evil. But all those that arise from affects that are *passiones* are blind, and would be of no use to men if they could easily be led to live according to the bidding of reason, for *by reason we can be determined to all the actions to which we are determined by an affect that is a suffering* (Eth. IV, 59)³.

Through these preparatory developments the difference now shows itself between [130] the *free man* and the *slave* (the wise man and the ignorant), and of this Spinoza gives, before he passes over to the decisive conclusion of his Ethics, a portrayal (Eth. IV, 67 ff.), in which the sphere of finitude and relativity is not yet left in the way it is left by that conclusion. While the slave is led by affect, is determined by external causes, and therefore, whether he will or not, must do what he does not understand, the free man is led only by his own essence, reason, clear and distinct knowledge, and therefore does only what he knows to be the essential, and for that reason desires (Eth. IV. 66. schol.). Since he is determined only by reason, which is his essence, and since reason is the mind *as active*, no other affects can be found in him than the active affects of joy and of rational appetite¹). He is thus not led by fear to the good, for fear is a sorrow, but his appetite seeks the good *directly*, since it arises from the knowledge of it, which is one with the affect of joy as conscious (see above, p. 120). Likewise it flees evil only indirectly, since the knowledge of evil, as the conscious *tristitia*, is an inadequate knowledge²). He thinks least of all of death; his wisdom is a meditation on life (*vitæ meditatio*). He does not let [131] himself be influenced by the affects of the unfree, but sets love¹) and magnanimity against

³)For in every passive state our power of action is less than that which follows from the necessity of our nature, considered in itself alone (Eth. IV. 59). Joy too is a *passio* insofar as our power of action is not increased to the point at which it comprehends itself and its actions adequately (Eth. IV. 59. dem.). The transition to a *greater perfection* is thus, in the domain of the passive states, only the transition to a *lesser imperfection*. The *positive* expression has significance only so long as the representation of an *existing* finite is held fast; when this representation dissolves, first the positive expression must be exchanged for the negative, and then the *transition* as a whole must show itself as something negative, a non-being (cf. chapter 8.).

¹)cf. Eth. IV. App. c. 25: in communibus — colloquiis cavebit hominum vitia referre, et de humana impotentia non nisi parce loqui curabit: at largiter de humana virtute seu potentia, et qua via possit perfici, ut sic homines, non ex metu aut aversione, sed solo lætitiæ affectu moti, ex rationis præscripto, quantum in se est, conentur vivere.

²)The knowledge of evil is an inadequate knowledge because it is equal to the conscious *tristitia*. For sorrow is a transition to a lesser perfection, which cannot be understood through man's essence alone and therefore is a *passio* dependent on inadequate ideas, so that the knowledge of it can only be inadequate. If we had only adequate ideas, i.e. if we were born free, we would not form the concept evil, and thus not its opposite either: the concept good (Eth. IV. 64. 68).

¹)In Eth. IV. App. c. XIX–XX *animi libertas* is posited as the ground of love. — *Voluntas constans* et in omnibus determinata is conceived as a property of *intellectus*. Ep. 60.

hatred; he preserves independence of the ignorant; he alone is capable of gratitude; he always acts with good faith; he is freer in the state, where he lives according to the common decision, than in solitude, where he obeys only himself; he hates no one, envies no one, despises no one, is angry with no one; what he desires for himself he desires also for the others; he considers above all that everything follows from the necessity of the divine nature²⁾, and that what he therefore represents to himself as troublesome and evil, and what seems impious, unjust, dreadful and shameful, only seems so because he regards things confusedly and mutilatedly, and therefore he strives first and foremost to comprehend things as they are in themselves, and to remove the hindrances to true knowledge, such as hatred, anger, envy, mockery, arrogance and the like, and, as far as it lies with him, *to act well and to be glad* (Eth. IV, 73. schol.); for thereby he expresses his essence, reason.

[132] Human freedom is thus seen in its opposition to man's state of bondage within the domain of finitude: it now only remains to see man as free in his eternal and necessary relation to God, the only *causa libera*, and to let this relation cast a light back on what has been developed with regard to the common representation. But at this point it is the fitting place to insert Spinoza's doctrine of the *state* and of *religion*, which, taking this representation as its point of departure, supplements what has just been developed, and at the same time indirectly prepares the way for the more complete understanding of the doctrine of *the eternally existing human freedom* which Spinoza develops in the last book of the Ethics.

Chapter Seven.

Natural Right. Religion.

Spinoza's doctrine of the *social relation* takes, like the Ethics proper, its starting point from man, represented as a single *modus*, as a dependent link in the order of nature, in

²⁾Eth. IV. App. c. 32: Quod (i.e. that we, as part of nature, must follow its necessary order) si clare et distincte intelligamus, pars illa nostri, quæ intelligentia definitur, hoc est, pars melior nostri, in eo plane acquiescet, et in ea acquiescentia perseverare conabitur. Nam quatenus intelligimus, nihil appetere, nisi quod necessarium est, nec absolute, nisi in veris acquiescere possumus; adeoque, quatenus hoc recte intelligimus, eatenus conatus melioris partis nostri cum ordine totius naturæ convenit.

the infinite chain of causes and effects. Conceived as such, man (cf. the previous chapter) is governed by the universal law of external necessity; he is constantly determined by passive affects, which act according to the mathematically calculable proportion of their strengths and, by the power they receive from external causes (cf. Eth. IV, 3. 6), are able to overwhelm the very knowledge of good and evil, which acts against them only in so far as it itself takes on the form of an affect. Man is here like one of the fleeting figures that are formed in infinite extension by the laws of motion, only to be reshaped again and at last to vanish into its unity, as the limitation, being merely negative, vanishes. From that standpoint, which is that of the imagination, we saw that liberation from the affects, from the state of bondage, stands as a goal that can be reached only approximately, since the finite as finite cannot become congruent with the infinite, and, within the *relative* [133] difference between the slave and the free man, the ignorant and the wise, the free and the wise make up only a small number. Since, therefore, human nature through the drive of self-assertion strives after the unity that increases its power, that which is to be able to act upon all men, and to be capable of forming the foundation of the social relation which, as experience shows, is found everywhere, not only among civilized men but among barbarians, must be, not the rational alone, but the affect. The concept of the affect must therefore become the starting point of the doctrine of the state; in its mechanical laws the laws of the state's coming into being and continuance must be sought, and since man as determined by it is single and isolated, the individual drive of self-preservation, the *egoistic* appetite, must form the foundation, and *laws of nature*, not *ethical* laws, must be what is determinative. But just as in the doctrine of knowledge and of the affects we saw that the conception of man as single cancelled itself, so we shall see it here too. Through the affect as the phenomenal we shall see man's true essence, reason, in which all men are in unity, act as the deeper *ground* of the association and determine its essence and *end*. The current here, as everywhere in Spinoza, runs back to *the unity in the infinite*, and even if this unity is not reached in this domain, by the nature of the matter, it is nevertheless intimated, and the lines drawn converge so as to meet in one point at the conclusion of the Ethics. The development will therefore point toward this point; but from the necessary inconsistencies in Spinoza's doctrine of the finite developed earlier, the consequence will be that the finite frequently holds thought fast as though it had the validity of reality, and that that point is seen only as in the distance.

Since the doctrine of society proceeds from the single man, governed by the universal laws of nature, his essence must first be determined in this isolation, *man's state of nature*.

The determination is drawn from the universal metaphysical relation between God and
 [134] single things. Since these have existence and continuance only through God's eternal power, *the power of natural things, by which they are and act, is God's (nature's) very power*. But since God has a right to everything, and his right is equal to his power, regarded as absolutely free, the right of the natural thing to exist and act is determined by its power, which expresses God's absolutely free power in a determinate way. *Jus naturæ*¹⁾ is thus the power of nature (*naturalis potentia*), i.e. its laws, according to which everything happens and which are not disturbed by an imagined human freedom. What every single individual does according to the laws of its nature, it does with the most perfect right of nature (*summo naturæ jure*). But as part of nature man is determined not only by reason but also by the passions; in both conditions the appetite for self-preservation is at work, and in both it is an expression of *vis naturalis*; for even if the passions, referred to men alone, are *passiones*, they are nevertheless determined by the laws of nature, effects of the power of nature, and in the same proportion as this power is expressed by the nature of this or that man, man shares in the right of nature, which is not separated from power. It therefore makes no difference whether man is wise or ignorant; whatever he desires and does in either capacity, he desires and does with the full right of nature (*tract. polit. II, 8*). In this state, then, egoism becomes the sole determinant; each is bound only by his own appetite²⁾. A promise, e.g., to do something which one could by one's right
 [135] refrain from doing, thus has validity here only so long as the will of the one promising is unchanged. He who has the power to break the promise has in reality not given up his right, but has only "given his word". When, therefore, he sees or believes he sees—and by the right of nature he is judge in his own cause—that by fulfilling the promise he will have more harm than benefit, he will break the promise, and do so by the right of nature (*II, 12*).

This *jus naturæ*, "under which all men are born, and most live", therefore forbids nothing except what no one desires and no one is able to do, neither strife nor hatred, nor anger, nor deceit, nor anything whatsoever to which appetite prompts. "And this is not surprising; for nature is not comprised by (*non continetur*) the laws of human reason, which have regard only to the true benefit and preservation of men, but by infinitely many others, which have regard to the eternal order of the whole of nature, of

¹⁾"Nature has a right to everything"; *tract.-theol.-polit. pag. 175*. As synonyms are set down in the same place: *jus naturæ, institutum naturæ, regulæ naturæ unuscuiusque individui*.

²⁾*Eth. IV. 37. schol. 2.*: *Existit unusquisque summo naturæ jure, et consequenter summo naturæ jure unusquisque ea agit, quæ ex suæ naturæ necessitate sequuntur, atque adeo summo naturæ jure unusquisque judicat, quid bonum, quid malum sit, suæque utilitati ex suo ingenio consulit, seseque vindicat, et id, quod amat, conservare, et id, quod odio habet, destruere conatur. cf. Eth. IV. App. c. 8.*

which man is a small part, and by which order, which we know only incompletely, every individual is determined with necessity in its existence and action”¹⁾.

Since men are thus determined only egoistically by the affects, they are different from and opposed to one another²⁾, and thus more dangerous to one another than any other being. *Men are by nature enemies* (tr. polit. II, 14); for he is most my enemy whom I must most fear and guard myself against. In this relation of enmity each individual’s appetite for self-preservation stands in opposition to that of all the others, his right stands against theirs; *it therefore becomes impossible for the individual to assert his right*, since this right is determined by power, and the individual’s power is insufficient against that of all the [136] others. Natural right therefore exists more in representation than in reality (*opinione quam re*); the individual’s power is checked by fear, and with power right is diminished. Thus it is shown here too how the conception of the individual as individual is untrue and cancels itself. Only by union with the others, by the cancelling of isolated existence, do the assertion of right and a human, and in particular a rational, life become possible, since connection with what is like us gives greater power, and thus also greater right. *The appetite for self-preservation therefore drives with necessity to the appetite for union*¹⁾. And this appetite issues with such strength from the fear of solitude that all men must be said to desire by nature the social relation (*status civilis*), and they can never wholly abolish it (tr. polit. VI, 1). In man, regarded as determined by the affects, it must now be an affect (such as fear, hope, vindictiveness), not reason, that appears as what prompts to union and secures it²⁾. But the deeper ground of union lies in reason; for since the [137] rational man is most *sui juris* (II, 11), the appetite to assert his right must at the same

¹⁾cf. tract. polit. II. 1–8; tract. theol.-pol. pag. 176 ff. — The propositions last cited get their validity in that men are conceived as single beings among innumerable other single things, and in that the difference between ratio as “universal knowledge” and intuitive knowledge is held fast.

²⁾Were they led by reason alone, their appetite and right would not come into collision (Eth. IV. 37. schol. 2).

¹⁾Tract. polit. II, 15: *concludimus, jus naturæ, quod humani generis proprium est, vix posse concipi, nisi ubi homines jura habeant communia, qui simul terras, quas habitare et colere possunt, sibi vindicare, seseque munire, vimque omnem repellere et ex communi omnium sententia vivere possunt.*

²⁾In order that individual men may be secure and have confidence in one another, their affects must be governed by an affect, and this happens through the power of the state, which instils fear (Eth. IV, 37. schol. 2). — On the whole, in the arrangement of the state and in regard to its preservation, the essential thing becomes to calculate the balance of the affects, and to arrange the state in such a way that the realization of what is useful to it, as regards both the rulers and the ruled, is secured, whatever their disposition may be, whether, that is, they do it voluntarily or compelled by the affects. Nothing that concerns the common weal ought to be left to the trustworthiness (*fides*) of any one individual; for then the continued existence of the state would be abandoned to chance, while the task is precisely to preserve it, since the dissolution of the state does not take place without the most violent upheavals; and with respect to the security of the state it makes no difference by what disposition men are moved to govern it well, provided only that it is governed well. “For freedom or strength (*fortitudo*) of mind is a private virtue, but the virtue of the state is security” (tract. polit. I, 6. VI, 3. X, 4. 9).

time become an appetite for the rational, and this was indeed (see the previous chapter) what is alike in all men, which as the unity of human nature unites them in the unity of the highest good. This deeper ground of union will then also become what determines its end, and what essentially and *positively* holds it together (cf. what follows).

Now, when the individual, in order to increase his power and assert his right, enters into union with others, he gives up his existence as isolated, and exists from now on only as a member of society. The extent of his right is determined by its relation to the power of society; he now has only that *jus in naturam* which the common right (*jus commune*) grants him. He is obliged to do what is laid upon him by common decision, and can rightly be compelled to it. The common right, which is determined by the power of the multitude, is the power of the state (*imperium*)¹⁾, which he possesses absolutely who by common agreement has the government of the state. The condition in society is, in contrast to the state of nature (*status naturalis*), a *status civilis*; the whole *imperii corpus* is *civitas*²⁾; its common affairs, which depend on him who holds dominion, are *respublica*. A citizen (*civis*) is he who by virtue of *jus civile* enjoys the advantages of the political community. He is called a subject (*subditus*) in so far as he is bound to obey the laws and institutions of the state. An enemy (*hostis*) is anyone who lives outside the state and is not an ally.

[138] Only in this new relation do the determinations *peccatum*, *justitia* and the like acquire meaning. In the state of nature there is no offence (*peccatum* i.e. *actio*, *quæ jure fieri nequit*), or, if anyone offends, he offends against himself, not against others; for the law of nature forbids only what no one is able to do. Men led by the affects, too, follow the necessary order of nature, i.e. God's *institutum*, which is eternal and cannot be violated, and from this it follows: "that the ignorant and mentally powerless man is, by the right of nature, no more obliged to order his life wisely than the sick man is to live with a healthy body." The concept of offence can first become intelligible in society, where it is determined by the common right of the whole state what is good and what is evil, and no one does anything rightly except what he does with the common consent¹⁾. The following of this common will²⁾ is *obedience* (*obsequium*), which can be determined as the will to follow the commands of reason (which is true freedom) only in so far as a real unity of the state can be brought about only by rational determinations of right, and

¹⁾Tract. polit. III. 2: *imperii* seu summarum potestatum *jus*. — In society there arises the concept of a *persona civilis* (a collective personality), as distinct from *persona naturalis*, tract. polit. X, 2.

²⁾*Civitas* is: *societas legibus et potestate sese conservandi firmata*. Eth. IV. 37. schol. 2.

¹⁾*Peccatum* thus becomes equal to *inobedientia*, *meritum* to *obedientia* (Eth. IV. 37. schol. 2).

²⁾This is *lex civilis*, which depends on men's discretion, whereas *lex naturalis* depends on the necessity of nature; cf. tract theol.-polit. pag. 43.

the determinations of right of the best state must be laid down according to the bidding of reason.

What holds with respect to offence and obedience holds also with respect to *justice* and *injustice*. In the state of nature there is nothing that can rightly be said to be the one man's and not the other's; but everything belongs to all in so far as they have the power to assert it for themselves. But in the state, where it is determined by the common right what belongs to the individual, he is called *just* who has a constant will to give each his own, and *unjust* he who strives to appropriate what is another's.

Since the general proposition that *right is determined by power* holds of society just [139] as well as of the individual, its preponderant power gives it the right to determine, over against the individual, how he shall live, which cannot be left to the individual's discretion without the social condition reverting again to the state of nature. For the same reason the power of society must itself be the sole interpreter of its laws. The individual is thus not *sui juris*, but *civitatis juris*; what the state determines to be just and good must be regarded as determined by everyone, and even if the subject finds the state's decisions unreasonable, he must obey them. *The individual's natural right does not, however, properly cease in the social condition*¹⁾; for in it, just as fully as in the state of nature, man acts according to the laws of his nature and provides for his own benefit. In both conditions he is led by fear and hope; but the essential difference is that in society all fear the same thing, and that the ground of security, as well as the manner of living, is one for all, which does not abolish the individual's faculty of judgement. For he who resolves to obey all the commands of the state, whether because he fears its power or because he loves security, provides according to his own mind (*ex suo ingenio*) for his security and his advantage. Nor does the transfer of right, the submission to another's judgement, conflict with the command of reason; for it was shown, indeed, that in the state of nature it was impossible to make one's right valid, whereas the political community and the observance of the common laws pave the way to it, so that the rational man, i.e. the free man, thus puts up with *the* lesser evil, in a single point of [140] having to subordinate himself to the irrational, since it is far outweighed by the goods that follow from society; for reason commands us to choose the lesser evil when it leads to a greater good.

Moreover, with respect to what is apparently dangerous and contrary to reason in

¹⁾On this point Spinoza departs from *Hobbes*. Ep. 50: Quod ad politicam attinet, discrimen inter me et Hobbesium — — in hoc consistit, quod ego naturale jus semper sartum tectum conservo, quodque supremo magistratui in qualibet urbe non plus in subditos juris quam juxta mensuram potestatis, qua subditum superat, competere statuo, quod in statu naturali semper locum habet. cf. Bruder's edition of Spinoza's works. Vol. III. pag. 213. Note.

the transfer of right, it must not be overlooked that this transfer has its natural limits. For just as in the state of nature that man was most powerful (*potens*) and most *sui juris* who was led by reason, so that state will be the most powerful, and most *sui juris*, which is founded on reason and governed by it. The right of the state is determined, namely, by the power of the multitude that is led as if by one mind; but it is reason alone in which men agree, and unity will take place only when the state strives after what sound reason declares to be useful for all men¹⁾. The power of the state is thus conditioned by its rationality, and its power, and thus also its right, is diminished the more, the more people are provoked to revolt by irrational commands from it and by their resistance give it occasion for fear. Herein, then, lies a safeguard for the individual, and moreover there always remains a domain that withdraws itself from the power of the state, namely everything that cannot be influenced by rewards or threats, such as the verdicts of the faculty of judgement, conviction²⁾, love, hatred and the like; likewise that which is so much against human nature that man prefers any evil to it, e.g. to bear witness against oneself, to kill one's nearest, not to strive to avoid death. To this the state has no right to [141] compel; for a right to which no one was bound would be a self-contradiction. Against unreason and prejudices, religious ones included, the state on the other hand has an unconditional right (*tract. polit. III, 7–9. cf. tract. theol.-polit. c. XVII*).

Since *jus summæ potestatis* is nothing other than the very right of nature, it follows of itself *that two different states stand to one another as two individuals in the state of nature*. They are thus by nature enemies and have the right to make war on one another and subjugate one another. If they place themselves in a relation of peace to one another, they are allies (*confoederatæ*), and their alliance lasts as long as its cause, namely fear of loss or hope of advantage. If this cause is removed, each state has the right to dissolve the alliance, and one cannot say that the state which breaks it acts faithlessly; for the right was equal for both, and the alliance presupposed the determinate circumstances. By this breach the state merely provides for its own security over against the other, and it even becomes an outright duty for the sovereign power to break its promise when it has promised another state something which afterwards either time or reason shows to be contrary to the welfare of the subjects (*tract. polit. III, 11–14*).

The supreme power of the state is as it were the soul of society (*imperii mens*), which is to lead all; it therefore alone represents the state's right to determine what is good and

¹⁾Concord founded on fear is founded only on something negative (*Eth. IV. App. c. 16. tract. polit. X, 8*) and is *sine fide*. Its positive ground is justice, equity and honesty.

²⁾In this domain the individual comes essentially to relate himself merely to the divine. The relation to other individuals and to the state vanishes here. *cf. tract. polit. III, 10: mens, quatenus ratione utitur, non summarum potestatum, sed sui juris est.*

evil, equitable and inequitable, i.e. what all, as individuals and in union, are to do and leave undone; it must therefore give laws, interpret them and judge, declare war and conclude peace, in short administer all public affairs without exception. If one takes the concepts of law and offence in the stricter sense developed above, one must say that the sovereign power cannot be bound by laws, since it itself determines them, and that it thus cannot offend. If, on the other hand, one takes the concepts in a wider sense, then the state can be said to offend when it does what must become its destruction, when it acts against reason, which makes it *sui juris*, when it does what of necessity—and the necessity of human nature the sovereign power cannot alter— annihilates the reverence [142] and fear felt for it, and, by turning these into exasperation, turns the social condition into a state of nature. The contract or the laws by which individuals have transferred their right to the sovereign power can be broken in the interest of the common weal; but what serves the common weal can, by the right of the state (*jure civile*), be decided only by him who holds dominion, and since he has the right of interpretation, no one can, by the right of the state, allege a transgression of the laws against him. If, however, the laws are violated in such a way that the fear of the majority is turned into exasperation, then the state is thereby dissolved and the contract abolished, and right is then asserted not *jure civili* but *jure belli*. The ground for keeping the contract thus becomes, for the head of state, the same as the ground, in the state of nature, for the individual not to kill himself (tract. pol. IV, 1–6).

If one compares the different forms of society with one another, then that one must be regarded as *the best* which best realizes what was intended by the union. This was immediately the assertion of right; but since the power for this, both for the state and for the individual, was conditioned by their being led by reason and acting according to its laws, the *best* state becomes the most rational¹⁾; for since reason expresses right and power most completely, it expresses the end most completely. Since the essence of reason is *the true knowledge* of the divine and of our unity with and in it, and since this knowledge is our highest good, the end of the state can also be determined by it²⁾. It can likewise be determined as *peace* and *security* (*pax et vitæ securitas*; tract. polit. V, 2 f. III, 6)³⁾, so that that state becomes the best where men live in concord and the right of [143] each is preserved inviolate, while the most turbulent state, since it comes nearest to the state of nature, corresponds least to its concept. For by peace in the state is understood

¹⁾Tract. polit. II, 21: Optimi imperii jura ex rationis dictamine institui debent.

²⁾De intell. emend. pag. 361.

³⁾As the end of the state is set down (tract. polit. III, 6): *pax, securitas, propulsio miseriæ*; cf. tract. theol.-polit. pag. 34: *finis universæ societatis et imperii est, secure et commode vivere* (in the same work: pag. 177: *secure et optime vivere*); cf. also Eth. IV. App. c. 14.

not the negative: the absence of war, or: sluggish quiet, but something positive. It is a virtue which arises only from strength of soul (*animi fortitudo*), and is the same as the citizens' steadfast will to obey the laws. The peaceful (*concordant*) life in the state is thus to be conceived as the true human life, and this is essentially determined by reason, *vera mentis virtute et vita*, since reason expresses human nature as unity. The determination of the end of the state as peace and concord and as reason and knowledge thus coincide, and from reason *freedom*¹⁾ is likewise inseparable, since only he is free who acts rationally. — Whether the end of the state is reached or not, Spinoza regards more as the merit or fault of society than of the individual; *homines enim civiles non nascuntur sed fiunt* (tract. pol. V, 2).

Spinoza distinguishes the particular *forms of state* by the number of those to whom the right of the state is entrusted. If dominion lies with a council formed of the whole multitude, it is *democracy*; if the council consists only of some chosen few, *aristocracy*; if the whole power is in one man's hands: *monarchy*. He places these 3 forms side by side, and seeks to show the possibility that in each of them the end of the state can be reached; [144] yet he does not regard them as equally good, but gives democracy the preference¹⁾, as much because it is the strongest (*omnino absolutum imperium*) as also because there is less danger of irrational decisions when so many take part in the governing power (tract. theol. polit. pag: 180, tract. polit. VIII, 6), and finally because it gives the greatest freedom and equality (tract. polit. X, 8). In developing the particular forms of state, his chief task is to show how they must be arranged in order that dangerous upheavals may be avoided and the form once established be preserved (tract. polit. VI, 2). On the presupposition that reason governed all, everyone would voluntarily subordinate himself to society; for reason, the positively uniting element, would bind all together. But since the presupposition is that the mass of men is governed by the affects, the affects must be balanced by affects, in the interest of reason; there must be given in the institutions an attachment for the interests of all, a counterweight against the irrational passion of

¹⁾Tract. theol-polit. pag. 226 f.: Ex fundamentis reipublicæ sequitur, finem eius ultimum non esse dominari, nec homines metu retinere et alterius juris facere, sed contra unumquemque metu liberare, ut secure, quoad eius fieri potest, vivat, hoc est, ut jus suum naturale ad existendum absque suo et alterius damno optime retineat. Non, inquam, finis reipublicæ est, homines ex rationalibus bestias vel automata facere, sed contra ut eorum mens et corpus tuto suis functionibus fungantur, et ipsi libera ratione utantur, et ne odio, ira vel dolo certent, nec animo iniquo invicem ferantur. *Finis ergo reipublicæ revera libertas est.*

¹⁾tract. polit. XI, 1: tertium et omnino absolutum imperium, quod democraticum appellamus. VIII, 3: si quod imperium absolutum datur, illud revera est, quod integra multitudo tenet. VIII, 7: quo jus summæ potestatis majus est, eo imperii forma cum ratione magis convenit; cf. tract. theol.-polit. pag. 216: eodem modo, ac in imperio democratico fieri ostendimus, ubi omnes communi consensu deliberant, ex solo rationis dictamine vivere. Yet Spinoza concedes (tract. polit. XI, 2) that aristocracy would be the most excellent if the election of the patricians were led by reason alone.

the rulers. Only by this equilibrium is quiet brought about, and through it the rational can assert itself. The necessity of finding a counterweight against the passions of the rulers and a guarantee for the continuance of the form of state appears most strongly in monarchy, which by its nature is most exposed to upheaval. For even if despotism seems to bring stability with it, this stability is only *negative*, bondage and sluggishness, not positive, security and concord. On the contrary, there lies in monarchy as absolute not only something hateful to the subjects, and something that conflicts with the laws [145] of human nature¹⁾, but there lies in it also a contradiction, since the personality of the single man, regardless of all the contingencies to which it is exposed (tract. pol. VIII, 3), cannot contain the power that can secure his right, for which reason he must always seek help for himself, so that monarchy in reality becomes a hidden aristocracy, and the condition in it violent, unnatural and wretched²⁾. Only when the monarch's power is restricted, so that the fundamental law itself is made independent of the king's will (VII, 1), and the king's power "is determined solely by the very power of the people and preserved by the very protection of the people" (VII, 31), can the security of the monarchy and the peace of the subjects be secured³⁾.

The more precise determinations for the arrangement of the different forms of state⁴⁾ have no philosophical interest. This domain is, in Spinoza's view, not that of thought philosophical in the stricter sense, but that of probability (cf. Ep. 60). The determinations he gives therefore have significance only as practical calculations, which refer to something that by its essence has no subsistence, and which constantly lets the truer ground, the proper essence into which it goes back, shine through it, even if only as in the distance. But toward this deeper ground the direction runs, and when it shows itself (cf. the next chapter), the relation on which the doctrine of the state rested vanishes.

In the working out of this doctrine in detail, however, it becomes of interest, as was [146] already intimated above, to see, with respect to Spinoza's conception of the fundamental concepts, how finite reality involuntarily asserts a significance for thought, and, with respect to the development of the special science, how Spinoza, in his sympathy for

¹⁾Tract. polit. VII, 14: imperio absoluto uti principi admodum periculosum, subditis admodum odiosum, et institutis tam divinis quam humanis adversum, ut innumera ostendunt exempla.

²⁾Tract. polit. VI, 8: sequitur, regem eo minus sui juris, et subditorum conditionem eo miseriorem esse, quo magis absolute civitatis jus in eundem transfertur.

³⁾This is justified and does not conflict with the king's dignity: nam fundamenta imperii veluti regis æterna decreta habenda sunt, adeo ut eius ministri ei omnino obediunt, si, quando aliquid imperat, quod imperii fundamentis repugnat, mandata exsequi velle negent. — Monarchy is to be so arranged, ut omne jus sit regis explicata voluntas, at non ut omne regis voluntas jus sit. (tract. polit. VII, 1, cf. the comparison with aristocracy VIII, 3).

⁴⁾tract. polit. Cap. 6—11.

rational freedom, touches at many points on the political order of a more recent age and asserts the claims of humanity (with respect to the abolition of torture, to the right to freedom of thought, of speech and of religion, and the like).

In the exposition of the doctrine of the right of the state, the point has been shown at which the relation of the state to *religion* comes forward. This relation can first be completely determined when the essence of religion has been developed, and therewith the proper relation of *science* to both will then become clear.

It is in the *Tractatus theologico-politicus* that Spinoza develops his conception of the essence of *religion* and its relation to the state and to philosophy. In order not to misunderstand the developments he gives, it is necessary here, more than anywhere else, to remember the significance he grants to accommodation¹⁾. The purpose of the treatise was, as was already stated in chapter 1, to make room for free philosophizing, and, in order to achieve this, *on the one hand* philosophy had to be separated from faith (religion), and the different character of the two demonstrated; *on the other hand* the inseparability of religious freedom from the freedom of the state, and the authority of the sovereign power in relation to religious matters, had to be established (cf. tract. theol.-polit. præf. and pag. 30, 160. 166). But thereby all the prevailing representations of the essence of [147] religion and of the significance of Scripture had to be affected, many prejudices had to be removed, and given the nature of these prejudices and the character of the estate¹⁾ that defended them, and in them its own dominion, this had to be done with caution. Spinoza therefore seeks not only to make use of the points of attachment he could find in his countrymen's republican feeling for freedom and in their historical experiences, but in his developments he accommodates himself as much as possible to the prevailing representation, uses its forms and its weapons in his argumentation, appropriates its expressions, and takes care only to put another content into these, so that those who were familiar with his thoughts could find them again in the foreign forms, while those who did not know them would be prepared to grasp them. If one does not constantly remember this, one will not be able to avoid misunderstanding Spinoza's writing, as almost all his contemporaries did, and one will then find contradictions in it with his fundamental philosophical view which cannot be removed.

From what was developed in the 5th and 6th chapters it has become clear which form of knowledge Spinoza sets down as the true one, and which goal he sets for this

¹⁾Tract. de intell. emend. pag. 361 he cites among the provisional rules of life: ad captum vulgi loqui et illa omnia operari, quæ nihil impedimenti adferunt, quo minus nostrum scopum (i.e. to reach the highest good) attingamus. Nam non parum emolumenti ab eo possumus acquirere, modo ipsius captui, quantum fieri potest, concedamus, adde, quod tali modo amicas præbebunt aures ad veritatem audiendam.

^{1*)}Summum odium, quale theologicum esse solet."

knowledge. *Reason* is the true, adequate knowledge, *the knowledge of God* its goal, and since it completes knowledge, it completes action too. *True religion*²⁾, as distinct from religion in the ordinary meaning, is then the acting that proceeds from the knowledge of God (cf. the preceding chapter and Eth. IV, 37. schol. 1). A higher knowledge than that of reason cannot be given; for its knowledge of God is adequate, its “natural light”³⁾ is a divine light, since it is an eternal, immediate, undisturbable, infallible, certain revelation [148] of God’s idea and natura, not in words, “but in a far more excellent way”¹⁾. Its spirit is a spiritus Dei, spiritus sanctus, spiritus divinus; through it a lex divina universalis expresses itself, and it comes to agree with the lex catholica²⁾, religio catholica, fides catholica.

If, therefore, there is talk of a *supernatural* knowledge³⁾ (cognitio supranaturalis), it is to be expected that Spinoza must have used this expression improperly, and that one [149] will find this intimated in him. This is also confirmed at once by his development of the fundamental religious representations: *revelation* and *prophecy*. Prophecy he first defines in general as: rei alicuius certa cognitio a Deo hominibus *revelata*. But since “revelation” thus comes to comprise natural knowledge as well, since this depends on the knowledge of God and on his eternal decretum¹⁾, natural knowledge is now distinguished

²⁾Tract. theol.-polit. pag. 53: Deum sapienter timere, hoc est, vera religione colere. Eth. IV, 73 schol.: quæ ad veram vitam et religionem spectant.

³⁾Lumen naturale (lumen naturæ), spiritus, intellectus (int. naturalis) and ratio are used as synonyms. Reason is determined as sufficient for the true knowledge of God (tract. theol.-polit. pag. 54), as a more excellent means to such knowledge than the historical element in Scripture (pag. 64), as agreeing with cognitio supranaturalis (pag. 139), as *necessary* for the knowledge of God (so that faith alone becomes insufficient; pag. 156), as God’s verum syngraphum (pag. 168), as uncorrupted and incorruptible (præf.; pag. 168: profecto non satis mirari possum, quod rationem, donum maximum et lucem divinam, mortuis literis et quæ humana malitia depravari potuerunt, submittere velint, et quod nullum existimetur scelus, contra mentem, verum Dei syngraphum, indigne loqui, eamque corruptam, cæcam et perditam statuere, at maximum habeatur scelus, talia de litera et verbi Dei idolo cogitare. Ep. 74: Ratione — vero Dei verbo, quod in mente est, quodque nunquam depravari nec corrumpi potest. cf. Ep. 36).

¹⁾Tract. theol.-polit. pag. 2, cf. pag. 144: “Dei æternum verbum et pactum” and “vera religio” is “divinitus inscripta hominum cordibus i.e. humanæ menti”, and it is “verum Dei syngraphum, quod ipse suo sigillo, nempe sua idea, tanquam imagine suæ divinitatis consignavit.”

²⁾For by the expression catholica Spinoza designates what is common to all men, which as such must agree with reason and the natural light. Thus religio catholica (which is sharply distinguished from rel. *Romana*) is determined as lex divina, per prophetas et apostolos universo humano generi revelata (præfat.); it is set down as synonymous with religio *toti humano generi universalis* (pag. 148), and as *maxime naturalis* (pag. 149); there is talk of a rel. catholica *lumine naturali et prophetia revelata* (Ep. 49), of catholica documenta rationis (tract. theol.-pol. pag. 217), of a *lex catholica*, which becomes equal to lex divina universalis (pag. 151 f.), and of a *fides catholica* (pag. 160), whose object becomes the essential content of religion, the content that agrees with reason.

³⁾Spinoza himself, where he criticizes the representation of miracles, rejects the distinction between what is *above* nature and what is *against* nature, since the former is placed within the limits of nature and must thus make a breach in its eternal order.

¹⁾Tract. theol.-polit. pag. 216: Religio eadem est, et a Deo æque revelata, sive hoc sive illo modo (i.e. sive religionem lumine naturali sive prophetico *revelatam* concipiamus) hominibus innotuisse supponatur. Cf.

more precisely from supernatural knowledge by this, that the latter (“quæcunque illa sit”, pag. 1) “extends beyond the limits of the former”²⁾, and that “the laws of human nature considered by itself cannot be its causes” (cf. the definition of the affects as passive states). The character of this specific revelation Scripture must teach us to know, since it is an empirical object that cannot be determined by intellectus. As its *means* Scripture now gives words, signs, or both together, and these either real or imaginary. But as Spinoza conducts an ironical argumentation from the narratives of Scripture, he raises numerous difficulties, which he does not resolve, against the reality of the words and signs; and since words and signs, even as real, belong to the imagination, he can conclude with the result: that “apart from Christ no one has received God’s revelation in any other way than *by the help of the imagination*, namely through words or images”, so that revelation and prophecy are put together with the imagination as proceeding from it [150] (cf. tract. theol.-polit. pag. 13 f.). Therewith they are separated from intellectus, “for then things are comprehended when they are grasped by the mind alone (*pura mente*), independently of words and images” (pag. 50). In *Christ*¹⁾ revelation is not through the imagination and by its means, but “immediately, mind to mind” (*de mente ad mentem*); [151] but he does not thereby become specifically different from other men; for in their mind too “God’s mind and his eternal pronouncements (*sententiæ*) are inscribed.”

That the prophets had God’s spirit therefore signifies, according to the usage of the Old Testament, which Spinoza develops in detail, not that they had a higher insight, but

Cog. metaph. II, c. 12: *decreta Dei, lumine naturali revelata.*

²⁾Tract. theol.-polit. pag. 14: *Non dubium est, eos multa extra intellectus limites percipere potuisse.*

¹⁾Where Spinoza speaks of *Christianity*, one must remember that he uses “*christiana religio*” as synonymous with “*amor, gaudium, pax, continentia et erga omnes fides*” (tract. theol.-polit. præf.), thus with what he himself understands by *religio* (Eth. IV. 37. schol. 1), and regards it, in its simplicity (pag. 143 f.), as agreeing with reason. *The spirit of Christ* therefore designates justice and love of one’s neighbour (Ep. 49. 74), and he who has this spirit of love, even if he professes another religion than the Christian (Ep. 49), knows Christ “according to the spirit”, and Christ is in him (pag. 164). This spirit becomes equal to *idea Dei*, “on which alone it depends that man is free” (Eth. IV, 68. schol.); it contains blessedness within itself (tract. theol.-polit. pag. 65); through it one grasps “God’s laws” as “eternal truths.” Thus it becomes equal to *spiritus sanctus*. *Christ* himself is conceived symbolically as “God’s eternal Son, i.e. God’s eternal wisdom, which has revealed itself in all things, but most in the human mind, and most of all (*omnium maxime*) in Jesus Christ” (Ep. 21). And as a historical, *human* person Christ is ascribed an adequate knowledge, so that he becomes as it were the image of God’s wisdom (tract. theol.-polit. pag. 7. 50); he is called *os Dei*, a teacher who was sent *ad solam legem universalem docendum* (pag. 56). But the dogma of the Incarnation in its ecclesiastical form Spinoza regards as absurd: that the infinite should have taken on a finite nature he regards as just as self-contradictory as if the circle had taken on the nature of the square (Ep. 21, cf. Ep. 23. 74 and *de intell. emend.* pag. 374.). And with the dogma of the Incarnation he rejects all the other dogmas that conflict with reason, “the true word of God, which is in our mind and can never be corrupted.” He calls them “*horribilia secreta*” (Ep. 74), “*absurda arcana*” (tract. theol.-polit. præf.). The narrative of Christ’s Resurrection and Ascension he explains symbolically (Ep. 23 and 25), and in general he declares that knowing Christ according to the flesh (*secundum carnem*) is not necessary to *beatitudo* (Ep. 21).

only that they were in possession of a *peculiar* and *uncommon* virtue (capacity), that they cultivated virtue with steadfastness, and that they perceived God's word or thought, and finally, that the cause of prophetic knowledge was not comprehended. According to what laws of nature this knowledge took place, Spinoza leaves undecided.

From the significance of the imagination for prophecy it now follows (by the essence of the imagination; cf. p. 88 ff.) that the prophets grasped almost everything in parables and riddles, and everything spiritual in bodily forms, and that prophecy, like the imagination, must be changeable, short-lived, and cannot, as reason can, contain certainty (tract. theol.-polit. cap. 1). Therefore the prophets themselves had to have an external guarantee. This they got in the *signs*; but the certainty these could give was only a moral one, since false prophets too performed signs (and besides, the sign in general, by its nature as an object of the imagination, cannot give real certainty). The greatest moral certainty must be sought in *the moral character of the prophets*; yet this too in turn remains imperfect, since no one is completely virtuous. With respect to the signs, it now follows again from their relation to the imagination that they had to conform to the prophet's representations and power of comprehension, and therefore be different for different prophets. For the same reason the content and form of revelation had to vary according to the prophets' different temperaments, circumstances of life and opinions, and according to the peculiar disposition of the imagination. This Spinoza carries out circumstantially, relying on statements of Scripture, but in such a way that his doctrine of the imagination and the affects constantly shines through the biblical demonstration. The result thus becomes that the prophets held different, indeed opposed, opinions, and many errors (with respect to the merely speculative, not with respect [152] to what concerns uprightness and good morals), and that prophecy never made the prophets more knowing (*doctiores*), but left them in their preconceived opinions, and that we are therefore not at all obliged to have faith in them¹⁾ with respect to the purely speculative (tract. theol.-polit. pag. 21). Likewise one must suppose that *the prophets were ignorant of many things*, which already lies in their having been caught up in the common representations of their time, as one can see from manifold examples from the Old Testament. The reason why they are commended, then, becomes not their insight²⁾ or superiority of mind, but their piety and constancy; their task was to teach true virtue, and from this it follows, on the one hand, that they must have been found among *all*

¹⁾Tract. theol.-polit. pag. 28: Concludimus itaque, nos prophetis nihil aliud teneri credere præter id, quod finis et substantia est revelationis (i.e. vera vita).

²⁾Tract. theol.-polit. pag. 23: Nihil enim singulare de Dei attributis docuerunt, sed admodum vulgares de Deo habuerunt opiniones, ad quas etiam eorum revelationes accommodatæ sunt. cf. Ep. 32.

nations (chap. 3), on the other, that they are authorities for us only with respect to what concerns it.

The relation between natural knowledge and so-called supernatural revelation thus proves to be this: that the former comprises the eternal, unchangeable, universally valid truth, certain by itself³⁾, while the latter, as determined by the form of the imagination, is affected by it in its content too, and can therefore indeed contain “more” than the former, but not more truth⁴⁾.

[153] Imagination and “revelation” thus become inseparable. The great multitude of men is led not by rational insight, but by the affects. They must therefore be influenced through these, and since the affects are bound up with the inadequate representations of the imagination, these become the means. But when the truths of reason are taken up into the form of these representations, they change their nature, and the fundamental representations of *religion* become inadequate. Thus, while reason conceives existence as governed by the law of necessity of the divine nature, and sees the effect bound to the cause by the bond of necessity, representation conceives law¹⁾ as an arbitrary one, given by God in the same way as human laws are given, and arbitrarily connected with reward and punishment, which through hope and fear can move men to do and leave undone what is commanded or forbidden. The universal, natural *lex divina*, which according to the nature of my essence²⁾ determines its highest perfection as the knowledge of God and the love of God that follows from it, changes into a special law, which cannot do without peculiar *ceremonies* affecting the imagination, and must be supported by something historical and by *experience*, which cannot give clear insight, but only call forth obedience and devotion. Reason’s view of the inviolable order of nature is transformed [154] into the representation of *miracles*¹⁾, of a supernatural, immediate divine intervention that suspends the eternal laws of nature, the very laws of God’s essence; and one now

³⁾Ibid. pag. 173 f.: De veritate — et certitudine rerum, quæ solius sunt speculationis, nullum spiritus testimonium dat præter rationem, quæ sola, ut jam ostendimus, veritatis regnum sibi vindicavit. — Spiritus sanctus “bears witness only to *good works*,” and this witness is one with “the peace of mind that arises in the mind from good works.”

⁴⁾Cognitio naturalis and revelatio could therefore be set down as opposites (tract. theol.-polit. pag. 141, cf. princ. phil. Cart. II, 13. schol. Cog. metaph. II. c. 12), and the relation between cognitio supranaturalis and *legitime argumentari* is determined as an inverse relation (tract. theol.-polit. pag. 139). The “more” in revelation becomes “res imperceptibiles, quas tantum imaginari possumus” (pag. 97).

¹⁾In this meaning law is opposed to æterna veritas (pag. 51), law to moral teachings (pag. 87 f.), lawgiver to teacher (pag. 89). Law in the vulgar meaning man can transgress, but not God’s æternum decretum, which is “in universa natura inscriptum” (tract. polit. II, 22).

²⁾Precisely for this reason it is universal, not tied to promises and threats, and contains beatitudo (chap. 4–5). — The virtuous man will do the good and refrain from the bad because it agrees with his nature, not because a law sets rewards or punishments for it (Ep. 34).

¹⁾On miracles cf. Cog. met. II. c. 9. 12. Ep. 23. 74.

believes one has in miracles a surer proof of God's essence and existence than in those laws themselves, while nevertheless such a deviation from the universal laws of nature would bring discord into the order of nature and set the most original concepts of our mind, which stand and fall with its validity, in conflict with themselves, overthrow all certainty and precisely make God's existence impossible²⁾.

From this fundamental difference between the conception of reason and that of religious representation, it follows that *Scripture*, which contains revelation, is a peculiar domain, with a distinctive character conditioned by the power of comprehension of the multitude, and *that Scripture and philosophy must therefore be set down as mutually independent*. Scripture must be regarded as something historically given, which must be grasped as such, and thus interpreted by itself. Interpretation must proceed purely objectively, not prove its truth, but establish what is factual³⁾. The means to this is an unbiased *theory of Scripture*, built on knowledge of the language of Scripture, of the [155] history of the books, of the personal lives, circumstances of their times and fortunes of the individual authors.

Scripture, regarded in this way, will prove to consist of very heterogeneous books, from different times, as an incomplete collection of historical documents. It will prove that there is found in it no agreement with respect to the speculative, which by the nature of prophecy must have been conceived differently by the different prophets, but only with respect to the practical¹⁾. Scripture can be called *holy* and *divine* only because it has regard to piety and religion; these designations are conditioned by the use that is made of the thing. "Nihil extra mentem absolute, sed tantum respective ad ipsam sacrum aut profanum aut impurum est." "*The word of God*" must acquire a far smaller extent than Scripture, which is called the word of God only because it contains what is essential to religion. While Scripture has undergone manifold changes, *the word of God contained in it is uncorrupted*. The extent of "the word of God", of the essential teaching of Scripture,

²⁾Tract. theol.-polit. pag. 77: Quidquid contra naturam est, id contra rationem est, et quod contra rationem, id absurdum est, et proinde etiam refutandum. The miracle becomes a relative concept and designates only: opus, cuius causam naturalem exemplo alterius rei solitæ explicare non possumus, vel saltem ipse non potest, qui miraculum scribit aut narrat. — Spinoza's critique of miracles finds indirect application to the concept of revelation, to which he himself also points the way (pag. 81).

³⁾Tract. theol.-polit. pag. 87: tota biblicorum cognitio ab iisdem solis est petenda. — pag. 84: dico methodum interpretandi scripturam haud differre a methodo interpretandi naturam, sed cum ea prorsus convenire. — pag. 86: de solo sensu orationum, non autem de ejus veritate laboramus. Yet once the factual has been found out, reason must necessarily judge the truth of revelation (of prophecy) (Ep. 34. Cog. metaph. II. c. 8. Tract. theol.-polit. pag. 167 f.: Verum quidem est, scripturam per scripturam interpretandam esse, quamdiu de solo orationum sensu et mente prophetarum laboramus, sed postquam verum sensum eruiamus, necessario judicio et ratione utendum, ut ipsi assensum præbeamus).

¹⁾With the New Testament the relation is somewhat different than with the Old, since in the apostles the element of revelation recedes before natural knowledge; yet discrepancies are found in them too.

must be determined by the purpose of Scripture: to make itself intelligible to all men. It can therefore not comprise subtle speculations, which are accessible only to few, but only the very simplest things, which even the most simple-minded can grasp. Since it does not wish to teach science, it requires not insight, but only *obedience* (pag. 154), and since obedience to God shows itself *only* in love of one's neighbour, the essential content of the word of God becomes: to love God above all things and one's neighbour as oneself (pag. 151), together with the propositions that follow from this with necessary consequence: "that God exists, takes care of all, that he is almighty, that by his decision it goes well [156] with the pious, and ill with the ungodly, and that our salvation depends solely on his grace", and finally the general moral precepts, which are more determinate expressions of this¹⁾. Scripture thus requires only the knowledge that is necessary for obedience. For since man at this standpoint is regarded as led only by affects, not by insight, only that knowledge acquires significance which in the form of affects can influence the affects, thus only such representations of God as can directly influence men's way of acting, e.g. the representation of divine justice and love, whereas men, with respect to the knowledge of God's essence as it is in itself, without direct regard to human action, can "sine scelere toto coelo errare" (pag. 157). Only the relation to actions gives opinions the character of pious or impious: "so that, if anyone, by believing what is right, becomes refractory [157] (contumax), then in reality he has an impious faith, whereas if anyone, by believing what is false, becomes obedient, he has a pious faith". What is required in Scripture is simple faith: "To believe in God, to have reverence for him, or, what is the same, to obey God" (pag. 160). Faith as objective therefore becomes not a sum of dogmas, but is nothing other than "to have such a representation (talía sentire) of God that it cannot be dispensed with for obedience to him, and that conversely, when obedience is given, this representation must be an inseparable consequence." (pag. 161). It is thus not saving "per se", but merely "ratione obedientiæ", and he who is truly obedient necessarily has

¹⁾Tract. theol.-polit. pag. 151. cf. pag. 63 and pag. 163 f.: The essential dogmas are contained in the proposition: dari ens supremum, quod justitiam et caritatem amat, cuique omnes, ut salvi sint, obedire tenentur, eumque cultu justitiæ et caritate erga proximum adorare. Therein lies: 1) Deum, hoc est ens supremum, summe justum et misericordem, sive veræ vitæ exemplar existere; 2) Eum esse unicum; 3) Eum ubique esse præsentem, vel omnia ipsi patere; 4) Ipsum in omnia supremum habere jus et dominium, nec aliquid jure coactum, sed ex absoluto beneplacito et singulari gratia facere; 5) Cultum Dei eiusque obedientiam in sola justitia et caritate sive amore erga proximum consistere; 6) Omnes, qui hoc vivendi ratione Deo obediunt, salvos tantum esse, reliquos autem, qui sub imperio voluptatum vivunt, perditos; 7) Denique Deum poenitentibus peccata condonare (for otherwise all would despair, whereas this faith strengthens the love of God). The different possible conceptions of these propositions have no influence on faith, provided only that they do not act harmfully on action. — It is easily seen that among the determinations given there occur several which Spinoza elsewhere rejects as anthropomorphic (e.g. God's justitia and misericordia, cf. pag. 50, 51, 158), and that the expressions are so framed that his own view can be put into them, as e.g. in the doctrine of the forgiveness of sins.

a true and saving faith. Faith is judged *solely* by works, and requires not so much true as pious (pia) dogmas, i.e. such as move the mind to obedience (yet he who professes them must not see that they are false, for then accepting them becomes an impossibility). Everyone therefore also has the right to interpret the dogmas in the way they become most suited to prompt him to obedience.

Once the essence of faith has thus been determined, the relation between it and philosophy can now be definitively stated: “The aim of *philosophy* is nothing but truth, that of *faith* nothing but obedience and piety¹⁾. The foundation of philosophy is the common notions (notiones communes), and it has its source in nature alone; the foundation of faith, on the other hand, is history and language, and its source is Scripture and revelation alone” (tract. theol.-polit. pag. 165). There is thus no community and no kinship between the two; they are as far apart as heaven and earth. Faith makes no encroachment on the freedom to philosophize; it grants everyone the right to hold any opinions whatsoever, and condemns as heretics and schismatics only those who preach insubordination, hatred, strife and anger, while it counts as pious only those who, according to the capacities of their intellect, prompt to justice and love. Just as [158] Scripture is not to be reinterpreted according to reason, so reason is not to subordinate itself to Scripture. The proposition on which the whole of theology¹⁾ rests, that men can be blessed by obedience alone without the knowledge of things²⁾, cannot indeed be proved by reason and the natural light, which must set down blessedness as one with the knowledge of God. Consistently, then, it would have to be rejected; for reason alone decides truth (pag. 170), also with respect to the understanding of the dogmas. But this consequence Spinoza does not state; he contents himself with giving the premises for it. Instead he adduces what can give this doctrine a “moral certainty.” This becomes essentially *the authority of the prophets*, which is grounded on the moral content of their teaching, agreeing with reason, and which brings us to assume: “that they taught, not deceitfully, but with full conviction (ex vero animo), that men become blessed through obedience and faith, and since they have moreover confirmed this by signs, we are persuaded to believe that they did not say it lightly (temere), nor were they out of their minds when they prophesied.” Moreover, this doctrine, which can be accepted without

¹⁾Tract. theol.-polit. pag. 170: Ratio regnum veritatis et sapientiæ [est], theologia autem pietatis et obedientiæ; cf. princ. phil. Cart. II. 13. schol.

¹⁾Tract. theol.-polit. pag. 170: Theology is equal to revelatio, quatenus indicat scopum, quem diximus Scripturam intendere (nempe rationem et modum obediendi, sive veræ pietatis et fidei dogmata), hoc est, id quod proprie vocatur Dei verbum.

²⁾Hoc est, quod ad salutem sive beatitudinem satis sit, divina decreta tanquam jura sive mandata amplecti, nec opus sit, easdem ut æternas veritates concipere, non ratio, sed revelatio docere potest. — Spinozæ Opera ed. Paulus I, p. 442).

danger and harm, also contains a great consolation for those who are not very strong in reason (*qui ratione non ita pollent*). “For since absolutely all can obey, whereas, in comparison with the whole human race, there are only few who acquire a virtue led by reason alone, we would, if we did not have this testimony of Scripture, despair of [159] the salvation of almost all” (cap. XV. the conclusion). One must therefore not reject this doctrine out of hand because it cannot be proved mathematically¹⁾.

From what was developed at the beginning of the chapter concerning the right of the state and of the sovereign power, it follows, when it is applied to religious matters, that *jus circa sacra* must lie with the head of state. For since justice and love are not the ruling powers in the state of nature, but only become so in the state, they can first acquire legal force through the right of the state, and this is the same as: through the decision of those who have the right to rule. But since the kingdom of God consists solely in the right (law) of justice and love, the consequence again becomes *that God has no kingdom except through those who hold dominion*. This also follows from the fact that reason does not comprehend that God as prince and lawgiver gives men laws (see above), since, then, the divine teachings cannot acquire the force of law immediately from God, but must acquire it mediately through those who have the right to rule and give laws, and God only through them becomes ruler and lord over human affairs. Divine right must thus depend [160] on the decision of the sovereign power²⁾, and the interpretation of it must likewise belong to that power. The outward worship of religion (*cultus externus*) and all exercise of piety must be directed according to the peace and concord of the state. For without the state nothing good can subsist; therefore the welfare of the state must be the highest law; but what the welfare of the state is, only the rulers of the state can decide; it is therefore their right to determine in what way everyone is to show piety (*pietas*) toward his neighbour, that is to say: in what way everyone is obliged to obey God¹⁾. It is the duty of the subjects in this respect to obey unconditionally the commands of the authorities, and the right of the authorities is limited only by impossibility and contrariety to reason.

¹⁾How Spinoza's utterances about blessedness through obedience are to be understood lies immediately in his doctrine of the affects and of the imagination. In one of the notes added later to the tract. theol.-polit. (cf. Bruder's edition III, p. 217) he sets “the love of God”, which is a virtue that with necessity inheres in the man who knows God, against “obedience”, which merely has regard to the will of the one who commands, not to the necessity and truth of the thing. Obedience is thus conditioned by the imagination's conception of the eternal truths as arbitrary laws: a conception which reason corrects, and as it is corrected, obedience passes over at once into love, which follows from true knowledge with the same necessity as light from the sun. “*Ex rationis igitur ductu Deum quidem amare, sed non obedire ei possumus*” cf. tract. polit. II, 22.

²⁾Concerning the extent of the right of the sovereign power over against the Church cf. tract. theol.-polit. pag. 221.

¹⁾We are obliged to show *pietas toward all*; regard for the general therefore becomes determinative, but this regard is taken by the head of state.

“Piety itself and the *inner* worship of God,” (*Ipsa pietas et Dei internus cultus*), becomes a domain which the sovereign power cannot reach²⁾, but neither can it wish to encroach upon it, for the end of the state and of piety is the same: love (*caritas*) and concord (*tract. theol.-polit. c. 16. 19. cf. tract. polit. III, 10. VI, 40. VII, 26, VIII, 46 ff.*).

From this right belonging to the sovereign power, and from the essence of religion, it now follows again that it will be dangerous for the state and for religion itself when the clergy is permitted to decree laws and dogmas, to refer the purely speculative to divine right, and to give laws about disputable opinions. (This is shown in chapter 18 by examples from the history of the Jews.) In this direction, therefore, *science* can demand the protection of the state against clerical encroachments. And the state must in general respect *freedom of thought*, since the right to think is inalienable¹⁾, and likewise *the freedom to utter one's thoughts*, which is so deeply grounded in human nature that it cannot be taken from men. Yet freedom of speech can be limited in so far as it immediately contains an action or has a hostile tendency against the sovereign power (pag. 227. 228). But every unjustified attempt to suppress freedom of thought and of speech must prove fruitless and at the same time dangerous for the sovereign power itself and harmful to morality and public quiet, since it will call forth faithlessness, hypocrisy, insubordination, discord and the decline of the state in spiritual respects. The end of the state is indeed precisely this: not to cow, but to free from fear, to make rational development, or freedom, possible: *finis reipublicæ revera libertas est*. The best state must therefore grant everyone the same freedom to philosophize as faith grants everyone (pag. 229). And that the freedom of thought which is demanded is possible without harm to the common weal, and that the standing of the authorities is sufficient to prevent abuse, Spinoza shows by an example from his native land, by the example of the city of Amsterdam, where the different sects and nations live together in concord and peace. He can then conclude the treatise with the result: “Nothing is more conducive to the security of the state than that piety and religion be placed *solely* in the exercise of love and equity, and that the right of the sovereign power, with respect to both the sacred and the secular, be extended only to actions, so that it is otherwise granted to everyone to think what he will and to utter what he thinks” (pag. 233, cf. the Preface).

²⁾The individual's *jus libere sentiendi de religione, libere judicandi, eandemque sibi explicandi et interpretandi*, is inalienable (*tract. theol.-polit. pag. 103; cf. pag. 215. 225*). Religion as consisting in *animi simplicitas* and *veracitas* is *nullius juris neque autoritatis publicæ*. pag. 102. — The freedom of religious opinions lies, moreover, already in Spinoza's conception of the relation of religion to the imagination.

¹⁾*Tract. theol.-polit. pag. 231: Omnes homines non possunt eadem sentire. — pag. 227: Fieri non potest, ut omnes æque eadem sentiant et uno ore loquantur.*

Chapter Eight.

Man's Freedom and Eternity.

[162] In Chapter 6, through the doctrine of the affects and their power over man, man's condition of bondage was developed. Through the determination of the relation of reason to the affects, and of the conception of the affects as good and evil conditioned by this relation, we were led to the opposition between the concept of the free man and that of the slave (of the wise man and of the ignorant); but this opposition was still held as relative, within a more and a less. The same relativity remained in the doctrine of the social relation and of religion, even though its removal lay as a simple consequence in the hints given. What now remains is to determine decisively what was earlier only hinted at: the concept of human *freedom*; but for the time being the development of this concept again takes the form of a doctrine of *liberation*; precisely because the point of departure was originally taken from man represented as a single, finite modus, dominated by the affects. From that very thing which is conceived as finite, the possibility of overcoming finitude, limitation, is to be shown; but this overcoming can only be partial: the finite's approximation to the infinite, going on without end. But through the consideration of reason, of the essence of the mind, the true conception then breaks forth: limitation and time vanish; eternity as being swallows up the becoming of time into itself.

On this point it will be necessary to attend closely to the hints toward the right conception that are given in Spinoza. Precisely here, where he collides most strongly with the common consciousness, he must express himself accommodatingly, and as it were veil his view.

From the development of the essence of the affects as passive it followed that they had their origin in the confused and unclear ideas. Through them the mind was passive, [163] whereas it is active as producing clear and distinct ones. These latter must therefore become the most essential remedy against the affects¹⁾ in that they themselves act as *active* affects. The affect, which is a passion, ceases to be one as soon as we form a clear

¹⁾Just as, in the development of human bondage, the starting point was taken from the body, so, in the development of freedom, the starting point is taken from the mind. A dualism involuntarily betrays itself.

and distinct idea of it; for it is a passion only as a confused idea, and the idea we form of it is not different from the affect itself insofar as this is referred to the mind alone (Eth. V. 3). But since in all things there is something common, and what is common can only be conceived adequately, there is no affection of the body of which we cannot form some clear and distinct idea, so that it is therefore in everyone's power, at least in part, to gain mastery over the affects. When the affect becomes the object of a clear and distinct knowledge, the mind, when it is affected by it, is determined to think that which it conceives clearly and distinctly, and in which it fully rests; and the affect itself, so conceived, is separated from the thought of the external cause (since through the thought of what is common the separation of limitation is removed) and is joined with true thoughts. Through this separation not only do passionate love and passionate hatred cease (cf. their definitions); but the appetites that usually arise from these affects are prevented, by becoming rational, from rising to excess. For it is the same appetite by which men are said to act and to be passive; thus *ambitio* and *pietas* are the same appetite, that men should live according to our disposition; but the former is irrational, the latter rational, since the former has arisen from inadequate, the latter from adequate ideas (Eth. V, 4 schol.).

The adequate knowledge of the affect is thus the most essential remedy against it as passion. In conceiving what is common, it removes, as we saw, the representation of the external, single cause, and frees us from the passionate relation to it; but at the [164] same time, since through it we conceive things as *necessary*, it brings it about that we are affected less by them than if we conceived them as free (Eth. V, 5); and because it conceives what is always present and always equally common, the active affects that proceed from it become, with respect to duration in time, stronger than those that refer to single things, which can be regarded as not present; the causes that call them forth become more manifold, and stronger through their combined action. And since the mind, as long as it does not struggle with affects that are contrary to our nature, i.e. that hinder the mind from understanding, has the power, as an active mode of thought, to form clear and distinct ideas, and to deduce others from them, — whence it, on account of the parallelism of mind and body, follows that the affections of the body are at the same time connected according to the order of reason¹⁾ — it thereby gains a greater power of resistance against the passive states, which cannot so easily disturb what is rationally linked together as what is uncertain and vague.

¹⁾Spinoza is compelled by the assumption of this parallelism, in positing a bodily affection that corresponds to the mind's adequate idea, to posit an imagination that has the same object as the intellect (Eth. V, 1. 12. dem.), and that thus can only improperly keep that name (cf. Eth. II, 17 schol.).

Since everything that we understand clearly and distinctly is referred back to God, and since in every affect there is something that can be understood thus, the mind can refer every affect back to him. But when man understands himself and his affects clearly and distinctly, *he loves God*, and that the more highly, the more comprehensive the knowledge is (Eth. V, 14 f.). Love arises when the idea of God accompanies the distinct idea (cf. the definition of love). It must, above all else, occupy the mind, since it is called forth by every affection. No one can hate God; for since the idea of God in us is clear [165] and distinct, we *act* in having it, and consequently no affect of sorrow can arise from it¹⁾. Nor can it, as the highest good common to all men, be tainted by the affect of envy or of jealousy, but it is strengthened ever more, the more men we imagine as united with God by the same bond of love. There is no affect that is directly contrary to it and that can destroy it; *it is therefore the most constant of all the affects*, and insofar as it is referred to the body (*quatenus ad corpus refertur*), it can not be destroyed except with the body itself (Eth. V, 20. schol.). Since its object is unchangeable and eternal, and truly in our power, it itself acquires the unchangeableness of its object²⁾, can grow ever stronger, more and more displace the passive affects, and fill the greatest part of the mind.

Even at this point, then, where Spinoza has brought forward the love of God as the strongest and most unchangeable affect, against which no contrary affect can hold its ground, man is nevertheless still posited as not completely freed from the affects³⁾, but only as confining them to a small region; and the difference between the free man and the slave still remains quantitatively determinable by the different proportion between the adequate and inadequate ideas of which each one's mind consists. This halting at an approximation has, as already touched upon, its ground in the point of departure taken; but in the concept of the knowledge of God and the love of God a standpoint is given from which this point of departure vanishes, and the conception consistent with [166] Spinoza's fundamental view comes forth. Spinoza presents this at the end of his Ethics; but partly in such a way that in his expressions he accommodates himself to the common representation, partly in such a way that at the end he again adds determinations that essentially concern the relative, merely quantitative opposition.

He makes the transition from the doctrine of the remedies against the affects to the new developments with the words (Eth. V, 20. schol.) that he has now finished with

¹⁾God cannot even be said, insofar as he is the cause of things, to be the cause of sorrow when they affect us; for insofar as we understand the cause of sorrow, it ceases to be a passive state, i.e. it ceases to be sorrow, and insofar, therefore, as we understand God as the cause of sorrow, we feel joy (Eth. V, 18. schol.).

²⁾Cf. de intell. emend. pag. 357 f.

³⁾Herein lies the same contradiction that appeared in the doctrine of knowledge and of the affects through the conception of man as abstractly finite.

what concerns *the present life* (*vitam præsentem*), and that it is now time to pass on to what pertains to the duration of the mind (*durationem*) without relation to the body¹⁾. By the expression “the present life” the relation to the imagination is indicated, since the determinations of time have significance only for it. By the expression *duratio* it is indicated that the talk of the mind without relation to the body²⁾ is accommodating, for we do not ascribe to the human mind a duration (*duratio*) that can be determined by time except insofar as it expresses the actual existence of the body, i.e. *ipsi durationem non tribuimus nisi durante corpore* (Eth. V, 23. demonstr.); and according to Spinoza's fundamental conception it is just as impossible to think a mind without a body as a body without a mind (cf. Ep. 58). What is therefore developed in connection with the representation of the immortality of the soul is a development of *the mind's true, eternal essence as the idea of the body conceived under the form of eternity*.

The mind's highest *virtue*, i.e. its essential *nature* (V, 25. dem.), and therefore its highest *striving*, is to understand things by the “third kind of knowledge”, *intuitive knowledge*, which proceeds from the adequate knowledge of God's attributes to the adequate knowledge of the essence of things. This knowledge of things is *direct* knowledge of [167] God; for through it they are known in their unity with him (Eth. V, 24, cf. Eth. II, 45. schol., tract. theol.-polit. pag. 46 f.). It expresses most perfectly the human essence in its activity; it is thus the source of the highest *acquiescentia*, i.e. the highest joy, accompanied by the idea of oneself and one's virtue. But since this kind of knowledge understands things in God, the joy is necessarily accompanied by the idea of God as cause, and thereby arises *amor Dei intellectualis*, i.e. a love of God, not insofar as we imagine him as present through the imagination, but insofar as we understand through reason (*intellectus*) that he is eternal (Eth. V, 32. schol.).

But at this point, through the essence of the highest knowledge and through the intellectual love of the eternal, a light falls back on the preceding development. The third kind of knowledge can indeed arise from the second, whose ideas are also true and adequate, but not from the first, the imagination, with its incomplete and confused ideas¹⁾. But only for the first kind of knowledge does time have significance; adequate knowledge is in the form of eternity; for it time becomes something unreal, vanishing. The third kind of knowledge has its adequate (formal) ground in *the mind as eternal*, i.e.

¹⁾Cf. Eth. V, 40. schol.: de mente, quatenus sine relatione ad corporis existentiam consideratur.

²⁾Eth. V, 23: Mens humana non potest cum corpore absolute destrui, sed ejus aliquid remanet, quod æternum est.

¹⁾The denial of this transition from inadequate to adequate knowledge, i.e. from the being of the mind as finite to its unity with the infinite, is the necessary parallel to the denial of the transition from the infinity of substance to existing finite things (cf. chapter 2).

in the mind insofar as it expresses the essence of the body under the form of eternity, not insofar as it expresses the present, actual existence of the body, which is the condition for the imagination and for the conception of things in relation to time and duration. But since the cause, the mind, is eternal, the effect, the intuitive knowledge, must necessarily be so too; it is an eternal logical consequence of the mind's nature (Eth. V, 33. schol.).

[168] That the mind is *eternal* follows from the fact that in God, as the cause not only of the existence of the human body, but also of its essence, — which therefore must be known with eternal necessity through the very essence of God, — there must be given an idea that expresses the essence of the human body under the form of eternity. But since the human mind is the idea of the human body, that idea must belong to the essence of the mind, which thus becomes eternal. This eternity of the mind cannot, since eternity has no relation to time, be the object of a memory; but we nevertheless have consciousness of it; for “the eyes of the mind, by which it sees and observes things, are the proofs themselves” (Eth. V, 23. schol., cf. 34. schol.). Memory and all the determinations of the imagination are tied to the duration of the body (*duratio*); but the mind expresses the body as actual not only insofar as it conceives it in relation to time and place, but also insofar as it understands it as contained in God and following from the necessity of the divine nature¹⁾, thus insofar as it understands it as real, as having existence through God's eternal essence, i.e. *as eternal* (Eth. V, 29. schol. 30. dem.). So determined, the mind is “an eternal mode of thought (*æternus cogitandi modus*), which is determined by another eternal mode of thought, while this in turn is determined by another, and so on to infinity, so that all in unity (*simul*) constitute God's eternal and infinite intellectus” (Eth. V, 40. schol.).

Since the mind and the highest form of knowledge is eternal, *does not come to be* (V, 31. schol.), *the intellectual love* of God must also be eternal, and it must be *the only* eternal love. It is God's very love, with which God loves himself (God loves himself in that he, as infinite, is in possession of an infinite perfection, accompanied by the idea of himself as *causa sui*, V, 35. dem.), not as infinite, but insofar as he is determined by the essence of the human mind considered under the form of eternity, or, in other words: the mind's intellectual love of God is a part of the infinite love with which God loves himself (V, 36). *Insofar, then, as God loves himself*, he loves men, and God's love of men and the mind's intellectual love of God are one and the same¹⁾. Since it follows with necessity

¹⁾Cf. Eth. V, 36. schol.: quia nostræ mentis essentia in sola cognitione consistit, cuius principium et fundamentum Deus est, hinc perspicuum nobis fit, quomodo et qua ratione mens nostra secundum essentiam et existentiam ex natura divina sequatur, et continuo a Deo pendeat.

¹⁾When in prop. 17 it is denied that God loves in the proper sense, this denial applies to love as *passio*, and when it is understood thus, it becomes untrue to demand love in return from God (V, 19). But in

from the essence of the mind, insofar as this is considered as an eternal consequence of God's nature, there can be nothing that is contrary to it, or that can abolish it; for anything of the kind would be an opposite of the true, and, in gaining power over it, would make it the false²⁾.

Intellectual love is, as the mind's highest expression, our *freedom*³⁾ (V, 36. schol.) and our *blessedness* (beatitudo). Blessedness expresses not a transition to a greater perfection, but an eternal possession of perfection (Eth. V. 33. schol.). It is one with virtue itself, not [170] a reward for it; only in the very active power that blessedness expresses does our virtue, i.e. our active capacity, consist (Eth. V, 42).

At this point the Spinozist Ethics and the Spinozist system are concluded. Through the apparent becoming in time, through the representation of the single finite things, we have returned to the thought of the one, infinite, eternal being, which *is*, and does not *become*, which, as its own cause, posits itself in its inner fullness of eternal modi. The same view that formed itself for the mind in the conception of infinite extension, which, through the laws of motion and rest infinitely modified, was eternally like itself, comes forth here too in the domain of mind. The eternal thought, which is the active essence of substance, is, as infinitely modified by the ideas, eternally like itself. What is limitation and negation has eternally vanished; the incomplete, inadequate ideas are, seen from this standpoint, true and adequate, and governed by the same eternal law of necessity. Only the eternal is, and in the light of the eternal what appeared in the form of time vanishes, and it vanishes, not as something that *has* been; but its being is its vanishing. The human mind is, according to its positive essence, intellectus, in unity with substance, enclosed by God's eternal idea, by the intellectual love with which he loves himself.

From this standpoint must be understood the propositions that Spinoza, again approaching the conception of representation (of the imagination), adds at the end of his Ethics (V, 38. ff.). In these the mind is still determined as a *composite* of adequate and inadequate ideas; reason takes its place in it *alongside* the imagination; the eternal in the mind becomes a greater or lesser *part*; that which death cannot touch is compared, as the *more* perfect, with the perishable, and the opposition between the wise man and the

intellectual love the mind is in unity with God, does not relate itself to him as to another; it is therefore one with God's immediate certainty of his infinite active being, and the expression love designates something qualitatively other than in that place.

²⁾The relation here is thus other than with regard to single things, which are considered in relation to a certain time and a certain place; for of these there holds, by the nature of quantity, the axiom that there is in nature no single thing without there being another that is more powerful and stronger, and by which the former can be destroyed. But the conception of things as single is at this point abandoned.

³⁾Freedom presupposes existence through itself (Eth. I, defin. 7, cf. I, 17. Coroll.), thus unity of essence and existence, the fundamental determination of substance. When freedom is ascribed to the mind, it is thus seen in unity with substance, so that the latter's determination can be transferred immediately to it.

ignorant (prop. 42. schol.) loses its unconditionedness through limiting determinations. [171] But in Spinoza's proposition that the eternal has no relation to the finite, the corrective is given for that division of the mind; what is called the mind's *better part*, intelligence (Eth. IV, App. c. 32), becomes the one real and active thing in it (V, 40. Coroll.), and the quantitative comparison is rejected (ibid.). And when the wise man is posited as "sui et Dei et rerum *æterna quadam necessitate* conscius," the transition and the difference of degree are again removed, eternal being affirmed, and the end of the system closed together with its beginning.

Chapter Nine.

Characterization and Critique of Spinozism.

Through what was developed in the preceding sections the moments are given for the complete determination of the peculiar character of Spinozism. To establish this, one must start from what was the system's essential task, its inner mainspring, which never ceases to act even where heterogeneous elements force their way in in the execution. What is deviation from the fundamental thought becomes the object not of the characterization of the system, but of the critique of it.

We saw that the fundamental thought was the concept of substance in its infinity, that the task of thought was to see it as *all* reality, that its inner impelling desire was energetically to hold fast the thought of infinity as encompassing everything. All reality is *in* substance, substance is all reality: that is the system's fundamental thought, and by it the system is determined as *pantheistic*. But this determination does not yet distinguish it from many other systems of entirely different origin; it becomes only a common designation, which must receive its specific difference. This is given by what is posited [172] in the relation between the two attributes: the concept of necessity as the form of the being of substance. We saw that the concept of substance had its origin in the concept of the thinking I; it was, according to its provenance, the objectified infinite essence of thought. But we saw at the same time that thought, which had separated nature from itself as its opposite, and which, in determining it abstractly as its opposite, had no other determination for it than the abstract concept of extension, had to seek its content

in nature; and since in the unity of substance it was again set in unity with nature, but only in the unity of *parallelism*, the law of nature abstractly conceived, the law of necessity, had to become the form of thought, and, as the form of thought, also the form of thought's objectified infinite essence. Even though, therefore, the point of departure is originally taken from self-consciousness, the form of the being of substance becomes *not the synthesis of self-consciousness, but the immediate self-certainty of causality* in its necessity. Since substance, *causa sui*, is conceived by thought in the whole wealth of determinations which follow timelessly from its essence with eternal necessity, in infinite modifications, the form of this eternal unfolding, which is not separated from its source, is the law of necessity. Substance is the necessary *cause* of necessary *effects*, not the free originator of freely posited *ends*, and since in representation the effects are separated from their cause, their infinite series comes to be governed by the compelling law of external necessity.

The system's pantheistic fundamental character thereby acquires a closer individualization. *That which infinitely is becomes the necessary power of nature, immediately self-certain in its unity with thought.* "God or nature" expresses this concept.

But with this determination of substance the relation of human thought to it is given, and through the character of thinking conditioned thereby, the character of the system is again more closely determined. Thought is in substance with an immediate certainty that finds its own essence again in substance. Since limitation is only a negative, every real separation is removed, every scepticism excluded with regard to the infinite. The infinite [173] is the first thought of human thought, its original certainty of itself. And in the infinite it is in unity with its opposite: extension. As expressions of the same substance the modes of the two attributes run parallel; a scepticism with regard to nature is thereby removed. In this immediate certainty and security lies the system's character as *dogmatism*. Thought cannot turn critically against itself; for it has no self subsisting for itself: it is only in the infinite and in it "in unity with the whole of nature". And since it is *thought*, as this determinate form of the human essence, to the exclusion of other forms of the mind, such as feeling and the like, that finds itself again in substance, and is therefore determined as the only adequate expression of the human essence, thought, reason, alone determines the truth; it is the imperturbable revelation of the divine, which includes certainty and is the sole judge of the false and the true. Thereby the system acquires the character of *rationalism*: whatever does not congrue with the universally valid determinations of thought, it rejects as belonging to untrue and incomplete representation.

Finally, in the twofold determination of the concept of substance and of thought's

relation to it, the determination of the form of the development of thought is given. The mind's form of existence is, like that of substance, causality in its self-certainty: from the mind as an active mode of thought there develop the adequate ideas linked together with mathematical necessity, which form a parallel to the series of things linked together by the law of natural necessity. The unfolding of thought is thus in the form of mathematical necessity; but since true knowledge is in the element of eternity, the development as development vanishes in the unity of substance, which in its eternal fullness shows itself to *intuitive knowledge*, which with one glance sees substance in its infinity together with that which infinitely, with eternal necessity, follows from its essence.

[174] The determinations *pantheism* and *naturalism* thus designate the system from the objective side, the determinations *dogmatism* and *rationalism* from the subjective; but the two sides cannot be separated; the character of dogmatism is, just as much as that of rationalism, given in the objective determinations.

With the character of the system thus established, it becomes the basis for the task of critique. This task receives its limitation from what is already historically given: philosophy in its progressive development marks the one-sidedness of the Spinozist system in integrating it. In the presentation of Spinoza's relation to later philosophy (see the next chapter) the results of this objective, indirect, historical critique will be indicated. In this chapter the task of critique will then be to judge Spinozism from *its own* standpoint, to investigate whether it has reached the goal it has set itself, whether it has been able to carry through its fundamental thought, whether inconsistencies have not forced their way in, and whether these have not then been called forth with necessity by the deficiency of the fundamental thought, and therefore partly demonstrate its unfitness to encompass what it wanted to encompass, partly raise the demand for other fundamental determinations, whereby a transition is made to the historical progressive development.

From the domain of this critique, then, every problem is provisionally excluded that has not arisen within the fundamental view given by the system. As long as thought consistently unfolds without touching such a problem, the demand on it to solve it is unfounded. If it succeeds in closing itself into an inner whole without reaching the problem, the problem is by that very fact rejected as unjustified. Only through inconsistencies does thought lose this right of rejection.

Next, it follows of itself that such contradictions in the system as are only *apparent* do not become objects of critique. Of such there are, precisely in Spinoza, on account of

his peculiar conception of the finite, a great many, and it is precisely on them that, e.g., [175] the critique of Bayle and of most of Spinoza's contemporary opponents relies. In the foregoing several such have been pointed out, and the contradiction has been shown to be removed when it is seen from Spinoza's standpoint; they will therefore be passed over here.

Spinozism has set itself its task through its fundamental concept, and this, we saw, was substance, conceived in its strict infinity, and in the parallelism of its mutually absolutely independent attributes. The task, then, is to think the thought of infinity in such a way that finitude at no point establishes itself over against it, while infinity nevertheless acquires a fullness; and next: to think this fullness as expressed in the mutually independent attributes, each of which expresses the infinite wholly.

First, then, the thought of infinity is to be thought as *rich in content*. As such it can only be thought when substance posits in itself an other, a really subsisting opposite, which is nevertheless taken up into its unity, bound by it. But here the difficulty at once comes forth. The infinite substance cannot posit an opposite in itself; the form of its being is infinite causality, which, as infinite, posits itself only as infinite, and immediately is one as cause and effect. Limitation would only be negation, but the infinite cannot negate itself, and therefore cannot limit itself; by its very thought the thought of finitude is excluded¹⁾. But the drive of human thought to self-affirmation, to thinking, to philosophizing, rests on the separation in existence between the finite and the infinite: if the finite is absolutely removed in thought, the possibility of human thinking is annihilated; to philosophize becomes a self-contradiction. This forces out the doubleness [176] in the conception of what becomes the effect of substance. Seen from the concept of substance, holding fast to the proposition that limitation is negation, one gets only from infinite to infinite. Substance as causa and as causatum is in eternal oppositionless unity with itself. But since separation is eternally removed, the concept sinks together into itself without difference; human thought expires, as it were, in its airless space. Therefore the need of thought forces forth a fuller view: the infinite that follows with eternal necessity from the nature of substance (Eth. I, 16) becomes something infinitely modified in its unity with itself. In the infinity of extension the *infinitely many* modi proceed according to the unchangeable laws of motion and rest; in the infinity of thought the ideas proceed in their infinity from the eternal law of reason; in both attributes there forms an image of an eternally unchanged life moved within itself, which expresses the same infinity and

¹⁾Could thought derive a subsisting finite from the infinite, then, according to Spinoza's conception of the relation between thought and its object, a corresponding development, and thus a relation of *time*, would have to be posited in the infinite being determined only by the form of *eternity*.

remotely suggests an *organic* conception. But the laws that bring the multiplicity bound by the unity into infinity remain uncomprehended¹⁾, and since the thought of finitude everywhere dissolves itself in contradictions (cf. p. 79, Note 2, p. 89, 121 and 136), and limitation becomes only something vanishing — and only thus can it be conceived where causality, not end, is the fundamental concept, — the fuller image again vanishes in the indifference of abstraction. But even if it constantly vanishes, it is nevertheless constantly posited anew, for only through it does thought acquire movement, only through it does it avoid denying itself. The general inconsistencies to which this must lead have been brought out at the end of the second chapter (p. 63 f.). In the more special developments [177] their consequences have been shown in detail. It was the doubleness in the conception of the finite that disturbed the limit between imagination and reason, between ratio and scientia intuitiva, that gave universal knowledge a doubtful truth, that made the concept of the common hover between meaning the property common to really separate single things, and the positive one that is the real in the things only represented as single; it was this that let the absolutely different¹⁾ adequate and inadequate ideas be united in the human mind in an uncertain neighborliness; that held thought fast in domains which, strictly speaking, belong only to the imagination; and it was finally this that, even after the single had been conceived under the form of eternity and necessity, the form of being of the *infinite*, held it fast as res *particulares* æternæ. But at this last point the contradiction breaks forth decisively. Since the human mind in intuitive knowledge, which is the eternal determination of its essence (cf. chapter 8), is posited as an æternus cogitandi modus that is a part of God's infinite intellectus (Eth. V, 40. schol.), either this modus, which, even if it is eternal, is nevertheless single, must express the infinity of substance, which is impossible, or it must vanish as single in the infinite, and in its vanishing deny itself and make substance empty of content. At this point, therefore, there is a decisive pointing toward another determination of the fundamental concepts. The conception of limitation merely as negation made the infinite abstract and brought the drive of thinking into contradiction with itself. This points toward the demand to conceive limitation as the self-limitation of the being, as its self-determination in its self-active separation from others, — toward the concept of the *monad*, and with this concept Leibnitz integrates Spinoza's fundamental thought (see the following chapter).

The *second* task Spinozism had set itself was to conceive the attributes of substance,

¹⁾In the fact that the multiplicity of the modifications cannot be deduced, and therefore stands as uncomprehended, it immediately lies that finite consciousness, inadequate knowledge, is not deduced either. It becomes, like the subsisting finite, a presupposition that dissolves itself in contradictions, and vanishes as it goes back into the infinite.

¹⁾They relate to each other as ens to non-ens, as infinite to finite.

thought and extension, as independent, in that they, without including each other's [178] concept, each by itself express substance, and thus to derive everything that followed with necessity from the nature of the single attribute from it alone, without regard to the other. Under the same form of causality, thought and extension should then have been conceived with the parallel series of their modifications. But where the concept of imagination and the passive states of the mind are developed, Spinoza starts from the relations of the body; only through these can we form a view of the essence of the confused, incomplete ideas; in particular, the nature of memory is made perspicuous only by the body's capacity to retain the impressions received, and Spinoza here even comes to speak of the body's being acted upon by external causes as the *ground* of the confused ideas (de emend. intell. p. 384), and of influences that hinder the mind from thinking (Eth. V, 10). And on the other side, where Spinoza develops man's freedom, his essence as acting, as determined by reason and its adequate ideas, the point of departure is taken from the mind alone; only from it is the view formed of the "imago" that corresponds to what is clearly and distinctly conceived (Eth. V, 12), and the mind is now ascribed the power to order the affections of the body (Eth. V, 10 schol.). The parallelism is thus not carried through; there is wavering, as everywhere where the modes of action of the one absolute are posited as constituting absolutely different forms of existence, between a fusion and a hidden dualism. In Spinoza, thought is on the one side determined in its form by the form of the activity of nature, and in this form it expresses, since in substance it is in unity with extension, extension's immediate certainty of itself. It is thus determined by extension both in form and in content; for the determination for thought itself becomes to be *the immediately self-certain thought of extension*. On the other side, by including in its own concept the determination of its opposite, it reaches out over that opposite, which was also originally determined only by the abstract form of thought and has therefore received determinations that conflict with its peculiar [179] essence (e.g. the determination as indivisible). This unconscious mutual determining also sometimes brings Spinoza, as if involuntarily, to apply concepts that are excluded by the fundamental determination, thus the concept of *end* (e.g. Eth. IV. App. C. 4. Tract. polit. V, 2. De emend. intell. p. 360); and the dualism that remains at bottom calls forth the insoluble problem of the innumerable attributes and their relation to thinking (cf. p. 85 f.).

But since Spinoza has thus not been able, at the two decisive points, to solve the task he himself set, critique acquires not only the right to declare the fundamental task unsolved, but it gets a wider scope, since what is hinted at through the inconsistencies

becomes justified demands on the system. It acquires the right to bring out *against Spinoza the abstract character of the system*, which makes everything sink together into the undifferentiated unity of substance, and, under the semblance of existence that is left to the finite, lets it be determined only by a *quantitative* difference, in which the energy of all oppositions is paralysed¹⁾, even the opposition between good and evil, and all fullness vanishes, since individuality becomes a relative, floating concept, which is posited not by an inner peculiarity of essence, but by the externally effected combination of the modifications of extension and of the ideas corresponding to them (cf. chapter 5). It can bring out — what lies partly in this abstraction, partly in the unconscious mutual determining of the attributes — that no peculiar determination can be given for the *human mind* as qualitatively different from the other modi, though a demand for this is made in the system's point of departure, and that there is therefore just as little room for [180] a free point of departure for self-determination, for an individual freedom, for ends, as for the ethical conditioned thereby¹⁾. It can bring out that everything in the mind that is not determined by thinking is excluded from its essence, and that therefore whole spheres of the life of the mind, such as art, are wholly ignored, others, such as religion, conceived only according to their relation to the thought of the intellect. It can bring out that in the domain of nature the dynamic element given in the principle is, within the limits of the finite, overwhelmed by the mechanical, and that the concept of the organic is made impossible by the oppositionlessness of substance. It can finally bring out that the system has not demonstrated the possibility of the concept with which it concludes: the intellectual love of God proceeding from intuitive knowledge; that the problem which is given in the single mind's intuitive knowing — a problem which, thought through, would turn dogmatism into *criticism* — is not solved, and that the system has only granted itself a dispensation, on grounds of impossibility, from solving it. And critique must, even if it concedingly holds fast to this concluding concept, bring out its poor content, which is conditioned by the mind's being determined as the idea of the body (of extension), and extension only by quantity, motion and rest. Intuitive knowledge, which gets only this content, even if in the form of infinity, becomes abstract and poor, and the intellectual love of God is touched by this poverty. But on this point it is nevertheless important not to overlook what so often happens with abstract systems: that the human spirit, and still more perhaps the human heart, puts its richer content into the abstract forms, and

¹⁾Since the difference becomes only quantitative, the determination in Spinoza that an external influence is determined both by the nature of what acts and of what is acted upon also loses its significance. The persistence of individuality under quantitative change, under the affections, becomes inexplicable.

¹⁾Just as physics became metaphysics, ethics becomes physics.

now through an illusion sees them as full through that content. What strikes Spinozism as a system does not strike Spinoza as a thinker. In the exalted calm of his thought, in the energetic seriousness of his life, in the love with which, through the purification of resignation, he sank his thought and his will into the infinite One, there speaks a deeper content, the drive of a richer being, than what he has been able to fix in the forms of [181] thought, and their deficiency must not lead us to overlook the former.

If we now, having let critique bring out what is deficient in Spinoza's philosophy, wish to indicate his lasting significance, we must not restrict it to what is independent of those deficiencies: that he made the demand that the substrate of nature too should be conceived as active, just as he, in his theory of knowledge resting on the principles of existence, energetically held fast to the activity of thinking, — that he in his doctrine of the affects has given a lasting foundation for what one might call the natural history of the human mind, — and that he has asserted the autonomy of philosophy and its independence of the religious, so that he, alone in his time, wanted to be *only* a thinker, and in his thinking had his religion; but we must place it in this: that he, suggesting the idea of an all-organism (cf. especially Eth. II, 13. schol. and Ep. 15), against dualism, against the splitting up of the unity of existence, wanted to think the all-encompassing thought of infinity, to seek the deeper ground in which the infinite essence of the human mind is in active unity with the infinite essence of nature. And although he has determined this ground of unity only as consuming the oppositions, yet the thought that was the inner impelling power of his philosophy is the ground of all thoughts, and, even though it takes up other determinations into itself, it nevertheless remains that which bears these, as the infinite existing thought, encompassing them, bears nature and the human spirit, which have their ground in it.

Chapter Ten.

Spinoza's Relation to Later Philosophy.

Spinoza's system was in its whole character far too alien to the common consciousness, and far too sharply opposed to the general direction of its time, for it to have been [182] able to gain an immediate, thoroughgoing influence. The disappearance of individuality

in the infinite, the annihilation of every anthropomorphic representation of God, the transference of the law of natural necessity to his essence and to his effects, the removal, conditioned by the pantheistic fundamental view, of the opposition between an existing good and evil, the conception of the religious fundamental determinations as mere forms of representation, gave too strong offence to the religious consciousness, which Protestantism had taught to accentuate individuality and, in the struggle for salvation, to sharpen the opposition between good and evil. Spinoza's thoughts terrified, repelled, were not understood. In mysticism's sinking into the divine the heart had found its satisfaction; it was the God of the *heart* to whom the mystic gave himself up, and with whom, in this surrender, he still preserved himself. But Spinoza's infinite is the infinite of *thought*, which gives the feelings no compensation for the surrender.

It is therefore not to be wondered at that Spinoza found only few contemporary disciples. Of only one do we have a writing in Spinoza's spirit, namely *Abrah. Joh. Cuffeler's*: *specimen artis ratiocinandi naturalis et artificialis ad pantosophiæ principia manuducens* (1684) — a kind of logic. Another writing, by the clergyman *van Leenhoff*: *Hemel op aarden* (Heaven on Earth), which on its appearance (1703) aroused much controversy, contains, so far as one can judge from the reports in Bayle and Brucker, only a doctrine of the independent value of virtue, and of resignation under the law of comprehended necessity, which, even if influenced by Spinozism, does not go back to its first principles.

But even if Spinoza found only few adherents, Spinozism nevertheless soon became, as the name for something not understood and abhorred, a heretic's name with which people branded one another, and much free-thinking has probably also given itself a more distinguished appearance by appropriating this name. Therefore an approximately contemporary author, *Roellius* (*de religione naturali*, § 151, pag. 166, cited by Brucker), [183] can say: *Spinozam tota armenta in Belgio sequi ducem*. But from several of the polemical writings against Spinoza still preserved, which, although attacking him, brought upon their authors the accusation of being his secret adherents, one sees how vague and indeterminate the conception of the character of Spinozism was, just as the whole polemical literature without exception shows that Spinoza was constantly misunderstood precisely in the most essential points: in the conception of the relation of finitude to God and of the form of being of the divine. From the representation of the finite as really existing, and of God as acting arbitrarily, — representations that could not be given up without giving up the whole foundation on which one stood, people fought against Spinoza, and drew absurd consequences from his doctrine.

It therefore had to be the fate of Spinozism to take effect only late: it has been like a kernel enclosed in hard shells, which must lie long in the earth before it can sprout, but which then also unfolds in all the more vigorous growth.

On only one of Spinoza's contemporaries has his thinking had an influence that has acquired significance for history; but this influence has been through opposition, as an incitement to an independent development of thought that forms an integrating opposite to Spinoza. This contemporary is *Leibnitz*. It is true that Leibnitz has only seldom expressed himself on his relation to Spinoza, of whom he speaks on the whole with diplomatic caution, and still less put specific points of his doctrine in a direct connection with Spinoza's; but there are nevertheless points of comparison enough present that can both form a parallelism illuminating for both systems and at the same time, while they demonstrate Leibnitz's peculiarity, show a similarity to his predecessor that can hardly everywhere be explained without a definite influence. Where the similarity lies in the whole character of the philosophy of the age, nothing speaks for a dependence; thus when Leibnitz meets Spinoza in conceiving ideas as the mind's original property; when he lets mechanism, to which he otherwise assigns a definite domain, assert itself [184] also within the limit of the mind and of the organic, and when he asserts the significance of philosophy in relation to the religious. But in a more decisive way Leibnitz's determination of the essence of substance as force recalls Spinoza's conception of it as causality; — Leibnitz's fundamental concept, the *monad*, recalls the *Corpora simplicissima* hypothetically assumed in Spinoza's physics (cf. Eth. II, 13), particularly when, with the determination of their relation to the universal individuum, one compares the determinations about the necessary harmony between the parts and the whole (Ep. 15), which form a parallel to the *harmonia præstabilita* given in the concept of the monad; — the concept decisive for Leibnitz's whole doctrine, *the confused representations*, which always involve infinity, recalls Spinoza's conception of the mind as composed of an infinite number of ideas, corresponding to the body's infinite composition, and of these ideas as existing only inadequately in the single mind (as *ideæ confusæ*); — the juxtaposition of the clear and distinct ideas with acting, of the confused with passion, and the referring back of acting to the mind, of passion to the body, is the same in both systems; likewise the parallelism between soul and body, the significance of the body's perfection for the soul, the conception of the whole universe as containing life, of difference as difference of *degree*, and of death and coming-to-be as a continuous transition.

But through this similarity, which points to a kinship, the fundamental difference comes forth. When Leibnitz conceives the essence of substance as activity, this activity

is immediately determined as *self-activity*, in the sense of *individual* determining and separating from others. The one infinite substance becomes the *infinitely many* monads, which, limited *by themselves*, in their independence express by their limit the ideal relation to all the others, and in an individual way include the whole universe within themselves. But Leibnitz's conception of activity as *self-activity* again stands in connection with the [185] fact that force is conceived as a *spiritual* principle, that monad becomes synonymous with *soul*, and that *the form of the mind, in decisive distinction from Spinoza, becomes the synthesis of self-consciousness*, not the immediate self-certainty of causality. And this conception of the form of the mind, which is a logical consequence of conceiving it as originally producing ideas that are in it, and constitutes a specific difference between its mode of being and that of matter, now conditions the conception of God's essence, of the finite, of the mind's acting, and of the relation between thought and extension. In God's essence it is not the law of mathematical necessity that becomes determining, but a hypothetical, moral necessity: a necessity conditioned by regard for the best determines the will. The concept of end again acquires its validity for God and the finite; it becomes the explanatory presupposition for the efficient causes, for mechanism. The coming-to-be of the finite becomes not an effect of necessity, but of God's freedom, on which the existence of things depends, while their essence is given with eternal unchangeable necessity in God's. The finite acquires a centre for self-activity, a freedom in dependence, a self-determination that also makes evil possible. The human mind becomes no longer a *modus cogitandi*, but an imperishable *principium cogitationis*. And extension now becomes no longer an attribute, not something real that in its infinity expresses the divine; it becomes merely the phenomenon of the composition of the single substances. What is lasting, real, active, is only the single substances, the monads, whose essence is spiritual; body, matter, extension become the passive, the non-real, which has its subsistence only in confused representation. In one word, then: individuality, which gives the infinite total organism fullness, breaks forth with the form of self-consciousness, and what is not expressed by this form, the material, loses its rank as the parallel of the mind, and becomes phenomenon, even though a parallelism is mirrored in the phenomenon.

[186] Thus Leibnitz himself expresses, in relation to Spinoza, the peculiar nature of his system's fundamental concept, the monad. Influence is converted into independent production; what is given from without becomes an incitement for creative peculiarity. And by this peculiarity he integrates Spinoza.

In the period between Leibnitz and the last decades of the previous century Spinoza was almost forgotten. *Wolf* polemicized against him (in his *theologia naturalis*), but

with half concepts and without understanding him, and the direction of the age was unfavourable to a deeper thinking. Toward the end of the century *French materialism* invoked Spinoza as an authority. In his concept of God it saw only the concept of nature, in his doctrine of necessity it found its determinism, in his doctrine of the mind's relation to the body its sensualism. The idealistic foundation in him it overlooked; it did not bring those determinations into connection with the whole of his views, but appropriated all the more eagerly the details of his polemic against the theological representations, and of his critique.

In Germany Spinoza at the same time found a kindred spirit in *Lessing*, who could find no rest in the spiritless philosophy of his time, and, since he did not himself have the power to produce one richer in content, sought back to the past. The controversy that was aroused when *Jacobi* revealed the secret of Lessing's Spinozism is well known. It became apparent in this controversy that Jacobi, who, like Leibnitz, was by his peculiarity opposed to Spinoza, but in his genius had the sympathetic understanding of the opposite, was the only one who had penetrated more deeply into Spinoza's thoughts, while *Mendelssohn* and *Herder*, the former even without the external knowledge of Spinozism, sought, through a misunderstanding of it, to bring it together with the trivialized theistic concept of the Leibnitzian theodicy.

This controversy about Spinoza called the study of him back to life, and the new direction of philosophy soon gave it a decisive significance. When *Kant* had made the unproved presupposition of dogmatism, the possibility of knowledge, into a problem, [187] and in the attempt at its solution had given the premisses from which *Fichte* drew the consequences by placing all reality in self-consciousness, the dialectic of the latter again forced forth the need of an objective supplement. Fichte himself had, at the later stage of development of his philosophy, to seek such a one, and could then seek it only in the philosophy that was the sharpest opposite of the system of self-consciousness: in Spinozism with its absolute *being*. The same need drove *Novalis* and *Schleiermacher* to an enthusiastic attachment to Spinoza, which nevertheless did not annihilate their peculiarity. It finally found its most adequate expression in *Schelling*, when, in place of the subjective principle of the Fichtean philosophy, self-consciousness, he posited the subjective-objective, *reason*, the absolute, which is the indifference of the subjective and the objective, the absolute identity, which is never sublated as identity, so that everything that is, is this absolute identity itself, that there is nothing finite, but everything is infinity itself, which only in its form of being is touched by the quantitative difference between preponderant subjectivity and objectivity, but in its essence is and

remains absolute totality. Through the fundamental concept of the system of absolute identity the fundamental concept of Spinozism thus acts, despite the different historical presuppositions, and Schelling rejects Spinozism as “one-sidedly realistic”¹⁾ only when, through his “positive” philosophy, he makes an attempt to put theism in the place of pantheism.

[188] *Hegel’s* philosophy too takes Spinozism as its foundation and expressly acknowledges it as such²⁾. But the Spinozist concept of substance, in which Hegel does not find the determination of activity, he demands be completed by the form of subjectivity, so that through this it can be torn out of its abstraction and immobility, and be conceived as *spirit* and as *freedom*, as “absolute *person*”, not merely as the absolute *object* (“die absolute Sache”).

Thus Spinoza’s influence still reaches into the system that stands as the last historically concluded one. Spinozism acts here through homogeneity, as something kindred to the ruling philosophical direction of the age, and as something thus still active it becomes the object of passionate and frequently misunderstanding polemic from the thinker who, like the whole of the most recent philosophy, acknowledges Kant, though only not the idealistic centre of his philosophy, as the point of departure of his thinking, — from *Herbart*¹⁾.

Through this influence on the philosophy of our time the significance is also justified that has been ascribed in this work to Spinoza as representative of the starting point of modern idealism. Spinoza and Hegel mark the two end points; Hegel’s philosophy has been possible only through Spinoza; the deeper motives of Spinoza’s philosophy are first understood fully through Hegel.

¹⁾*Schelling*: philos. Schriften I, p. 417 ff.

²⁾With regard to Hegel’s relation to Spinoza, cf. *Hegels sämmtl. Werke*. Bd. I, p. 60–79. III, 117 f. 178. 396 ff. 466. IV, 194 f. V, 9 ff. VI, Preface S. XVII. p. 301. 303. 310 f. 313. 391. 403. XII, 442–449. XV, 336 ff. 341 ff. 359. 362 f. 365 ff. XVII, 7 ff.

¹⁾Cf. e.g. *Herbart*: Allgemeine Metaphysik, I, p. 128–190 and many places in the second part. Analytische Behandlung des Naturrechts und der Moral p. 32–43. p. 242 and elsewhere.